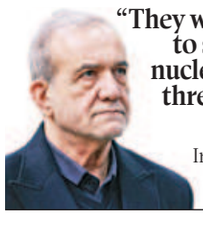
DHAKA THURSDAY NOVEMBER 12, 2026



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Lured to Teknaf only to be sold, held for ransom

Trafficking survivors narrate how recruitment, abduction and extortion networks operate in Cox's Bazar

MOHAMMAD JAMIL KHAN *and* **MOKAMMEL SHUVO,** *from Teknaf*

On November 3, eight construction workers left Cox's Bazar town for Teknaf, the district's border upazila, after a man offered them jobs.

The man, identified with a single name, Sohel, arranged two CNG-run autorickshaws for the journey. They were taken to a house near Baharchhara and told work would begin the next day.

Later, armed men moved them to a tin-roofed house beside a betel nut plantation, blindfolded them, tied ropes around their waists, and marched them into the hills, one worker told The Daily Star, requesting anonymity for fear of reprisals.

The captors took the workers' phones and cash and beat those who protested, the worker said, adding that some armed guards looked just 12 or 13. Police case documents list a 15-year-old among the accused.

The worker said their captors told them Sohel had sold each of them for Tk 20,000. The armed men gave them two options: pay Tk 3.5 lakh per person for an illegal sea journey to Malaysia, or Tk 4 lakh to return home.

"We went there for work. We never wanted to go to Malaysia," he said.

The worker was among 56 people rescued on November 5 when a joint force of army, Border Guard Bangladesh and police raided the Nuralipara hills, about three kilometres west of the West Leda Rohingya camp in Teknaf's Hnila union.

Army soldier Titas Sheikh died after being shot when armed suspects opened fire.

Interviews with victims, community sources, and officials over the past two days, along with police records, point to a loose chain of recruiters, transporters, armed guards, and boat operators exploiting Rohingya seeking passage to Malaysia and Bangladeshis lured by jobs or abducted for ransom.

Victims faced ransom demands of up to Tk 4 lakh

56 people rescued from Teknaf hills on November 5

Trafficking routes stretch from Teknaf to Malaysia

462 trafficking cases filed in Cox's Bazar since 2012



The accounts do not establish a single command structure.

According to law enforcement records, 3,534 people, most of them Rohingya, were rescued while attempting to travel to Malaysia through the Cox's Bazar coast between 2016 and 2025.

SEE PAGE 2 COL 4



Chakratinath Government Primary School in Bogura's Sariakandi has been relocated six times in three villages over the past decade due to erosion by the Jamuna. On May 11, the school was forced to move to a tin-roofed structure on an embankment. A storm on Tuesday night blew away nearly half of the structure's roof. The photo taken yesterday shows some of the students in class.

PHOTO: COURTESY OF SCHOOLTEACHERS



PM, Chinese VP discuss climate cooperation at the COP31

UNB, *Dhaka*

Prime Minister Tarique Rahman and Chinese Vice-President Han Zheng discussed expanding Chinese investment in Bangladesh and strengthening climate cooperation during a bilateral meeting in Antalya, Türkiye, yesterday.

The meeting, held at 4:30pm local time on the sidelines of the 31st UN Climate Change Conference

SEE PAGE 2 COL 4

PHOTO ON PAGE 2

QAWMI MADRASAS

Children exposed to abuse amid lack of safeguards

25,000 Qawmi madrasas educate some 70 lakh students

No sector-wide, enforceable child-protection framework

Teacher recruitment is largely informal, with limited background checks

29 incidents of violence against women, children in madrasas recorded in October

NILIMA JAHAN

Around 25,000 Qawmi madrasas in Bangladesh are currently educating an estimated 70 lakh students, but many of these non-governmental Islamic schools do not have enforceable child protection policies or the measures needed to keep children safe.

Complaint mechanisms are inconsistent and oversight is weak in these institutions, leaving children vulnerable to abuse, especially in madrasas with dormitories.

Recent allegations of sexual abuse, physical assault and intimidation of over two dozen madrasa students in several districts have exposed how institutional failures can leave children without adequate protection or reliable channels to seek redress.

One of these incidents involved eight-year-old Abu Sufian (not his real name). After attending a Qawmi madrasa in Gazipur as a day-shift student for two years, he was enrolled in its residential section on October 7 after his parents were persuaded by a teacher.

Four days later, he returned home lethargic and feverish, struggling to swallow. His hands, throat, tongue and buttocks bore bruises.

Sufian told his mother that the teacher

SEE PAGE 2 COL 1

Madrasa teacher gets death for raping 11-yr-old

OUR CORRESPONDENT, *Netrakona*

A court in Netrokona yesterday sentenced madrasa teacher Aman Ullah Mahmudi Sagor to death for raping an 11-year-old girl and making her pregnant in Madan upazila.



His brother Mamun Mia Maimun, who was also an accused in the case, was acquitted as the allegation that he had threatened the victim's family could not be proved.

Judge Md Abdus Salam of the Women and Children Repression Prevention Tribunal in Netrokona pronounced the verdict in the presence of both accused

SEE PAGE 2 COL 4



PHOTO: AZAHAR UDDIN

Farmers harvest Aman paddy in the golden morning sunlight near Amanura in Rajshahi's Godagari upazila yesterday. As they cut the dew-covered stalks, flocks of birds swoop down to feed on fallen grains, seemingly unperturbed by the farmers working nearby.

DHAKA AIRPORT

3rd terminal deal moves closer to approval

RASHIDUL HASAN *and* **TASNEEM TAYEB**

The Civil Aviation Authority of Bangladesh (CAAB) is set to send the draft concession agreement with a Japanese consortium for operating Hazrat Shahjalal International Airport's third terminal to the civil aviation and tourism ministry for further approval.

The CAAB board cleared the draft for submission at a meeting on Tuesday, a source familiar with the development told The Daily Star yesterday.

The agreement will undergo further scrutiny, including legal and financial vetting by the relevant ministries, before being placed before the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs for final approval.

The move comes as authorities continue preparations to begin partial operations at the terminal on December 16, coinciding with Victory Day.

The initial phase will involve a limited number of flights, with operations gradually expanding as more facilities become available. Authorities are working to ensure that the infrastructure required for limited flight operations is ready by then.

The move comes as authorities continue preparations to begin partial operations at the terminal on December 16, coinciding with Victory Day.

Sources familiar with the developments said that, unlike the ceremonial inauguration in October 2023, after which the terminal remained closed to regular commercial operations,

SEE PAGE 2 COL 1

Toddler falls to death from RMCH balcony

OUR CORRESPONDENT, *Rajshahi*

A two-year-old boy died after falling from an unguarded balcony at Rajshahi Medical College Hospital yesterday afternoon.

The deceased, Abu Huraira, was the son of Hridoy Ali, a resident of Kushtia Sadar upazila.

Dr Sk Shamim Ahmed, spokesperson for the hospital, confirmed the death.

Hridoy Ali was receiving treatment for dengue, while his daughter Umme Khadija was admitted with abdominal complications.

The incident occurred at Ward 11 of the hospital.

According to Hridoy, the family had nearly exhausted its savings to cover the treatment costs and was preparing to return home.

At the time of the incident, Hridoy's wife, Selina Begum, had gone to a doctor's chamber to collect necessary documents, while his son Abu Huraira

SEE PAGE 8 COL 6



Prime Minister Tarique Rahman at a bilateral meeting with China's Vice-President Han Zheng in Türkiye's Antalya yesterday. The meeting was held at the conference venue at 4:30pm local time on the sidelines of the 31st UN Climate Change Conference (COP31). PHOTO: PMO

Bangladesh joins global rooftop solar pact

Sets target to generate 5,500MW by 2030

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

Bangladesh has endorsed the Global Rooftop Solar Declaration at the UN climate summit COP31 in Türkiye, reaffirming its target of generating 5,500 megawatts of rooftop solar power by 2030.

Achieving the target will require installing solar panels on around 8.7 lakh rooftops, Power Division Secretary Mirana Mahrukh said on Tuesday, according to a press release issued by the Global Solar Council, Solar Citizens, and Climate Parliament, the organisations backing the declaration.

Under a proposed financing split, about 80 percent of the funding would need to come from international sources, she said.

"We invite our global partners to join Bangladesh in mobilising affordable financing, advanced technologies, and investment," she added.

Kenya, Nigeria, and Vanuatu also endorsed the declaration, joining Australia, the first signatory, the release said. Thirty-four lawmakers from 21 countries and Indonesia's state-run power company PLN have also backed the initiative.

SEE PAGE 9 COL 2

Children exposed to abuse amid lack of safeguards

FROM PAGE 1

gave him a mobile phone to watch cartoons at night before sexually assaulting him for three consecutive nights. The teacher allegedly covered the CCTV camera at the dormitory with clothes.

"He did something bad," Sufian's mother quoted her son as saying.

The boy also told his mother that the teacher had threatened to kill him if he disclosed the abuse to anyone.

When his parents confronted the madrasa founder, known as "Boro Hujur", they found out that at least four other boys had allegedly been assaulted over several months. The Hujur told them that the CCTV cameras were switched off at night and requested them to remain silent to protect the institution's reputation.

Later, he allegedly helped the accused teacher flee.

Following pressure from the victims' families, police arrested "Boro Hujur" and the accused teacher.

The investigation officer, Sub-Inspector Mizanur Rahman of Gacha Police Station, said that during interrogation, the accused teacher admitted to sexually abusing at least two children at the madrasa.

Sufian's case raises a fundamental question about how children are protected in institutions where effective child protection mechanisms are absent and teacher recruitment remains largely informal.

Administrators and teachers of some of these madrasas acknowledged that their institutions lacked formal policies governing teacher recruitment and safeguarding students from sexual abuse.

Another recent case underscores the consequences of this gap. A 12-year-old student of a Qawmi madrasa gave birth after being repeatedly raped by Aman Ullah Mahmudi, a teacher at the madrasa in Netrokona. DNA tests confirmed a 99.99 percent match between the teacher and the child. Yesterday, a tribunal sentenced Mahmudi to death for raping the girl.

According to reports by The Daily Star, six madrasa teachers were arrested in several districts last month over alleged sexual assault on students.

In Tongi, a madrasa teacher was arrested over the alleged sexual abuse of a seven-year-old student, while others were arrested in Savar, Kushtia and Pabna on charges of sexual offences amid public outrage.

The Manobadhikar Sanskriti Foundation (MSF), a human rights organisation, recorded 29 incidents of violence against women and children in madrasas in October alone.

Bangladesh Peace Observatory (BPO), a UNDP-funded research facility, recorded 108 rape cases involving young boys between 2012 and 2025, with several incidents occurring inside madrasa dormitories.

Awaz.bd, an archive of anonymous childhood sexual-abuse accounts, received at least 45 submissions involving Qawmi madrasas over the last two months.

Testimonies submitted to the online platform describe recurring patterns of exploitation in residential and non-residential facilities, where madrasa teachers and senior students allegedly used gifts, money and intimidation to abuse victims.

Many of the victims remained silent because of social stigma, fear and the absence of confidential reporting channels.

A SYSTEM LACKING SAFEGUARDS

Unlike the mainstream education sector, where teacher recruitment is governed by regulatory frameworks, Qawmi madrasas largely rely on decentralised hiring.

Teachers of government primary schools are recruited through the Directorate of Primary Education (DPE), while non-government schools and colleges follow the rules set by the Non-Government Teachers' Registration and Certification Authority (NTRCA). These systems impose formal qualification requirements, structured examinations and police verification.

By contrast, recruitment at Qawmi madrasas is largely controlled by their founders, administrators or managing committees. Teachers are commonly selected through personal connections, local recommendations and verbal interviews, according to administrators and teachers of several madrasas.

Verification often amounts to the collection of a curriculum vitae, a National Identity (NID) card and, occasionally, a character certificate from a Union Parishad chairman, they said.

There is no consistently enforced, sector-wide mechanism to examine previous employment records of applicants or find out whether they have a criminal past or whether they are suitable to handle children.

The problem extends beyond recruitment.

Safeguard policies, mandatory reporting procedures and independent complaint mechanisms are largely absent in these institutions.

Qawmi madrasas remain outside direct state oversight, while mainstream educational institutions are subject to the Children Act 2013 and the National Child Policy 2011. They are also required to adhere to the landmark High Court verdict issued on May 14, 2009, which made it mandatory for all public and private workplaces and educational institutions to adopt guidelines for preventing sexual harassment and form complaint committees.

Later in January 2011, the HC declared all forms of corporal and mental punishment in educational institutions to be completely unconstitutional and illegal.

However, awareness and implementation of these requirements at Qawmi madrasas appear to be extremely limited as revealed by field visits and interviews with dozens of madrasa teachers and staffers. Allegations are handled internally, with institutional interests taking precedence over children's safety.

Field visits to several Qawmi madrasas between October 21 and November 8 revealed an institutional void: none of them had any written safeguards or child-protection policies.

This correspondent interviewed administrators and teachers from eight Qawmi madrasas in Dhaka, Narayanganj, Gazipur, Bhola, Netrokona, Kishoreganj and Dinajpur.

Administrators were largely unfamiliar with the 2009 HC directive on sexual-harassment complaint committees. Some referred to general management committees which lacked standardised investigation procedures, independent oversight and clearly defined abuse-prevention mechanisms.

Mufti Zakir Hossain, director of a Gazipur madrasa housing 70 male students, said, "We do not have any CCTV cameras in our institution. We advise our students to keep lights switched on while sleeping."

Recruitment procedures remain informal. Noman Ahmed, administrator of Kashem Ul Ulum Qawmi Madrasa in Kishoreganj, said, "When teachers are needed, we apply to our local board, and they help arrange candidates through interviews.

"However, we do not have an independent mechanism to cross-check a teacher's prior employment history or legal background across different districts," he said.

Laila Khondkar, a child-protection expert and convener of Shishurai Shob, said residential institutions have responsibilities extending beyond education and basic care.

"They must provide children with safe, confidential and independent reporting channels."

She noted that every institution needs to have clear safeguard policies, proper recruitment practices, trained staff, independent monitoring and effective accountability mechanisms.

"Prevention must come before incidents, not after them," she added.

Shaheen Anam, executive director of Manusher Jonno Foundation, argued that internal self-regulation alone is not sufficient.

"A nation cannot operate with one set of laws for general institutions while leaving others completely unregulated. The government must take strong, decisive action to bring Qawmi madrasas under a unified legal and oversight framework."

Calling for independent monitoring to protect young children who may be unable to report abuse, she said, "The government can appoint trusted men and women from the community to visit madrasas. Officials from the Department of Social Services and child welfare boards at the upazila and union levels can also play this role."

She urged the government to take concrete action through regular madrasa inspections, stronger oversight and the appointment of dedicated officials to monitor the institutions.

WHAT AUTHORITIES SAY

On July 14, Education Minister ANM Ehsanul Hoque Milon told parliament that Bangladesh has 25,000 Qawmi madrasas operating under six independent examination boards.

However, they have no unified administrative oversight.

The statutory coordinating body, Al-Haiatul Ulya Lil-Jamiatil Qawmia Bangladesh, established in 2017, banned corporal punishment in September and mandated the formation of student Surokkha Committees, warning that non-compliant institutions could face suspension of affiliation.

Musleh Uddin Raju, vice-president of the largest Qawmi board, Befaqul Madarisil Arabia Bangladesh, acknowledged that the boards are yet to have a unified digital database for teacher vetting but work is underway to develop registration software.

Regarding the HC directives, Raju, also a member of Al-Haiatul Ulya, said the coordinating body had adapted the framework in the form of Surokkha committees to make it easier for institutions to adopt.

Rahat Mannan, deputy secretary of the Technical and Madrasa Education Division, said representatives of Qawmi madrasas frequently remain absent from ministry meetings aimed at teacher training, registration and mainstream integration.

Regarding accountability and reform of madrasas, he said, "Since they have no direct institutional links with us, what can we do?... It is up to the policymakers to decide how to reform them."

Referring to the recent incidents, Religious Affairs Minister Kazi Shah Mofazzal Hossain Kaikobad described the incidents as "extremely distressing and shameful", pledging preventive measures under the prime minister's directives.

"We'll do whatever is necessary in this regard...," he told journalists on October 24 without further elaboration.

Education Minister Ehsanul Hoque Milon, State Minister for Primary and Mass Education Bobby Hajjaj and the religious affairs minister did not respond to our emails, calls, and text messages.

Lured to Teknaf

FROM PAGE 1

However, only five of the 56 rescued victims were Rohingya, according to Mohammad Kawsar Shikdar, commanding officer of 16 Armed Police Battalion.

Police records show the rescued victims came from different areas, including Teknaf, Ukhiya, Chattogram, Bandarban, and Faridpur.

Kawsar said his force monitors suspects inside the refugee camps, while incidents outside fall mainly to local police.

Md Saiful Islam, officer-in-charge of Teknaf Police Station, claimed trafficking had declined as police continued operations along Marine Drive.

Rakib Hossain, a mason from Rajakhali in Pekua, said he and fellow worker Babul accepted a better-paid job offer in Teknaf from a man he believed was named Ataullah. Rakib and Babul were earning Tk 700 each per day in Cox's Bazar.

They travelled to Teknaf five days before the joint forces operation. The pair tried to escape after realising they were being taken into the hills, armed men beat them, Rakib said. The captors demanded Tk 2 lakh for their release, claiming that they had been sold for Tk 1 lakh.

The detainees were beaten and given small portions of rice and lentils twice daily. Rakib saw 30-40 people there, with more brought in later.

HOW THE CHAIN WORKS

Two sources from Rohingya camps and one from Teknaf's host community described recruiters as "influencers" who persuade camp residents to leave for Malaysia with promises of jobs or family reunification.

The recruiters reportedly receive Tk 10,000-Tk 20,000 for each person they enlist, the sources said. Intermediaries then arrange transport and accommodation for the recruits after they leave the camps.

Women living in the camps also play a significant role in the recruitment network, persuading unmarried girls to make the journey with promises of marriage in Malaysia.

Some autorickshaw drivers receive about Tk 20,000 per trip for taking victims to isolated locations where armed accomplices take custody, the sources said.

The rescued worker said abducted people were held separately from those seeking passage voluntarily. He claimed the latter fled during the raid, leaving 56 people brought against their will. He estimated around 103 people had been held there.

The sources said Rohingya and local Bangladeshi intermediaries played different roles, with local handlers arranging transport, collecting money, and maintaining armed hideouts.

The sources also described several hideouts in the Teknaf hills where people were kept before being moved towards the coast.

Of the 56 rescued, only five were Rohingya, according to the commanding officer of 16 Armed Police Battalion.

Police records show the victims came from different areas, including Teknaf, Ukhiya, Chattogram, Bandarban and Faridpur.

Sajid Ahmed, president of the Kayukkhali Trawler Owners' Association, said traffickers use sampans to ferry people from coastal points such as Shamlapur to larger vessels offshore.

Large trawlers from Chattogram and Cox's Bazar take them onward, with transfers around 2:00am or 3:00am. Passengers are kept in houses or hills until boats are ready, he said.

The Rohingya sources described routes through Myanmar's Rakhine State, including Sittwe, and direct sea journeys towards Thailand. They alleged that armed groups, including the Arakan Army, take part in some transfers inside Myanmar, a claim The Daily Star could not independently verify.

From Sittwe, people are reportedly moved towards the Thai border by land or sea. The sea journey takes three to four days, while the overland route can take around two weeks, the sources said.

People seeking passage are charged Tk 3 lakh to Tk 4 lakh each, with around Tk 1 lakh collected before they leave Teknaf and the rest demanded near the Thailand-Malaysia border.

Families are allegedly asked to send money through intermediaries, including mobile financial services, before relatives are handed over. For abducted workers, the routes become a means of extortion. Some face fresh demands even after earlier payments.

RESPONSE

Police data show that 462 human trafficking cases were filed in Cox's Bazar district between 2012 and August 2025.

According to case documents, the November 5 raid followed intelligence reports that around 100 people were being held captive in the hills. Officers recovered cooking utensils, phones, passports and identity documents.

Three cases involving murder, arms and trafficking were filed on November 9.

The murder case names 27 people and another 16-17 unidentified suspects. It alleges that Khairul Amin alias Sana Ullah or Sanaiya fired the shot that killed Titas.

The trafficking case names 41 people and 20-25 unidentified suspects.

Six suspects had been arrested by November 10, including Md Hossain alias Bokkainya, 20, in connection with the case, according to the SRB-15.

On October 8, Home Minister Salahuddin Ahmed announced a decision to establish two army camps at Rangikhali and Noakhali Pahar in Cox's Bazar, acknowledging that abductions were regularly taking place in the areas.

BGB Teknaf Battalion (2 BGB) Commander Lt Col Mohammad Tajul Islam Chowdhury said his personnel handled border offences.

On November 7, BGB rescued nine more people at South Lombori Ghat.

PERSISTING VULNERABILITY

Khin Maung, president of the United Council of Rohingya, said uncertainty over repatriation and lack of jobs made camp residents vulnerable to traffickers.

He said some unemployed young Rohingya had joined criminal networks for money. He called for better protection, livelihood opportunities and a clear repatriation roadmap.

According to UNHCR, more than 6,500 Rohingya attempted sea crossings in 2025, with nearly 900 dying or going missing in the Bay and Andaman Sea.

The Anti-Trafficking Working Group, co-chaired by UNHCR and IOM, identified 407 trafficking incidents involving Rohingya refugees in Bangladesh in 2025, up from 316 in 2024.

Host-community members recruited victims in 30 percent of cases, while 40 percent were recruited by people they knew, including neighbours, acquaintances and family members.

PM, Chinese VP

FROM PAGE 1

(COP31), focused on various issues of mutual interest, particularly Chinese investment and cooperation to address the impacts of climate change.

State Minister for Foreign Affairs Humaiun Kobir was present at the meeting.

Earlier, Tarique held a bilateral meeting with Uzbek President Shavkat Mirziyoyev at the conference venue, discussing ways to strengthen relations between Bangladesh and Uzbekistan, address climate change impacts and expand cooperation.

The meeting began at 2:45pm local time and lasted around half an hour, said PM's Deputy Press Secretary Hasan Shiplu.

Foreign Minister Dr Khalilur Rahman and Humaiun Kobir attended the meeting.

Later, at 4:50pm, the prime minister visited the Bangladesh Pavilion at COP31, where he toured an exhibition of environment-friendly jute products and displays showcasing Bangladesh's environmental initiatives.

Environment, Forest and Climate Change Minister Abdul Awal Mintoo, State Minister Shaikh Faridul Islam and Prime Minister's Special Assistant for Environment, Forest and Climate Change Dr Saimum Parvez welcomed him.

Tarique viewed displays on tree plantation, environmental conservation and measures to address climate change. He also spoke with officials and staff about the pavilion's activities, exhibits and efforts to present Bangladesh's climate initiatives to the international community.

Earlier in the day, the prime minister joined the World Leaders' Summit at the Antalya Exhibition Centre.

He arrived at the conference venue at 10:10am local time and was welcomed by the organisers, said Shiplu.

Accompanied by his wife, Dr Zubaida Rahman, Tarique exchanged greetings and held brief informal conversations with heads of state and government and senior representatives of international organisations at the Leaders' Lounge before the opening ceremony.

Among them were Organisation of Islamic Cooperation (OIC) Secretary-General Ismail Ould Cheikh Ahmed, London Mayor Sadiq Khan, Moldovan Prime Minister Vasile Tofan, Pakistani President Asif Ali Zardari, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, Syrian President Ahmed al-Sharaa, Syrian Foreign Minister Asaad al-Shaibani and Kuwaiti Prime Minister Sheikh Ahmad Abdullah Al-Ahmad Al-Sabah.

He also exchanged greetings with members of the Indonesian delegation.

The prime minister, who arrived in Antalya on Tuesday on a three-day visit, is leading a high-level Bangladesh delegation to COP31.

3rd terminal deal

FROM PAGE 1

the latest plan envisages actual flight operations from December 16.

The proposed agreement had earlier faced disagreements over four contractual provisions concerning ground-handling responsibilities, revenue sharing, legal protections and liability for construction defects.

Another contentious provision was a proposed 15-year restriction on competing civilian airports commencing commercial operations within a 100-kilometre radius of the airport. The restriction concerns commercial operations, not construction.

However, Civil Aviation and Tourism Minister M Rashiduzzaman Millat said on November 4 that the restriction would not prevent the government from planning or constructing another airport within the specified area.

He clarified that building a new airport could itself take around 10 years and that the government had no immediate plans for one within 100 kilometres of Dhaka.

The precise conditions governing the launch of operations at a future competing airport will depend on the final agreement.

The third terminal, built at a cost of around Tk 22,213 crore, is expected to substantially increase passenger-handling capacity at the country's busiest airport once fully operational.

CAAB is also seeking to make greater use of existing international airports outside Dhaka, particularly Shah Amanat International Airport in Chattogram and Osmani International Airport in Sylhet.

Efforts are also under way to develop international operations at Cox's Bazar airport as part of a broader push to strengthen regional aviation connectivity.

Madrasa teacher

FROM PAGE 1

after examining witness testimonies, DNA test reports and other scientific evidence.

The court also fined the convict Tk 1 lakh and directed that the child born as a result of the rape be recognised as Sagor's child and registered accordingly, said Nurul Kabir Rubel, public prosecutor of the tribunal.

It also observed that the state would bear all expenses related to the child's upbringing and welfare, with the government entitled to recover the expenses from the convict.

The girl was a student at the female Qawmi madrasa that Sagor founded and taught, according to the court and the case statement.

After her parents separated, the girl lived with her maternal grandfather and attended the madrasa, situated in the Panchhar Borobari area of Kaitail union in Madan upazila.

Her mother worked as a domestic help in Sylhet to support the family.

Sagor repeatedly raped the girl, and at one stage, she became pregnant.

The incident came to light on April 18, when the girl underwent a medical examination at a clinic in Madan municipality. A doctor informed her family that she was seven months pregnant.

On April 23, the girl's mother filed a case against Sagor and his brother Maimun with Madan Police Station under the Women and Children Repression Prevention Act.

After the case was filed, the prime accused went into hiding. Members of Rapid Action Battalion-14 later arrested Sagor in Mymensingh's Gauripur upazila on May 6. Police subsequently handed him over to Madan Police Station.

On May 10, the investigating officer sought the court's permission to conduct a DNA test on the prime accused. The court approved the application.

Meanwhile, following an application by the girl's mother, the court on May 12 ordered that she be moved to a safe shelter in Sylhet run by the Department of Social Services, citing concerns for her safety and protection.

As per the court's order, Sagor was taken to the Criminal Investigation Department (CID) headquarters in Dhaka on May 16. His DNA sample was collected the following day.

While staying at the safe shelter in Sylhet, the victim gave birth to a girl at a local hospital on July 2.

To establish the newborn's paternity, the investigation officer filed an application with the court on July 9 seeking a DNA test.

CID officials collected the newborn's DNA sample on July 28 and compared it with the sample previously collected from Sagor.

The CID test found a 99.99 percent match between the DNA samples of Sagor and the newborn.

After receiving the DNA test report, investigation officer Md Akhtaruzzaman of Madan Police Station submitted the charge sheet to the court on August 27, naming both Sagor and his brother as accused.

During the trial, the court recorded the testimonies of 10 witnesses.

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4 officials off to Netherlands for dog selection, evaluation

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

Four officials from the home ministry and police are scheduled to visit the Netherlands from November 15 to 19 to attend a five-day programme on dog selection and evaluation.

According to an order issued by the home ministry on Tuesday, the officials are Mirza Mohammad Ali Reza, joint secretary at the ministry; Md Bashir Ahmed, additional deputy inspector general of police at the 13 Armed Police Battalion in Uttara; Md Shamim Hossain, deputy commissioner of the Special Response Unit of Chattogram Metropolitan Police; and Md Gias Uddin Ibne Rahman, veterinary officer at Dhaka Metropolitan Police.

The visit may also take place over five days from the nearest possible date, excluding travel and transit time, the order said.

SEE PAGE 9 COL 4



Just days after an eviction drive cleared footpaths in the capital's New Market area, traders have occupied them again, forcing pedestrians onto the road and worsening traffic congestion. This photo, taken yesterday, shows pedestrians, rickshaws and other vehicles jostling for space as roadside stalls crowd the footpaths.

PHOTO: MEHEDI HASAN

FROM JS GALLERY

316 killed in armed attacks in CHT in five years

Says home minister

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

At least 316 people, including civilians and security personnel, were killed and 490 injured in attacks by armed groups in the Chittagong Hill Tracts (CHT) over the past five years, Home Minister Salahuddin Ahmed told parliament yesterday.

Of those killed, 308 were civilians and eight were security personnel, while the injured included 435 civilians and 55 security personnel, he said in response to a query from BNP lawmaker SA Jinnah Kabir.

The minister said armed groups carried out 194 attacks on the Bangalee community, 81 on ethnic minority communities and 97 on law enforcers and Bangladesh Army personnel in Rangamati, Khagrachhari and Bandarban during the period.

Government records also showed 197 abductions, 471 incidents of extortion and 377 incidents involving illegal firearms.

Salahuddin said the government had taken legal, administrative and security measures to maintain law and order in the three hill districts.

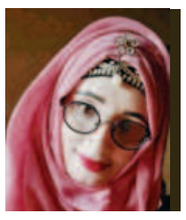
SEE PAGE 9 COL 5

Family outing ends in tragedy

Parents, eight-year-old son killed in Gazipur crash



ASHRAFUL



SHIMU



ARAFAT

OUR CORRESPONDENT, *Gazipur*

Eight-year-old Arafat Hossain was excited as he set off on a motorcycle trip with his parents yesterday, looking forward to spending some time together.

But the family outing ended in tragedy when all three were killed in a road accident on the Shafipur flyover of the Dhaka-Tangail highway in Kaliakair, Gazipur.

The deceased were Mamun Hossain Ashraful, 30, of Dewaliabari area in Gazipur city; his wife Shimu Akhter, 30; and their son Arafat Hossain, 8.

Police said the accident occurred around 2:30pm on the Konabari-to-Chandra-bound lane of the flyover.

Mamun lost control of his motorcycle, causing all three to fall onto the road. An unidentified vehicle then ran them over, killing them on the spot.

Manzur Morshed, officer-in-charge of Naojor Highway Police Station, said police recovered the bodies and later

SEE PAGE 9 COL 5

Primary education set for more hands-on learning

Over 420 educational games designed for pupils in 2028 curriculum

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

More than 420 educational games have been designed for primary schoolchildren as the government prepares to introduce toys and hands-on learning activities under a revised curriculum planned for 2028.

Developed by the National Academy for Primary Education (NAPE) for classes I to V, the games are linked to classroom lessons. Authorities are also working to integrate science, technology, engineering, arts and mathematics (STEAM) into primary education.

State Minister for Primary and Mass Education Bobby Hajjaj disclosed the plans at a discussion on STEM education at Bangladesh Parjatan Corporation Bhaban in Agargaon yesterday, jointly organised by the Campaign for Popular Education (CAMPE) and NETZ Bangladesh.

"NAPE has already designed more than 420 games," Bobby said, adding that activities had been developed for each class to make learning enjoyable.

"Toys could help class I pupils learn addition and subtraction and class III pupils understand perimeter and area," he said. "We want to see the reformed curriculum in 2028. We are trying, but it is a major task."

- Toys, workbooks, videos to support classroom learning
- Govt exploring rooftop playgrounds for schools
- 36,500 primary schools lack headteachers
- Basic teacher training to increase to 12 months

Besides textbooks, the proposed learning materials would include workbooks, video lessons, games and toys. The government is also exploring rooftop playgrounds for schools with limited land.

"Keeping children's natural curiosity alive is extremely important."

He said around 36,500 primary schools lacked headteachers, but legal disputes delaying appointments had ended, and the Directorate of Primary Education (DPE) was taking steps to fill the vacancies.

Nearly 12,000 newly recruited teachers have joined, while basic teacher training is being extended from 10 to 12 months. Teachers also have 37 additional responsibilities beyond classroom teaching, he said.

Presenting study findings, Skills Inspire lead consultant Ataul Gani Osmani proposed setting up low-cost STEM corners with reusable materials costing Tk 10,000 per school. He suggested testing the approach in 300 to 500 schools before revising the curriculum.

DPE Director General Shahina Ferdousi said teacher training and mentoring were being strengthened but cautioned against drawing broad

SEE PAGE 9 COL 5

Heated exchanges in JS over fertiliser dealerships

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

Heated exchanges erupted in parliament yesterday after National Citizen Party lawmaker Hasnat Abdullah alleged irregularities in the appointment of fertiliser dealers, accusing ruling party MPs of securing dealerships for relatives through political influence and financial dealings.

When will this culture end in our country that whenever I become an MP, my son becomes a businessman, my wife becomes a businesswoman and my nephew becomes a businessman? I want a clear answer from the honourable minister.

HASNAT ABDULLAH, NCP lawmaker

The confrontation began during the question-answer session as Agriculture Minister Mohammed Aminur Rashid responded to the allegations, repeatedly facing interruptions from opposition lawmakers.

Citing media reports, Hasnat alleged that 28

SEE PAGE 9 COL 1

RMG unrest continues in Savar, Ashulia

50 factories remain shut

OUR CORRESPONDENT, *Savar*

Garment workers clashed with police in Savar and Ashulia again yesterday morning, forcing at least 50 factories to suspend operations for the day.

Police fired tear gas shells and sound grenades to disperse the protesting workers as clashes broke out in Jamgora of Ashulia around 8:30am and Hemayetpur of Savar around 9:00am.

Police and witnesses said workers from several factories in Jamgora, Nischintapur, Narsinghpur and Zirabo tried to take to the streets, leading to chases and counter-chases with law enforcers.

In Hemayetpur, workers from factories near Padmar Mor tried to block the Hemayetpur-Singair road and hurled brickbats at police, prompting them to fire tear gas shells and sound grenades.

Dhaka Additional Superintendent of Police (Crime, Operations and Traffic-North) Md Jahangir Alam alleged that outsiders were trying to create unrest despite the formation of a wage board.

"At one point, outsiders tried to create unrest at one or two garment factories in Hemayetpur. We have no information about whether they were actually workers. However, we dispersed them quite easily. The situation is now normal," he said.

Mohammad Mominul Islam Bhuiyan, superintendent of Ashulia Industrial Police-1, said the situation had returned to normal by noon following the morning clashes.

He confirmed that around 50 factories across Savar and Ashulia remained closed for the day.



Rejecting allegations of third-party involvement, Khairul Mamun Mintu, legal affairs secretary of the Bangladesh Garments and Sweaters Workers Trade Union Centre, questioned how outsiders could enter the industrial areas amid heavy security.

SEE PAGE 9 COL 4



A city corporation worker uses a fogger to spray insecticide around the Dhaka University campus yesterday as part of government efforts to curb dengue and other mosquito-borne diseases.

PHOTO: MEHEDI HASAN

Swechchhasebak Dal leader held over extortion allegations

COURT CORRESPONDENT

Liton Mahmud Babu, vice-president of the Dhaka North city unit of Swechchhasebak Dal, was arrested in the capital's Mohammadpur yesterday over allegations of extortion, according to the Detective Branch.

Shafiqul Islam, additional commissioner (DB) of Dhaka Metropolitan Police, said Liton was on a list of alleged extortionists and was arrested following specific allegations against him.

However, the DB produced Liton, 48, and his two associates, Kamrul Hasan Almas, 50, and Mohammad Momin, 27, before the Chief Metropolitan Magistrate's Court of Dhaka in a case that carries no extortion charge.

Dhaka Metropolitan Magistrate Md Ashraful Haque sent the three to jail, said a police officer.

On November 7, Rimon Mia, 22, a driver of AJR Parcel and Courier Service in Hazaribagh, filed the case with Mohammadpur Police Station against 24 to 26 unidentified people under Sections 143, 341, 323 and 427 of the Penal Code and Sections 3, 4, 5 and 6 of the Explosive Substances Act. None of these sections concern extortion, criminal lawyers said.

According to a forwarding report submitted to the court, a gang led by individuals named Saifur and Jewel had long been involved in criminal activities at AJR Parcel and Courier Service. On November 5, a vehicle carrying parcels and postal documents left AJR's Motijheel branch for delivery.

Around 1:30am, 24 to 26 unidentified attackers on 12 to 13 motorcycles intercepted it near Krishi Market in Rayer Bazar and smashed its windows with bricks, iron rods and stones.

"Rimon got out of the vehicle, but the attackers grabbed him by the collar and struck him below the knee with a rod, injuring his leg. He somehow managed to escape," DB Inspector Bahalul Khan, the investigation officer, said in the forwarding report.

The attackers allegedly hurled crude bombs and petrol bombs into the vehicle's cabin and set it ablaze, destroying goods inside, before fleeing.

Case documents showed that Liton, Almas and Momin were arrested in Mohammadpur around 5:45am yesterday.

DB officials said the government recently prepared a list of 545 alleged extortionists operating in Dhaka and handed it to the DMP with instructions to arrest them.

Liton's name was on the list, they added.

4 more die of dengue

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

At least four dengue patients died, and 1,900 others were hospitalised in the 24 hours till 8:00am yesterday, according to the Directorate General of Health Services.

All four deaths were reported from the Dhaka division.

With the latest fatalities, the death toll from dengue this year has risen to 478, while the cumulative number of cases has reached 1,55,668. Currently, 6,067 dengue patients are undergoing treatment at hospitals across the country.

'Can't afford another loss'

Low prices push Pirojpur farmers to cut Boro cultivation

HABIBUR RAHMAN, *Pirojpur*

"Even after selling the paddy, I could not recover my production costs last year because of the low market price," said Abinash Mondal, a farmer from Dakkhin Jhanjhania village in Pirojpur's Nazirpur upazila.

He spent around Tk 36,000 cultivating Boro paddy on one bigha (52 decimals) last year and harvested 40 maunds, but still suffered losses.

"I cannot afford another loss by taking the same risk again this time," he said.

Like Abinash, many farmers across Pirojpur's wetlands are planning to reduce Boro cultivation this season, discouraged by low paddy prices and rising production costs.

Pradip Mondal of the same village has decided to cut his Boro acreage from eight bighas last year to five this season.

Abdus Salam, who cultivated 4.5 bighas last year, plans to reduce his acreage by 1.5 bighas.

Farmers said they previously sold paddy for more than Tk 1,100 per maund. They now need Tk 1,200-1,300 to make a profit, but received a maximum of Tk 850 last year.

"Last year, I got around Tk 800 for a maund (40kg) of paddy, which caused losses. Rising fuel and pesticide prices will increase production costs further this year," Salam said, adding that timely access to fertiliser remained uncertain.

Farmers also questioned why wholesale buyers were reluctant to purchase paddy despite high rice prices.



Farmers prepare paddy seedbeds ahead of Boro season in Nazirpur upazila of Pirojpur. The photo was taken recently. PHOTO: HABIBUR RAHMAN

Harvesting costs have added to their difficulties, with labourers charging around Tk 1,200 each.

The situation is particularly concerning in Nazirpur and other wetland areas, where Boro is the only annual crop and accounts for the largest share of the district's paddy production.

Farmers have begun preparing seedbeds, with transplantation expected to start in December.

Esratunnesa Easha, agriculture officer of Nazirpur upazila, acknowledged that farmers had not received expected prices last year, which could affect cultivation this season.

She said the department provided technical support but was not responsible for determining market prices.

Boro was cultivated on 12,600 hectares in Nazirpur last year, while this season's target is 12,500 hectares, she said.

According to the Department of Agricultural Extension (DAE) in Pirojpur, Boro cultivation covered 34,005 hectares across the district last year, against a target of 34,020 hectares this season.

CU admission tests begin January 29

Online applications from Dec 10 to Jan 10

CU CORRESPONDENT

The first-year admission tests of Chittagong University (CU) for the 2026-27 academic session will be held from January 29 to February 8 under the revised schedule.

CU Pro-Vice-Chancellor (Academic) Professor Dr Mohammad Al-Amin confirmed the decision yesterday.

Students who will pass the Higher Secondary Certificate supplementary examinations will be eligible to apply, provided they meet the required GPA criteria.

The application schedule has been revised to allow supplementary candidates to apply. Online applications will be accepted from December 10 to January 10, while the fees can be paid until January 12. The previous application timeline was November 15 to December 10.

PRAYER TIMING
NOVEMBER 12

	Fazr	Zohr	Asr	Maghrib	Esha
AZAN	5-00	12-45	3-45	5-22	7-00
JAMAAT	5-35	1-15	4-00	5-25	7-30

SOURCE: ISLAMIC FOUNDATION

DU suspends two staff over role in campus blasts

DU CORRESPONDENT

Dhaka University (DU) administration has suspended two officials over preliminary evidence of their involvement in the crude bomb blasts and attempts to create instability on the campus.

The suspended officials are Nipu Islam Tanni, a section officer at the Education-1 branch of the university's Registrar Office, and Mohammad Aman Ullah, a sanitary supervisor at its Estate Office.

The university has also filed a case with Shahbagh Police Station over the crude bomb blast on the premises of the Faculty of Business Studies on Tuesday, said a press release of DU Public Relations Office yesterday.

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1. Computer Stitching Technician (Sports Shoes Dept.) : Min. 5 years experienced. Must have good & practical knowledge on computer sewing machine maintenance, routing inspection, preventive maintenance, minimize breakdown in production, lead team and keep all types of required & relevant docs. to meet compliance requirements. Minimum S.S.C or equivalent Degree is required. Age: 32 years or above. In case of really deserving candidates, educational qualification may be relaxed. In case of unavailability of local candidate, foreign applicants may be considered in recruitment & selection process. Applicants are advised to apply with CV along with 2 recent PP sized photographs within 15 days of publication of this advertisement **to GM – HR, Admin & Compliance, maf Shoes Limited, Outer Signal, Chandgaon I/A, Chittagong, Bangladesh or career@mafshoes.com**

AHSANULLAH UNIVERSITY OF SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY
141-142 Love Road, Tejgaon Industrial Area, Dhaka-1208.
Phone: 02 8870422 (Ext.-201) Web: www.aust.edu
Ref. No: AUST/UE Office/Tender-06/2026-27

TENDER INVITATION

Sealed Tender is hereby invited from the reputed building construction companies/farm for:

(1) Civil works for the installation of an additional Lift in Block- D

The tender documents will be available for purchase from the Procurement Office, AUST during office hour 10 AM to 5 PM at a cost of Tk. 5,000.00 (Five thousand) (non-refundable) only in pay order in favor of "AHSANULLAH UNIVERSITY OF SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY".

The tender will be received in the same office and will be opened on the last date of submission of tender in presence of the Bidders or their representative (if any).

The tender must be accompanied by a Bank Draft / Pay order of Tk. 2,00,000/- (Two Lakh) only with offer from any schedule bank of Bangladesh in favor of "AHSANULLAH UNIVERSITY OF SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY" as bid security money without which the tender shall be out right rejected. Noted that the pay order shall be released to the bidders after issuance of the respective work order.

The AUST authority reserves the right to reject or accept any or all tenders without assigning the reason what-so-ever and is not bound to award the work to the lowest bidder.

Last date of selling Tender Document: Nov. 23, 2026 up to 3-00 PM
Prebid Meeting: Nov. 26, 2026 (Thursday) at 2-00 PM at VC Seminar Room (Lift-3, Blk-D)
Dead Line of Submission Tender: Nov. 30, 2026 (Monday) at 2-00 pm and Tender will be opened at 02-30 pm on the same day (Nov. 30, 2026)

INNOVATION:: CREATION:: LEADERSHIP

e-Zone Servicing Change Managers

VACANCY ANNOUNCEMENT

The Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS) under the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW), with financial support from the Global Fund to Fight AIDS, Tuberculosis and Malaria (GFATM), is implementing the National Tuberculosis Programme (NTP), National AIDS/STD Control (NASC) Programme, National Malaria Elimination Programme (NMEP), and Resilient and Sustainable Systems for Health (RSSH) interventions in Bangladesh.

To enhance coordination, operational efficiency, and standardized governance, an integrated Program Management Unit (PMU) has been established for all Global Fund-supported grants. Recruitment is underway for the following positions, with assignments scheduled to commence in January 2027.

E-Zone HRM Limited has a formal agreement with one of the UN Agencies to provide outsourcing support to accomplish this recruitment. E-Zone HRM Limited is now accepting applications from the Bangladeshi nationals. See the link for detailed ToR and other relevant information.

- **Title 1: Team Lead** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un331.html
- **Title 2: Deputy Team Lead, Program** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un332.html
- **Title 3. Deputy Team Lead, Operations** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un333.html
- **Title 4. Internal Audit and Compliance Manager** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un334.html
- **Title 5. Finance Manager** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un335.html
- **Title 6. Procurement, Supply Chain, and Logistics Manager** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un337.html
- **Title 7. Lab Management Expert** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un338.html
- **Title 8. HIV/AIDS Expert** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un339.html
- **Title 9. Malaria Expert** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un340.html
- **Title 10. TB Expert** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un341.html
- **Title 11. Monitoring, Evaluation, Research, and Learning (MERL) Expert** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un342.html
- **Title 12. Programme Operations Specialist** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un336.html
- **Title 13. Transition and Integration Specialist** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un343.html
- **Title 14. Lab Specialist** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un344.html
- **Title 15. HIV Specialist - Treatment and Care** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un345.html
- **Title 16.HIV Specialist - Prevention** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un346.html
- **Title 17. Malaria Specialist - Entomologist** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un347.html
- **Title 18. DR-TB and TPT Specialist** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un348.html
- **Title 19. Community Intervention Specialist** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un349.html
- **Title 20. Public-Private Mix (PPM) Specialist** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un350.html
- **Title 21. Child TB, IPC and TB Vaccination Specialist** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un378.html
- **Title 22. Human Rights and Ethics Specialist** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un351.html
- **Title 23. Data Management and Software Specialist** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un352.html
- **Title 24. Finance Specialist (Planning and Reporting)** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un353.html
- **Title 25. Finance Specialist (Operations)** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un354.html
- **Title 26. Finance Officer (Planning and Reporting)** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un357.html
- **Title 27. Finance Officer (Operations)** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un358.html
- **Title 28. Bio-Medical Engineer** — Number of Position(s): 03 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un355.html
- **Title 29. Communication and Knowledge Management Officer** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un356.html
- **Title 30. Admin Officer** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un359.html
- **Title 31. Procurement Officer** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un360.html
- **Title 32. Logistics Management Officer** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un361.html
- **Title 33. Supply Chain and Logistics Officer** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un362.html
- **Title 34. Internal Audit and Compliance Officer** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un363.html
- **Title 35. Coordination Officer (Prison Interventions - TB/HIV)** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un364.html
- **Title 36. Human Resources Management (HRM) Officer** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un365.html
- **Title 37. IT Officer** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un366.html
- **Title 38. MIS Officer** — Number of Position(s): 03 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un367.html
- **Title 39. Monitoring Evaluation and Reporting Officer** — Number of Position(s): 03 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un368.html
- **Title 40. Technician-Entomological** — Number of Position(s): 02 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un369.html
- **Title 41. Finance Associate (Planning and Reporting)** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un370.html
- **Title 42. Finance Associate (Operations)** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un371.html
- **Title 43. Finance Associate (Treasury)** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un377.html
- **Title 44. Procurement Associate** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un372.html
- **Title 45. Supply Chain and Logistics Associate** — Number of Position(s): 03 — Duty Station: Dhaka, Bangladesh — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un374.html
- **Title 46. IT Logistics Associate** — Number of Position(s): 01 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un373.html
- **Title 47. Driver** — Number of Position(s): 04 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un375.html
- **Title 48. Support Staff** — Number of Position(s): 08 — Duty Station: Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), Dhaka — https://hotjobs1.bdjobs.com/e-zone-hrm-limited/un376.html

Duration and Starting Date: The assignment is scheduled to begin on 1 January 2027 for an initial duration of one (1) year. Continuation or renewal is subject to a formal satisfactory performance evaluation, operational requirements, and the continued availability of funding from the donor.

All these positions are open for Bangladeshi Nationals only. All candidates, irrespective of gender, religious and ethnic backgrounds can apply for the vacancies. Female candidates are highly encouraged to apply.

Only short-listed candidates shall be invited for written test/interview. All selected candidates will undergo rigorous reference and background checks.

Last Date of Application: 20 November 2026 (23:59 PM)

Israeli fire kills seven in Gaza

Father, son among dead

REUTERS, *Cairo*

Israeli forces killed at least seven Palestinians, including a father and his 13-year-old son, in the Gaza Strip on Tuesday evening, health officials said.

Medics said Fadi Rajab and his son Abubakr were killed in an airstrike that hit the roof of a displacement shelter in the Zeitoun neighbourhood in Gaza City. A third Palestinian was killed in an Israeli airstrike near a school in Gaza City's Daraj neighbourhood, health officials added.

The Israeli military said "it struck militants" in both areas, without giving further details. In Khan Younis, in southern Gaza, Israeli gunfire killed a man, medics said.

Later on Tuesday, an Israeli airstrike hit a metal foundry in the Sabra neighbourhood of Gaza City, killing three people, medics said, taking the day's death toll to seven.



Australia's Prime Minister Anthony Albanese, UNFCCC Executive Secretary Simon Stiell, UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres, Turkish President Tayyip Erdogan, Azerbaijani President Ilham Aliyev, Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, Uzbekistan's President Shavkat Mirziyoyev and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian pose for a family photo with other leaders during the UN Climate Change Conference (COP31) in Antalya, Turkey, yesterday. PHOTO: REUTERS

ALLEGED RUSSIA LINK

UK arrests senior US army member

Washington charges 3 'Iranian operatives' over UK airbase plot

AFP, *London*

A member of the US military was arrested in Britain on Tuesday on suspicion of spying for Russia, London police said.

"The 41-year-old man was arrested near Gloucester on Tuesday," London Metropolitan police said in a statement, adding that "The country to which the allegations relate is Russia." The suspect was a member of the US Army and was being held at a London jail, police said, adding that they worked closely with US authorities on the case.

"This significant arrest and investigation is a result of close collaboration between UK and US authorities," Vicki Evans, Senior National Coordinator for Counter Terrorism Policing at the Met, was quoted as saying in the statement. "The allegations are serious and our investigation is very much ongoing."

Meanwhile, the US Justice Department on Tuesday announced charges against three men it described as "Iranian operatives" over their role in an alleged terrorist plot at Britain's RAF Fairford airbase.

Mohammad Baqer Saad Dawood al-Saadi, Mohsen Mohajeri and Mohammad Ali al-Hassani were charged in relation to the September incident at the base, which has been used by the US military in its operations against Iran.



Ex-Pak PM Imran back in jail after eye check-up

REUTERS, *Islamabad*

Pakistan's former prime minister Imran Khan was taken to hospital in Islamabad late on Tuesday for medical treatment and returned to prison, sources said.

Khan, who is imprisoned in Adiala Jail in Rawalpindi, had an eye check-up at the Pakistan Institute of Medical Sciences (PIMS), one of the officials said yesterday.

"He had some blood pressure issues ... and was given required treatment last night. He has been shifted back to his prison cell," the person said.

The cricketer-turned-politician has faced multiple corruption charges since he lost power in a no-confidence vote in 2022, and has been in prison for over three years.

All of Khan's convictions bar one have been suspended or overturned, with appeals pending. He denies wrongdoing and says charges are politically motivated.

US 'luring helpless tankers into walls of fire'

Iran's IRGC claims amid Hormuz passage risks

AGENCIES

The American military is "luring helpless oil tankers into walls of fire" by saying that the Strait of Hormuz is open, Iran's state-run IRNA news agency cited the IRGC Navy commander as saying on X yesterday.

The top Iran naval commander also claimed that American forces actively avoid the strategic waterway while encouraging commercial shipping into high-risk waters.

"The humiliating, smuggling American military, which does not even dare to approach the Strait of Hormuz itself, is luring helpless oil tankers into walls of fire with the lie that the Strait of Hormuz is open," IRNA quoted the IRGC Navy Commander as saying. Three oil tankers were on fire in Hormuz on Tuesday.

Oil tanker on fire in Hormuz after hitting mine

US Treasury chief relocates to base after Iran threat

Iran's army said yesterday that an oil tanker had struck a mine and caught fire in Hormuz. Mohsen Rezaei, the Secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, earlier said Washington has not given an "acceptable response" to Tehran's conditions and that the Strait of Hormuz remains closed.

Russia and Iran have held consultations in Moscow on regional issues, with a focus on resolving conflicts in the Middle East and North Africa, the Russian foreign ministry said yesterday.

Russian Deputy Foreign Minister Georgy Borisenko has met Mehdi Shoushtari, the director general for West Asia and North Africa at Iran's Foreign Ministry, who travelled to Moscow to take part in consultations between the two foreign ministries on regional issues, reports Dawn online.

Meanwhile, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent has relocated from his home in the Washington area to a military base following an Iranian threat against his life, the New York Times reported on Tuesday.

Republicans in the US House of Representatives blocked an effort on Tuesday to impeach Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth, winning a reprieve for the polarizing Pentagon chief before Democrats take control of Congress next year and possibly try again.



Mourners attend funerals of those reportedly killed in Saudi strikes on Yemen over the weekend in Sanaa. PHOTO: AFP

Russia, Ukraine trade strikes amid peace talks

Baltic nations, Finland issue drone warnings; attack sparks fire at Russian oil port

REUTERS, *Vilnius*

Nato scrambled jets overnight after at least four drones strayed into the airspace of the Baltic states during Ukrainian strikes on Russia, officials said yesterday, triggering brief alerts to citizens of Lithuania, Latvia and Estonia to seek shelter.

Ukrainian military drones straying into the airspace of Finland and the Baltics this year have fuelled concern that the Ukraine war is spilling into Nato countries that border Russia and its ally Belarus.

There were no reports of injuries on what Lithuania's Prime Minister Mindaugas Sinkevicius called "a difficult night". One of the warnings covered Kaunas, Lithuania's second-most populous city, home to about 300,000 people.

In Ukraine, an overnight Russian air strike knocked out power in parts of the industrial city Kryvyi Rih, injured one in the second-biggest city Kharkiv and another six in Zaporizhzhia

The incidents occurred on a night that Ukrainian drones attacked Russia's northwest, home to major Baltic Sea export facilities and a big oil refinery, setting afire the Ust-Luga port area and injuring three people.

In Ukraine, an overnight Russian air strike knocked out power in parts of the industrial city Kryvyi Rih, injured one in the second-biggest city Kharkiv and another six in Zaporizhzhia, officials and emergency services said.

The turmoil comes against the backdrop of a two-day meeting between Russian and Ukrainian officials in Abu Dhabi from Tuesday, as the United States makes a new push to end their war.

Moscow has accused Kyiv of using Nato airspace as cover for attacks, while Kyiv says Russian signal jamming sometimes sends some of its drones off course. The Nato nations generally blame Russia for such incidents, for igniting the war by invading its neighbour in 2022.

Two attempts were made to shoot down a drone over Lithuania but both failed, and it later crossed into neighbouring Latvia's airspace, Lithuanian armed forces Chief of Defence Staff Giedrius Premeneckas said.

3 Indian CRPF jawans hurt as terrorists open fire in J&K

THE STATESMAN/ANN

Three Indian paramilitary personnel were injured yesterday when suspected militants opened fire at a security checkpoint in Jammu and Kashmir's Kulgam district, triggering a search operation for the attackers, local media reported.

The attackers, reportedly riding a motorcycle, targeted a Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) checkpoint in the south Kashmir district before fleeing the scene. Security forces cordoned off the area and launched a search operation, the reports said.

There was no immediate official confirmation of the identities of the attackers or the condition of the injured personnel. The attack came three days after security forces arrested two suspected militant associates in Kulgam and recovered a pistol, ammunition and two hand grenades.



Police identified the arrested men as Muneeb Yaseen Rather and Tahir Bilal, both residents of Bugam in Kulgam district.

"During search, one pistol along with a magazine and two live rounds were recovered from Muneeb Yaseen Rather, while two live hand grenades were recovered from Tahir Bilal," police said following the November 8 arrests.

There was no confirmed connection between those arrests and yesterday's attack.

Gunmen kill eight police officers in NW Pakistan

AGENCIES

Gunmen attacked a police convoy on its way to an illegal gold mining operation in Pakistan's northwestern region yesterday, killing eight officers, officials said.

A senior administrative official in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province's Kohat district told AFP eight police personnel were killed and 13 others were injured. A second security official in Peshawar confirmed the toll of eight officers killed, reports AFP.

It said that terrorists attack a police contingent in the Darbukach area, within the jurisdiction of the Gumbat police station, adding that Fitna al Khawarij were behind the attack.

Fitna al Khawarij is a term the state uses for terrorists belonging to the banned Tehreek-i-Taliban Pakistan, reports Dawn.

Police said that additional personnel had been dispatched to the area and an exchange of fire was underway.

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa Governor Faisal Karim Kundi condemned the incident and sought a detailed report, as per an official statement issued by his office.



দরপত্র বিজ্ঞপ্তি

১। প্রতিষ্ঠানের নামঃ ২ ইঞ্জিনিয়ার ব্যাটালিয়ন
২। কাজের বিবরণঃ ২০২৬-২০২৭ অর্থ বছরের বাজেট কোড - নং ১১৯০৬০১১০৪২৩৩/৩২৩১৩০১-প্রশিক্ষণ (এটিজি সাধারণ) খাত হতে সুষ্ঠু প্রশিক্ষণ নিশ্চিতকল্পে ঘাটাইল ফিল্ড ফায়ারিং রেঞ্জকে পদাতিক ফিল্ড ফায়ারিং রেঞ্জে উপযোগী করার লক্ষ্যে ৮০০ মিটার দীর্ঘ স্টপ বাট নির্মাণ, মেরামত ও প্রয়োজনীয় অন্যান্য আনসাংগিক সুবিধাদি প্রস্তুত করণ এবং এতদসংক্রান্ত বিবিধ প্রশিক্ষণ ব্যয় নির্বাহ বাবদ।
৩। দরপত্র বিক্রয়ের তারিখঃ ১৪ নভেম্বর ২০২৬।
৪। দরপত্র বিক্রয়ের শেষ তারিখঃ ২৫ নভেম্বর ২০২৬।
৫। দরপত্র খোলার তারিখঃ ২৬ নভেম্বর ২০২৬।

বিস্তারিত তথ্যের জন্য ভিজিট করুনঃ www.army.mil.bd

আইএসপিআর/সেনা/৯৪২

অধিনায়ক
২ ইঞ্জিনিয়ার ব্যাটালিয়ন

GD-2738

BANGLADESH INLAND WATER TRANSPORT CORPORATION
BIWTC
Ministry of Shipping
Fairly House
24, Kazi Nazrul Islam Avenue,
Banglamotor, Shahbag, Dhaka-1000.
Website: www.biwtc.gov.bd

e-Tender is invited in the National e-GP System Portal (http://www.eprocure.gov.bd) for the procurement of goods as follows:

Sl. No.	Tender ID No. & Reference No.	Description of Goods	Last Selling Date & time	Closing and Opening date & time
01	1332579 18.12.0000.000. 264.07.0202.26	Procurement of 04 Size MS Plate for Stock of Central Store of BIWTC.	25.11.2026 (12:00)	25.11.2026 (12:30)

This is an online Tender, where only e-Tender will be accepted in the National e-GP portal and no offline/hard copies will be accepted. To submit e-Tender, registration in the National e-GP portal (http://www.eprocure.gov.bd) is required. The fees for downloading the e-Tender Documents from the http://www.eprocure.gov.bd have to be deposited online through any Branches of registered Bank.
Further information & guidelines are available in the National e-GP system Portal and from e-GP help desk (helpdesk@eprocure.gov.bd).

২০।১১।২৬
(Mansura Ahmed)
Chief Purchase Officer
BIWTC, Dhaka.
e-mail: cpo@biwtc.gov.bd
Phone: 02-9634057

GD-2745

বি-আর পাওয়ারজেন লিঃ (বিআরপিএল)
(সরকারি বিদ্যুৎ উৎপাদনকারী প্রতিষ্ঠান)
আইইবি ভবন (৯ম তলা), ৮/এ, রমনা, ঢাকা-১০০০।

নিলাম বিজ্ঞপ্তি

১.	বিভাগ/ মন্ত্রণালয়	:	বিদ্যুৎ বিভাগ/বিদ্যুৎ, জ্বালানি ও খনিজ সম্পদ মন্ত্রণালয়।
২.	এজেন্সি	:	বি-আর পাওয়ারজেন লিঃ (বিআরপিএল)।
৩.	নিলাম দরপত্র বিজ্ঞপ্তির সূত্র নং ও তারিখ	:	BRPL/MPP/AUC-04/2026-2027, ১২/১১/২০২৬ খ্রিঃ।
৪.	নিলাম দরপত্র দলিল বিক্রয় শুরুর তারিখ ও সময়	:	১২/১১/২০২৬ খ্রিঃ, সকাল ৯:০০ ঘটিকা। (অফিস চলাকালীন)
৫.	নিলাম দরপত্র দলিল বিক্রয়ের শেষ তারিখ ও সময়	:	২৫/১১/২০২৬ খ্রিঃ, বিকাল ৪:০০ ঘটিকা।
৬.	নিলাম দরপত্র দাখিলের সময়সীমা	:	২৬/১১/২০২৬ খ্রিঃ, সকাল ৯:০০ ঘটিকা থেকে দুপুর ১২:০০ ঘটিকা (অফিস চলাকালীন)
৭.	**মালামালের সংক্ষিপ্ত বিবরণীঃ**		

ক্র.	মালামালের বিবরণ	মালামালের অবস্থান ও ঠিকানা	পরিমাণ (লিঃ)
০১	Used Lube-Oil (১ বছরের জন্য)	মিরসরাই ১৬৩ মেঃওঃ ডুয়েল ফুয়েল বিদ্যুৎ কেন্দ্র, মিরসরাই, চট্টগ্রাম।	১,৩০,০০০.০০

৮.	নিলাম দরপত্র দলিল সংগ্রহের পদ্ধতি	:	বাংলাদেশের যে কোন সিডিউল ব্যাংক হতে 'বি-আর পাওয়ারজেন লিঃ' এর অনুকূলে ২,৫০০.০০ (দুই হাজার পাঁচ শত) টাকার অফেরতযোগ্য ব্যাংক ড্রাফট/ পে-অর্ডার এবং প্রতিষ্ঠানের প্যাডে নির্বাহী পরিচালক (অর্থ ও হিসাব), বি-আর পাওয়ারজেন লিঃ এর বরাবর আবেদনপত্র জমা প্রদান করে উল্লেখিত সময়ের মধ্যে প্রধান কার্যালয় হতে দরপত্র দলিল সংগ্রহ করতে হবে।

বি.দ্রঃ বিস্তারিত তথ্যের জন্য প্রতিষ্ঠানের ওয়েবসাইটে ভিজিট করুনঃ https://brpowergen.gov.bd

GD-2743

তত্ত্বাবধায়ক প্রকৌশলী (অপারেশন ও মেইনটেন্যান্স)

সোনালী ব্যাংক পিএলসি
জেনারেল ম্যানেজার'স অফিস, রাজশাহী।
(উন্মুক্ত দরপত্র বিজ্ঞপ্তি)

কাজের নাম ঃ- সোনালী ব্যাংক পিএলসি, জেনারেল ম্যানেজার'স অফিস, রাজশাহী ও এর আওতাধীন প্রিন্সিপাল অফিস/শাখাসমূহের ব্যবহারের জন্য ৮৬ টি প্রিন্টার ও ১৭৩টি অফলাইন ইউপিএস সরবরাহ ও স্থাপন।
টেন্ডার রেফারেন্সঃ
1.SBPLC/GMO/Raj/Printer/OTM-19/2026
2.SBPLC/GMO/Raj/ Printer/OTM-20/2026
3.SBPLC/GMO/Raj/ Printer/OTM-21/2026
4.SBPLC/GMO/Raj/ Offline UPS/OTM-22/2026
5.SBPLC/GOM/Raj/ Offline UPS /OTM-23/2026
Dateঃ 10/11/2026
দরপত্র বিজ্ঞপ্তির বিস্তারিত তথ্যের জন্য সোনালী ব্যাংক পিএলসি এর নিজস্ব Website:www.sonalibank.com.bdএবংhttps://www.eprocure.gov.bd দেখুন। যোগাযোগঃ সোনালী ব্যাংক পিএলসি, জেনারেল ম্যানেজার'স অফিস, রাজশাহী। ফোনঃ+৮৮০২-৫৮৮৮৫৩৪৯০, মোবাইলঃ০১৭১৬-১৭৭৬১৯

স্বাক্ষরিত/-
জেনারেল ম্যানেজার(ইনচার্জ)

GD-2744

The Daily Star
FOUNDER EDITOR: **LATE S. M. ALI**

Fatullah madrasa fire exposes negligence

All residential educational institutions must have fire safety precautions

The fire at a residential madrasa in Fatullah, Narayanganj, on Tuesday that left 88 students hospitalised with smoke inhalation, four of them in critical condition, is a stark reminder that fire safety is never a priority in the construction and functioning of most buildings. In this case, the fire broke out around 1:45 am when the madrasa residents were sleeping.

The fire service said that an electrical short circuit in the library could have caused the fire, though further investigation is required. Whatever the source, the fact remains that neither the madrasa authorities nor the state's building authorities stepped up to install fire safety measures in a five-storied residential building where most of its 1,300 students live in the dormitories. The building had no fire extinguisher. The blaze was brought under control within half an hour using water from a water storage facility beside the building.

Such callousness points to negligence in fire safety in buildings all over the country. In many cases, structures are built without approval from the relevant authorities and continue to operate without facing any legal consequences. Yet disasters keep happening due to such negligence. In January, six people were killed in a fire that broke out at a residential building in Uttara, with many others suffering from smoke inhalation. The horrific images of the FR Tower tragedy, with people jumping off the building to their deaths and others desperately trying to climb down ledges and air conditioner shafts, shown live on TV, will continue to haunt us. That such a tall building in a busy area did not have any fire escape is unthinkable. But this is the reality. Despite years of surveys identifying buildings that violate building codes, many continue to stand and operate, while others remain entirely outside the authorities' scrutiny.

The madrasa fire should be a wake-up call for those in charge of residential buildings. In the case of residential schools and madrasas, fire safety measures must be installed without delay. This includes adequate fire exits, firefighting equipment, evacuation plans, regular fire drills by students and teachers and mandatory electrical inspections and maintenance.

The madrasa fire should be a wake-up call for those in charge of residential buildings. In the case of residential schools and madrasas, fire safety measures must be installed without delay. This includes adequate fire exits, firefighting equipment, evacuation plans, regular fire drills by students and teachers and mandatory electrical inspections and maintenance. The relevant building authorities and fire service must strengthen coordination, conduct regular inspections and take decisive action against violations before another preventable tragedy exposes the consequences of their inaction.

The Fatullah madrasa's authorities have to be held accountable for violating safety requirements. Educational institutions are responsible for the safety of the children and young people they have been entrusted with. They cannot treat fire safety as an option. We expect the government to conduct a nationwide safety audit of madrasas, schools, hostels, orphanages and other residential educational institutions, identify risks and enforce compliance with basic fire safety standards.

Stop policing cultural events

Lawmakers must uphold people's right to cultural expressions

We strongly denounce Habiganj police's action prohibiting a Baul music event from taking place on the premises of Purasunda Government Primary School in the district's Shaistaganj upazila on Monday night. Coincidentally, only a day earlier, Habiganj-3 lawmaker and parliamentary whip GK Gouse had instructed the district administration not to allow folk music events—if not in the district, then at least in his constituency. This casts doubt on the police's justification for stopping the event, which was based on locals' complaints that noise from similar programmes had disturbed their sleep and caused distress to sick people. How can the police cancel a programme even before receiving specific noise complaints about it? Did they then act at the behest of the parliamentary whip?

What's worrying is that the cancellation of music, cultural and sporting events, as well as attacks on syncretic religio-cultural traditions, is being normalised here. According to one estimate, since August 2024, at least 36 such events have either been cancelled or faced threats from right-wing religious groups. According to reports, more than 90 shrines have come under attack between August 2024 and February 2026. Police largely remained passive in these cases, neither providing extra protection or security at programme venues, nor arresting those who issued threats or vandalised event sites. Instead, in some instances, they urged the organisers to cancel events, citing security concerns. The November 3 exhibition at the Liberation War Museum is a case in point.

Surprisingly, some of our lawmakers, instead of voicing support for our diverse cultural traditions and national heritage, are enabling attempts to suppress cultural expressions through their statements and instructions. Not everyone may like folk or Baul songs and their practices, but that does not mean programmes featuring such music should be stopped entirely.

Our constitution, in fact, asks the state to ensure that measures are taken to preserve cultural heritage and expressions, that minority communities can practise their faith and tradition without fear, and that people can express their thoughts in various forms, including creative works. Why, then, are we witnessing our lawmakers, who took an oath under that very constitution, act and speak in ways that contradict it? If the BNP is true to its promise of building an inclusive society, its members should first understand its meaning and not instruct the police to cancel cultural events.

Draft cyber law revisions could still be a tool for silencing dissent



Zillur Rahman, a political analyst, is president at the Centre for Governance Studies (CGS) and founding board chair of CGS USA. He hosts 'Tritiyo Matra' on Channel i. His X handle is @zillur.

■ **ZILLUR RAHMAN**

If one intends to silence the media, there is no need to put every critical journalist or investigative reporter in jail. Just a handful of examples are enough to convey the message that uncovering crime or corruption may get a journalist harassed, arrested, dragged into expensive legal proceedings, or driven into bankruptcy. Frightened, many will stop writing critical stories or asking uncomfortable questions, leaving the powerful free from public scrutiny. Censorship is thus often established without formal bans or sweeping restrictions, but through fear and the selective punishment of a few.

Bangladesh knows this all too well. The 2024 uprising was meant to mark a departure from this authoritarian policy that, under the Sheikh Hasina regime, found its most potent expression in the cyber security law. However, attempts to amend the law in recent months have raised fresh doubt about whether the country can decisively break away from that legacy or will end up restoring the tools used to suppress dissent.

In response to consultations with civil society, the government has now reportedly made 12 revisions in the draft cyber law. The revised draft has yet to be released publicly, but from what has been reported, we must admit that some of the changes seem quite positive. Rumour will no longer mean just any unverified information; it should be proven false to qualify as a rumour. Defamation penalties will align with those in the Penal Code of 1860. Journalists and media outlet owners will be granted certain guarantees against being arrested, and provisions allowing the use of mobile courts to investigate certain cybercrimes will be excluded.

However, these concessions still fail to address the basic concerns. The revisions disclosed by officials don't seem to show the government's willingness to give up control over speech. The most alarming of them is that the proposed punishment for spreading rumours stays the same: up to 10 years in prison and/or a fine of up to Tk 40 lakh. Even with the narrowed definition, such severe punishment creates a major risk as the authorities decide what counts as false information.

Journalistic practice often involves dealing with allegations that governments deny. Information on corruption, electoral irregularities, and deaths in custody often emerge through unofficial channels because official institutions are historically secretive and lack transparency. Who decides whether a piece of information is actually false? A government accused of something? The police receiving a complaint? The official in question whose reputation is damaged?

Once the state becomes the judge of what is true or not, the ability to check the facts will depend on the state's approval. Bangladesh knows well what happens when vague cybercrimes become tools of intimidation. According to a study by the Centre for Governance Studies and the TrialWatch initiative of the Clooney Foundation for Justice, 222 cases filed between 2018 and 2023 under the Digital Security Act (DSA) resulted in the criminalisation of 396 journalists. Among the 30 cases that were investigated in-depth, 27 journalists were arrested, half of whom were held for more than a month. Twenty practised self-censorship, and three left journalism forever. Of course, in hindsight, this dataset provides a partial view as the full picture of the total damage caused by the DSA—and its successor, the Cyber Security Act (CSA)—has yet to be established.

But it is clear that successful prosecution was not necessary to hurt someone or enforce censorship. Arrests, uncertainty, expensive legal processes, and reputational damage could do the job. The process that one targeted by the law had to go through became a punishment in itself. That is why the proposed protections for journalists are important but still insufficient. It is good news that the arrests and prosecution of journalists and media owners for publishing information will require prior court approval. But why should ordinary citizens with political views have fewer protections? As Dr Iftekharuzzaman, executive director of Transparency International Bangladesh (TIB), noted in his comment on the revisions, protecting journalists but no other citizens may lead to an unfair distinction. Freedom of expression is a constitutional right of every citizen, not just journalists, researchers, activists or politicians.

Another serious gap in the draft is the part on search, seizure and arrest without a warrant (sections 33, 34 and 35), which the revised version has left unaddressed. These provisions may be especially damaging when applied to journalists who keep their sources confidential.

The changes to the provision on blocking content are also inadequate. Authorities will have to notify their decisions within three days and dispose of the application to unblock the content within 15 days. This requirement cannot replace the judicial approval of censorship—notification after censorship is not equivalent to protection from censorship.

Aligning defamation penalties with the Penal Code also seems like a wrong step. Reducing the proposed maximum imprisonment period from five to two years does not solve the main problem: criminal prosecution should not be available for disputes of a reputational nature, which should be resolved through proportional civil remedies.

Moreover, there are concerns about the provisions for cancelling a media organisation's registration or licence after conviction, especially for an individual's offence. It is quite excessive and unreasonable to punish the whole institution for the deeds of its members.

Undoubtedly, the government faces certain cybersecurity problems. Cybercrimes like hacking, fraud, sexual exploitation, harassment, blackmailing and even AI-generated abuse require proper legal measures. But protecting citizens from cybercrimes and protecting the government from criticism are completely different goals. The Editors' Council's recommendations are more plausible: judicial oversight of arrests, search, seizure, and surveillance; protection of confidential sources; protection of public interest reporting; and protection against penalising media outlets for a single publication.

The government should remove criminal penalties for rumours and defamation, strengthen judicial oversight, and provide protection to all citizens without distinction. Its readiness to revise the draft is good news, but real change would be impossible without renouncing the idea that online criticism is a threat to be controlled.

Above all, Bangladesh cannot, and should not, rely on mere assurances that restrictive laws will not be misused. The DSA and CSA proved how easy it is to transform legal tools into weapons of intimidation. The only test of press freedom is journalists' ability to investigate and embarrass the government without fear of imprisonment. The country needs an effective cybersecurity law, not another tool for controlling public opinion.



VISUAL: **ALIZA RAHMAN**

Why Dhaka doesn't want Hasina back



David Bergman is a journalist who has written about Bangladesh for many years. His X handle is @TheDavidBergman.

■ **DAVID BERGMAN**

Seen from Sheikh Hasina's perspective, deciding to try and return to Bangladesh is clever politics.

First, it makes her relevant again; it makes her the centre of the story. Second, it looks brave and self-sacrificing, with her facing imprisonment and possibly even death. Third, it allows her supporters to contrast her "bravery" with that of the current prime minister, Tarique Rahman, who did not attempt to return to Bangladesh and face detention while Awami League was in power.

Fourth, it makes her appear loyal and empathetic towards her Awami League colleagues and supporters, since she suggests she is returning in part because of the rights violations and suffering they now face. Fifth, it will let her and Awami League draw far more critical attention to the International Crimes Tribunal (ICT) and the in absentia trial in which she was convicted.

Sixth, and perhaps most importantly, it puts the BNP government in a very difficult position. Officially, the government wants her back to face her sentence. In reality, her return could be the last thing it wants, because it would then have to decide whether to let her execution go ahead or find a way to avoid it, through her appeal or presidential clemency.

There would be huge public demand for her execution. And people would point out that between 2013 and 2016, the Awami League government executed five Jamaat-e-Islami leaders and one BNP leader, all convicted by the same tribunal that has now convicted her.

But the government also knows that Awami League still has considerable support in the country. Executing her could prove explosive, with consequences that are hard to predict and could badly damage both the country and the ruling BNP. Her execution, or even just her being in jail, would almost certainly lead to resurgent Awami League protests resulting in repression and human rights violations as the government tries to contain them.

Then there is the question of who she is. Whatever Hasina's misdeeds and crimes, can a BNP government really hang the daughter of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, the country's independence leader, whose family was murdered in 1975? It is hard to imagine. The government would also face heavy international pressure not to execute her: from India, obviously, but from other countries as well. Human rights organisations would point out that sentencing someone to death after a trial they took no part in, and possibly with no right of appeal, is a particularly egregious violation of fair trial rights.

Yet sparing her carries its own risk: a "Shahbagh on steroids," with tens of thousands on the streets demanding her execution and serious instability for the government.

So, by offering to return, Hasina makes herself relevant again and hands the government a problem it cannot easily solve, along with the kind of political instability she would be well placed to exploit. That is why her decision is more likely genuine, not just a gesture.

And it explains why the Bangladesh government has responded the way it has. For the last year, since her conviction, it has demanded that India hand Hasina over so she can face the tribunal's death sentence. Now that she says she will come back on her own, it appears to be refusing to help her do that. On the face of it, this makes no sense. The government says it wants her back, yet now that she is offering to come, it seems to be trying to find reasons to keep her away.

The reason is simple: for all the reasons stated above, Hasina inside Bangladesh is far more dangerous to the government than Hasina in Delhi.

Hasina's announcement also puts India in a bind. Her voluntary return would, on the face of it, solve New Delhi's biggest problem with Dhaka: the extradition request it has so far stonewalled. It would not have to hand over a long-standing ally. However, given Dhaka's insistence on a return under Bangladesh's extradition treaty with India, something it claims befits a convicted individual, it would seem that Dhaka would blame India for facilitating any attempt by Hasina to return outside the treaty arrangements, creating a reason for new tensions. In addition, it is difficult to see how India would want to be seen as letting a long-time ally walk towards a possible execution, even if it is apparently her own decision.

Meanwhile, Hasina's presence in India does have a real cost. Her August 2026 press conference in Delhi, where she and her party leaders spread a series of falsehoods and disinformation, derailed preparations for Tarique Rahman's first visit, which Narendra Modi wants as India tries to repair ties and limit Dhaka's drift towards Pakistan and China.

The irony is that Dhaka and Delhi may now share an interest: neither really seems to want Hasina back in Bangladesh, and Dhaka's apparent refusal to give her a passport or travel papers lets India keep her without having to say so.



VISUAL: **ANWAR SOHEL**

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What is holding back the health sector's development spending?



Dr Rumana Huque is professor in the Department of Economics at Dhaka University and executive director at ARK Foundation.

■ RUMANA HUQUE

The health sector in Bangladesh faces a troubling paradox: on the one hand, public hospitals struggle with shortages of medicines, diagnostic equipment and healthcare professionals, while on the other, a substantial portion of the budget allocation remains unutilised. An October report by *The Daily Star* reveals that during the first quarter (July-September) of the current fiscal year, the Health Services Division (HSD) spent only 1.78 percent of its direct Annual Development Programme (ADP) allocation, while the Medical Education and Family Welfare Division (MEFWD) spent 1.86 percent. Together, the two divisions spent just Tk 209 crore from the direct project allocations of Tk 11,513 crore. These exclude Tk 23,577 crore in block allocations for the two divisions, reportedly unused during the period. Both divisions performed below the national ADP implementation rate of 3.89 percent.

Although it is not unusual for the development expenditure to be generally slower during the first quarter, the above-mentioned figures raise an important question: why has the health ministry struggled to translate its budget allocations into implementable programmes? The explanation lies in interconnected structural challenges: discontinuation of the Sector-Wide Approach (SWAp), changes in government and policy priorities, inadequate institutional capacity, and delays in preparing and approving Development Project Proposals (DPPs).

For more than two decades, Bangladesh has implemented major development activities through successive Health, Population and Nutrition Sector Programmes (HPNSPs) under SWAp. These programmes provided a common planning and financing framework, with operational plans covering immunisation, disease control, maternal and child health, family planning, nutrition, and the strengthening of the healthcare system. The fourth programme ended in June 2024, and the proposed fifth programme was discontinued during the interim government. The decision reflected concerns about duplication, overlapping management structures, inefficiencies and weak accountability.

The transition has changed not only how projects are financed, but also how they must be planned and managed. Under the replacement arrangement, development activities are increasingly expected to be implemented through individual DPPs. Preparing these proposals requires technical design, costing, feasibility assessment, procurement planning and multiple approvals. While some DPPs have been prepared and approved, the broader pipeline has not been sufficiently ready for implementation. The fundamental problem here is that the previous programme management structure was discontinued before an equally functional alternative was firmly established.

Changes in government and administrative leadership have brought to the table new policy commitments and development priorities. Reconsidering projects, agreeing on priorities, and translating new commitments into feasible designs take time. The interim administration initiated the shift away from SWAp, while the elected government introduced its own health sector commitments and substantially increased development allocations. However, defining new priorities, reviewing earlier proposals and translating commitments into costed projects require institutional continuity and adequate preparation. The health sector faces competing demands: uninterrupted vaccine administration, essential medicine and contraceptive supplies, maternal and child healthcare, communicable and non-communicable disease control, stronger primary care, disease surveillance, recruitment of health personnel, emergency services, and hospital infrastructure.

The issue is how these priorities are sequenced. Essential services should take priority over less urgent infrastructure investment. A need-based, costed project pipeline must come before or at least accompany budget commitments. Without an agreed, need-based prioritisation framework, implementing agencies may struggle to determine which projects should proceed first. The health ministry needs to distinguish immediate service delivery requirements from medium-term system strengthening and long-term infrastructure investment. The priority should be projects that address urgent population health needs, demonstrate implementation readiness, and protect continuity of essential services.



VISUAL: **SALMAN SAKIB SHAHRYAR**

Preparing a DPP is not simply completing an administrative form. It requires expertise in epidemiology, needs assessment, financial analysis, costing, procurement, monitoring and evaluation, and project management. However, officials under different directorates already carry extensive responsibilities for managing services, personnel, administration, disease outbreaks, procurement and coordination with the ministry and field-level facilities. The Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS), for example, oversees hospitals, primary healthcare, disease control, planning and research, management information systems, and other technical operations. Similarly, the Directorate General of Family Planning (DGFP) and medical education institutions have their own workloads. Hence, the responsibility of preparing the DPPs may not reasonably be assigned as additional duties without dedicated technical support, clear accountability and sufficient time. Under SWAp, designated line directors, programme managers and deputy programme managers undertook development programme management responsibilities. After SWAp was discontinued, the ministry abolished these designations in September 2025, removing the previous programme management arrangements. But doing so did not make the need for specialised development planning disappear. The ministry and DGHS have planning functions, but the transition to multiple project-based arrangements requires a stronger, multidisciplinary project preparation capacity. The challenge is not necessarily a shortage of capable officials, but the absence of sufficiently protected time, specialised technical teams, and the institutional arrangement to translate policy priorities into implementable projects. The same problem extends to other implementing agencies, including DGFP and institutions responsible for infrastructure, medical education and specialised services.

A block allocation is a provision for prospective projects, not money that can be spent immediately without the required approvals. Without approved DPPs and appointed project personnel, implementing agencies cannot proceed with many planned procurement and implementation activities, and expenditure will lag even when resources are available on paper. This is particularly relevant to the substantial block allocation in FY2026-27. Routine delays in fund release and budget processing can add to the problem. Delays may subsequently encourage hurried procurement towards the end of the financial year, increasing risks to efficiency and value for money. That would substitute one governance problem for another. Faster expenditure should not come at the expense of quality and accountability.

What the country needs is faster preparation and more disciplined execution, not spending just for the sake of it. The immediate priority must be establishing a dedicated, multidisciplinary project preparation and implementation support team within the health ministry, working closely with DGHS, DGFP, the Planning Commission, and other implementing agencies. The mechanism can bring together health planners, health economists, public health specialists, finance and procurement professionals, and experienced project managers. Development partners and research institutions could provide time-bound technical assistance. Second, the ministry should develop a prioritised, costed project pipeline with clearly assigned responsibilities and timelines for DPP preparation, appraisal, approval and implementation. Existing services requiring uninterrupted financing should be identified first. Clear delegation to DGHS, DGFP and relevant technical agencies, alongside stronger coordination with the Planning Commission and Finance Division, would ease the burden on central policymakers.

Third, senior policymakers and DGHS directors need to provide strategic oversight to undertake technical project preparation by the team. Clear delegation, dedicated project teams, and stronger coordination between planning and implementing agencies are essential. Fourth, quarterly monitoring can track allocations, approvals, fund releases, expenditure and service outcomes. Progress against these milestones can be publicly reported. Last but not the least, development and operating budgets must be better coordinated. New hospitals and equipment investments will yield limited benefits without recurrent financing for staff, maintenance and essential supplies.

That Bangladesh needs greater public investment in healthcare is beyond dispute. But the experience of the July-September period of this fiscal year shows why the ability to plan and deliver matters as much as the size of an allocation. The challenge is not simply to accelerate spending but to establish the structures, expertise and accountability necessary to convert financial resources into quality healthcare. Unless the country invests in the institutional capacity to plan and implement its health budget, larger allocations will hardly meet all healthcare needs.

Animal welfare deserves greater attention from our NGOs



Dr Ahmed Mushtaque Raza Chowdhury is convener of Bangladesh Health Watch and founding dean of the James P Grant School of Public Health at BRAC University.

■ AHMED MUSHTAQUE RAZA CHOWDHURY

I went to BRAC University recently expecting to hear Peter Singer speak about poverty, inequality, ethics, and effective altruism. I came back thinking about chickens.

Singer, one of the world's most influential moral philosophers, was in Dhaka to receive the university's inaugural Honorary Fellowship. His connection with Bangladesh goes back to 1971, when, as a young philosopher at Oxford, he watched millions of refugees flee the atrocities in what was then East Pakistan.

That experience helped inspire his famous 1972 essay, "Famine, Affluence, and Morality". Its argument was deceptively simple: if we can prevent something terrible without sacrificing anything of comparable importance, we ought to do so. If we would rescue a drowning child from a shallow pond, why should distance make a suffering child in Bengal less deserving?

More than half a century later, Singer finally visited Bangladesh. He praised the country's development achievements and BRAC's evidence-based approach to reducing poverty. This was familiar territory to me. I have spent much of my working life asking how research can help reduce poverty, prevent unnecessary deaths, and take successful interventions to scale. Then the chickens entered the conversation.

An audience member asked why animal liberation and veganism receive so little attention in development discussions, including at NGOs. Singer described intensive farming for food as the largest form of human abuse of animals. Even counting vertebrates alone, he said, "something like 200 billion animals" are raised and killed worldwide annually—an almost incomprehensible scale of suffering.

He brought the argument closer to home. Singer said he had raised concerns about intensive poultry production with the leadership of his host organisation. Near Rajshahi, he had seen chickens wandering freely in villages. He contrasted them with modern meat chickens bred to grow so rapidly that their legs sometimes struggle to support their weight. He also described a calf belonging to a participant in a programme for ultra-poor graduation. Clearly a valuable and probably cherished asset, it was nevertheless tied in a confined space. Was that a good life for the calf? I found myself uncomfortable.

Must we first end wars, eliminate poverty, overcome discrimination, and save the environment before considering animals? Moral progress has never followed such an orderly sequence. We recognised environmental threats long before overcoming hunger. One moral concern need not wait for another to be resolved.

For decades, development practitioners like me have viewed livestock through a particular lens. A cow is an asset. Chickens generate income. Eggs provide nutrition. Livestock can strengthen women's economic position. For extremely poor households, acquiring animals can mark the beginning of an escape from destitution. Singer did not dismiss these achievements. Indeed, what impressed me was his hesitation. Acknowledging his privileged position, he said he could not simply tell poor Bangladeshis to stop raising chickens without understanding the consequences for their livelihoods and children's nutrition. But he insisted that animal well-being must also enter the equation.

That thought stayed with me. Development has taught us to ask whether an intervention improves human lives. Singer made me wonder whether that is any longer a sufficient question. Another audience member raised a disturbing possibility: might future generations look back at our treatment of animals as we now look back at societies that accepted slavery? The historical horror of slavery should not be casually equated with animal farming. But Singer's response concerned something broader: moral blindness. He hoped future generations would question how otherwise decent people could accept unnecessary suffering inflicted on sentient creatures.

What do we consider normal today that our grandchildren may find morally indefensible?

After the event, I discussed this with a school friend in London. He was sceptical. Humans are still killing fellow humans over territory, resources, power and ideology. Millions remain poor, and wars rage. Yet we are already discussing extending compassion to chickens? His conclusion was characteristically the phrase: 'Delhi is still a long way away'. I understand his scepticism. Singer, however, remains optimistic. At BRAC University, he pointed to declining child mortality and extreme poverty, and improvements in literacy and life expectancy. Despite the disturbing headlines, humanity has made substantial progress.

I find myself somewhere between Singer and my friend. But must compassion proceed sequentially? Must we first end wars, eliminate poverty, overcome discrimination, and save the environment before considering animals? Moral progress has never followed such an orderly sequence. We recognised environmental threats long before overcoming hunger. One moral concern need not wait for another to be resolved. Perhaps our moral circle can widen in several directions simultaneously.

This brings me back to a question I raised recently: what should be the future role of NGOs in Bangladesh? NGOs cannot simply continue doing what they have always done. As Bangladesh changes, they must discover new purposes and frontiers rather than merely preserve programmes created for an earlier era. Historically, NGOs have often recognised problems before they gained attention in mainstream development discussions. They drew attention to the landless poor, disadvantaged women, children excluded from schooling, people with disabilities and others living at society's margins. They experimented with solutions and helped bring neglected concerns into public policy. Could animal welfare become another such frontier?

This does not mean all NGOs must become animal-rights organisations or disregard poor farmers' livelihoods and children's nutrition. A modest beginning would be to recognise animal welfare as a legitimate consideration whenever development programmes involve animals. NGOs could research animal welfare conditions, experiment with more humane livestock and poultry practices, raise public awareness and encourage government and industry to adopt better standards. Such pioneering work, recognising emerging problems and testing practical responses, has long been among their strengths. We already assess whether programmes raise incomes, empower women, improve nutrition, and protect the environment. Why not also ask whether animals experience avoidable suffering?

As Bangladesh moves towards more intensive food production, these questions will become increasingly important. Efficiency, affordable nutrition and livelihoods matter enormously. But efficiency alone cannot define progress. I am not yet a vegetarian, let alone a vegan. Nor do I pretend these choices are simple in a country still struggling with poverty and nutritional insecurity. But Singer has made me less comfortable with the assumption that animal suffering lies outside the development conversation. Perhaps that discomfort is useful for our NGO community.

More than 50 years ago, Bangladesh's suffering prompted a young philosopher in Oxford to reconsider the boundaries of moral responsibility. Now Singer has finally visited Bangladesh and left at least one lifelong development worker with another question—one worth asking as our NGOs search for their future: Whose suffering have we not yet learned to see?

গণপ্রজাতন্ত্রী বাংলাদেশ সরকার
নির্বাহী প্রকৌশলীর কার্যালয়,
গণপূর্ত বিভাগ, পাবনা।
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সংশোধিত বিজ্ঞপ্তি

এতদ্বারা সর্বসাধারনের অবগতির জন্য জানানো যাচ্ছে যে, পাবনা গণপূর্ত বিভাগের অধীনস্থ পাবনা মানসিক হাসপাতাল এলাকায় অবস্থিত পুরাতন জরাজীর্ণ ব্যবহারের অযোগ্য পরিত্যক্ত ১৫(পনেরো) টি ভবন (যাহা ১৫ (পনেরো) গ্রুপে বিভক্ত) নিলাম দরপত্র বিজ্ঞপ্তি নং- ০৪(চার) অর্থ বছর ২০২৬-২০২৭ ইং মোতাবেক নিলাম দরপত্র আহবান করা হয়েছিল। কিন্তু অনিবার্য কারনবশত ১৫ (পনেরো) টি গ্রুপের মধ্যে গ্রুপ নং-৪ (চার) পাবনা মানসিক হাসপাতাল এলাকায় অবস্থিত পুরাতন জরাজীর্ণ ব্যবহারের অযোগ্য পরিত্যক্ত পুরাতন (বহিঃ বিভাগ) ভবন। (সাইট প্ল্যান অনুযায়ী চিহ্নিত ভবন নম্বর ঃ ২৯/৩০) এবং গ্রুপ নং-৬ (ছয়) পাবনা মানসিক হাসপাতাল এলাকায় অবস্থিত পুরাতন জরাজীর্ণ ব্যবহারের অযোগ্য পরিত্যক্ত টিন সেড (গার্ড) বাসা। (সাইট প্ল্যান অনুযায়ী চিহ্নিত ভবন নম্বর ঃ /৩১) নিলাম দরপত্র ০২(দুই) টি স্থগিত করা হলো।

(মোঃ রাশেদ কবির)
নির্বাহী প্রকৌশলী
গণপূর্ত বিভাগ, পাবনা।

GD-2739



‘NO COMPROMISES, ONLY QUALITY’

Mousumi Mou reflects on decade-long journey

SHARMIN JOYA

She commands the camera with her fluency, smile and confidence. One of the country’s most beloved anchors and actresses, Mousumi Mou has completed a decade as a host.

Today also marks her birthday, a date etched with an extraordinary coincidence in her life. Exactly ten years ago, on this day in 2016, she first stood in front of a broadcast camera as a host at BTV. Five years later, on the same calendar day, her journey as a reality show host began, making November a month of quiet triumphs. Reflecting on a decade of perseverance, Mou opens up about her personal growth, industry hurdles and unwavering dedication to the presenter’s mic.

Over the past ten years, Mou has hosted some of Bangladesh’s most prestigious television programmes, seamlessly spanning multiple channels and genres. From interviewing legendary cultural icons like Runa Laila, Alamgir, Abul Hayat, and Dilara Zaman, among other renowned artistes on Maasranga TV’s ***Star Night***, to hosting prime-time staples such as ***Ispahani Mirzapore Banglabid***, ***Ajker Anannya***, ***Konka Sera Poribar***, ***Meril Cafe Live*** and ***Shera Radhuni***, her presence has become a familiar fixture on television.

“Looking back, I still can’t believe ten years have passed,” Mou reflects. “It hasn’t been easy—there were times I was dropped from projects, but staying honest and dedicated brought me back to host the biggest shows. I always treat myself as an equal team member and maintain strict punctuality.”

Her empathetic presenting style has earned her a devoted international audience. “An expatriate lady from Australia recently told me that her family laughs and cries alongside me when watching ***Star Night***,” she shares warmly. “That emotional connection is a massive compliment.”

While hosting remains her primary craft, Mou’s artistic background also extends to mime and acting. However, her packed broadcast commitments have temporarily put her mime career on hold. “I had to miss mime performances in Korea and postpone a solo performance with Mir Lokman due to shooting schedules,” she explains.

Acting, meanwhile, is something she pursues purely out of passion, taking on exceptional scripts such as the upcoming season of ***Chokro***. “Since hosting is my primary profession, I only step onto an acting set when the project truly excites me,” she notes.

Mou does not shy away from discussing systemic flaws within the entertainment sector, particularly payment irregularities and unprofessional scheduling practices.

“Unprofessionalism is a real challenge in the acting industry,” Mou states candidly. Stating that she, in the beginning, was determined to become an actress, had taken theatre experience and wanted to continue her craft as well; however, the dream then took another turn due to some unexpected experiences. “Directors often block fifteen days of your schedule but end up shooting for only five, wasting crucial time. On top of that, delayed or withheld payments are common.”

As the primary breadwinner for her family, Mou relies on television hosting for financial stability, allowing her to turn down acting projects that lack professional integrity. “Because my bread and butter come from hosting, I don’t have to compromise on acting roles that don’t respect an artiste’s time or remuneration,” she asserts.

As she celebrates another birthday alongside a decade of success in television, Mou remains deeply grateful and optimistic. “The Almighty has blessed me with back-to-back shows, and as I turn a year older, I feel I still have so much more to give to my audience,” she concludes.

PHOTO: **COURTESY**



BFDC plans film festival honouring **Gazi Mazharul Anwar**

The Bangladesh Film Development Corporation (BFDC) plans to hold a film festival in February to honour the late lyricist, director and producer Gazi Mazharul Anwar.

BFDC Managing Director Masuma Rahman Tani said the festival would be held early in the month, ahead of Anwar’s birthday on February 22, which falls during Ramadan. The event will feature screenings of his films and new renditions of his timeless songs to introduce his work to younger audiences. His daughter, singer Dithi Anwar, is also involved in the initiative.

Anwar wrote more than 20,000 songs and also worked as a screenwriter, director and producer. His films include ***Shasti***, ***Swadhin***, ***Ulka*** and ***Amma***. Born in Cumilla on February 22, 1943, he died on September 4, 2022.

Johnny Depp makes Hollywood comeback with ‘Ebenezer’



Johnny Depp is set to make a major Hollywood comeback with ***Ebenezer***, a new adaptation of Charles Dickens’ ***A Christmas Carol***, in which he plays Ebenezer Scrooge. Directed by Ti West, the film is scheduled for release on November 13 and marks Depp’s first major studio role in nearly eight years.

The film reportedly has a production budget of $38 million, with a further $50 million spent on marketing. Depp is said to have earned $5 million, with additional performance-based bonuses.

Despite the controversies surrounding the actor in recent years, cinema owners remain cautiously optimistic about the film’s prospects. Industry projections estimate an opening weekend collection of around $20 million in North America.

NEWS

‘Fascist Awami forces’

FROM PAGE 12

would not file cases against those who had politically oppressed its members.

He agreed with the opposition leader that recent unrest had been instigated from across the border, saying he had repeatedly made similar remarks.

He alleged that the public was aware of secret meetings between senior leaders of a political party and representatives of foreign organisations in Dhaka.

He further alleged that the fugitive former leader had repeatedly instructed party leaders in audio calls from across the border to identify July uprising participants and attack their homes, but said such an opportunity was unlikely to arise.

Salahuddin said the government would never turn law enforcement agencies into partisan forces. Despite attacks on officers, he claimed, they had refrained from violating human rights.

“But it seems the fallen fascist forces have started taking advantage of this restraint. They are exploiting our respect for human rights,” he said, pledging to uphold the government’s commitments and thwart conspiracies and sabotage while respecting human rights.

He also accused the fallen forces and their domestic allies of inciting workers and turning labour grievances into protests, saying the government had taken effective measures.

During an unscheduled discussion, Opposition Leader Shafiqur Rahman said he had heard similar claims about improvements in law and order throughout his 52 years in politics.

Shafiqur, also the Jamaat ameer, welcomed Salahuddin’s commitment to unity against fascism but questioned his “suggestive remarks”.

“It has also been said that a particular political party has an understanding with a foreign intelligence agency. If that is what he meant, then he should clarify which party he is referring to,” he said.

Apparently referring to Prime Minister’s Political Assistant Rashed Khan, Shafiqur accused him of repeatedly criticising Jamaat.

“I state clearly that we have no history of meeting any foreign intelligence agency. Why would we meet intelligence agencies? We are a political party,” he said, adding that his party met political opponents and friends, not intelligence agencies.

He alleged that his party’s accusers had themselves met foreign agencies at home and abroad.

Claiming he had been misquoted at a previous press conference, Shafiqur said, “I never said that the Awami League had been forgiven. Throughout my entire 22-minute speech, I did not mention the Awami League even once, not even by mistake. The full video is still available and anyone can verify it.”

230 families

FROM PAGE 12

received no prior notice and could not salvage their furniture and other belongings.

“How will we live? Where will we go?” she asked.

Her daughter, Manowara Begum, said the family had been allotted the house for 99 years after being relocated from the TTP Para slum in Kamalapur to what was then a marshy area.

Mohammad Nur Jamal Haque, founding secretary of the Light of Justice Society, said the organisation filed a writ petition in 2024 on behalf of elderly women and other vulnerable residents following the political changeover on August 5, 2024.

He said the HC had issued a rule directing the authorities not to evict the residents until they were rehabilitated.

According to Haque, residents informed the organisation on October 31 that they had received a verbal notice giving them 24 hours to vacate the area.

The next morning, representatives visited the DSCC office, where an official from its estate department denied plans for any eviction drive, he said.

However, they later found an eviction drive underway, allegedly led by Mallik Ahsan Uddin Sami, deputy commissioner of the Wari zone, along with an executive magistrate and more than 100 police and Special Reserve Force personnel.

Haque said representatives, including the organisation’s president, Afsan Rahman, showed the authorities a copy of the court order and urged them to stop the operation.

“Although the demolition was initially halted after a few shops were removed, it resumed the following day,” he alleged.

He said the Wari zone deputy commissioner described the operation as an anti-drug drive, while DSCC officials denied involvement.

“If it was a drive against drugs, the authorities could have arrested those involved. They had no right to evict all the families,” he said.

Haque said the eviction had displaced around 230 families, leaving residents dependent on begging, domestic work and rickshaw driving in severe hardship.

He added that the organisation’s lawyer was preparing to file a contempt of court petition over the alleged violation of the court order.

Mohammad Liton Mia, 54, a resident of Ward 49, also appealed to the prime minister to intervene.

He said his family had been relocated from TT Para during Ershad’s tenure and given a house and allotment documents under an arrangement involving the army.

Liton said generations had grown up in the settlement, but residents had yet to find a permanent solution despite repeated assurances from successive governments. He alleged that residents had faced eviction attempts under the Awami League government and later approached the interim government, which assured them they could remain until alternative arrangements were made if the land was needed for development.

“I support lawful action against drug traders but oppose evicting entire families over the alleged activities of a few individuals.

He said residents had also approached the National Human Rights Commission and submitted documents to the mayor’s office, seeking five acres of land under a proposed project called Nijoshsho City Polli.

“We supported the BNP with the hope that our situation would improve. After enduring 17 years of hardship, we expected justice when our own party came to power. We are simply asking for our right to live with dignity.”

DSCC’S RESPONSE

Md Shah Alam Bhuiyan, superintending engineer (current charge) of the Mechanical Circle, said construction of housing facilities for evicted sanitation worker families, including the 230 families in Dhalpur, on five acres of the 15-acre project site was around 80 percent complete.

“The project aims to accommodate the families in a newly built tin-shed colony by December 30,” he said.

Regarding compensation, he said claims for losses could be reviewed in accordance with relevant documents and applicable laws. He added that official records would need to be checked to verify whether eviction notices had been served.

Regarding the ongoing court case and reported status quo rule, he said the corporation would determine its legal position after reviewing the court order and relevant documents.

The Daily Star made several attempts to contact Mallik Ahsan Uddin Sami, deputy commissioner of the Wari Division, by phone since last Wednesday, but he did not respond. This correspondent also visited his office but was unable to meet him.

When contacted, the additional deputy commissioner and assistant commissioner of the Demra zone under the Wari Division declined to comment.

Keep control of streets

FROM PAGE 12

party Chairman Tarique Rahman’s return to Bangladesh on December 25 and the first death anniversary of former prime minister Khaleda Zia on December 30.

“Our leaders and activists have been instructed to remain vigilant to counter these attempts politically,” said Nasir Uddin Nasir, general secretary of Chhatra Dal, the BNP’s student wing.

Chhatra Dal will remain active through various programmes throughout this month, as well as in December and January, he said.

The instructions came amid growing political tension and reports of possible developments surrounding former prime minister Sheikh Hasina’s return to Bangladesh.

Reuters reported on Monday that Hasina had requested a new passport and NID card to return to Bangladesh.

However, BNP leaders said they did not believe Hasina would actually return to the country.

They suspect that the announcement of her possible return is intended to mobilise Awami League leaders and activists, create panic among the public and put political pressure on the BNP-led government.

The political developments have coincided with a series of violent incidents across the country, they added.

On Tuesday, one person was killed and at least 10 vehicles were torched as incidents of crude bomb explosions and arson escalated and spread to more areas, according to media reports.

The BNP leaders alleged that the incidents were part of planned activities by the Awami League.

Responding to the situation in parliament on Tuesday, Home Minister Salahuddin Ahmed said there had been visible attempts by what he described as “fallen fascist forces” to destabilise the country.

“For some time now, the fallen fascist forces have been openly conspiring to destabilise the country. Anyone in the country with even a basic understanding of politics can recognise their intentions,” he said.

Meanwhile, at a briefing at the party’s Nayapaltan central office yesterday, BNP Acting Secretary General Ruhul Kabir Rizvi said that instability was being deliberately created to send a negative message about Bangladesh to the international community.

Any attempt by India to interfere in Bangladesh’s internal politics would not receive international support, he said, while urging the opposition to clarify their position on acts of sabotage.

Alongside its continued presence on the streets, the BNP is also placing emphasis on organisational restructuring, mobilising grassroots leaders and activists, and strengthening relations with its longstanding political allies.

Recent changes in the leadership of Dhaka Metropolitan North and South BNP were part of the ongoing organisational activities.

TIB slams

FROM PAGE 12

the advice as “grossly irresponsible” and unlawful, saying engineers were already paid from public funds to ensure work quality, accept completed projects and clear bills. He challenged the minister to cite any law allowing such benefits, referring to Sections 161 and 165 of the Penal Code, which criminalise unauthorised gratification and certain benefits linked to official duties.

The Government Servants (Conduct) Rules, 1979 require prior approval for gifts creating obligations, with certain exceptions, and cap specified gifts to secretaries or equivalent officers at Tk 500 each, he said. The Public Procurement Rules, 2025 allow branded diaries, calendars and pens worth up to Tk 5,000 each, but neither provision permits personal benefits from contractors’ profits for official duties.

Such benefits could compromise engineers’ impartiality in supervising projects and certifying bills, undermine fair competition, encourage collusion and legitimise bribery, he said.

Meanwhile, the ministry described TIB’s characterisation of the remarks as legitimising bribery as “untrue and misleading”. In a clarification signed by Public Relations Officer Borhan Uddin, it claimed the minister’s informal comments had been circulated without the core remarks, creating controversy with ill motives.

It called the allegation unwarranted political propaganda against the government’s anti-corruption stance.

Arson attacks

FROM PAGE 12

by using petrol on the Dhaka-Narayanganj link road around 11:30pm in the Karaitala area of Jalkuri on Tuesday, said Additional Superintendent of Police Tarek Al Mehedi, quoting locals.

Part of a tyre was burnt before the driver and his helper extinguished the blaze, he added.

In Brahmanbaria’s Akhaura upazila, several seats in the Dhaka-bound Titas Commuter train were damaged after a carriage caught fire during shunting around 3:00am yesterday, about a kilometre north of Akhaura Railway Junction, said Md Jahangir Alam, in-charge of Railway Nirapatta Bahini in Akhaura. On information, firefighters rushed to the spot and brought the blaze under control.

Talking to reporters, Md Nurunnabi, superintendent of Akhaura Railway Station, said the damaged carriage had been detached from the train, which left the junction about an hour behind schedule. Police detained two persons in connection with the incident, he added.

In Pabna Sadar upazila, miscreants set the Grameen Bank’s Dogasi Bazar branch on fire around 1:00am yesterday, said Md Asaduzzaman, assistant general manager of the bank’s Pabna zonal office.

The attackers also vandalised the office’s windowpanes, he said.

Inspector (Investigation) Sonjoy Kumar of Pabna Sadar Police Station also confirmed the incident.

In Netrokona, police recovered two bomb-like objects wrapped in adhesive tape from in front of the bank’s another branch at Challisha Bazar in Sadar upazila around 3:00am yesterday.

Meanwhile in Cox’s Bazar’s Teknaf, police and BGB members were injured in an attack from a flash procession of Awami League, whose political activities are now banned, and its affiliated organisations on Tuesday night.

Ohidur Rahman, additional superintendent of Cox’s Bazar’s police, said a team of police and BGB personnel went to the Godar Beel area around 11:00pm after receiving information that Awami League and Jubo League activists would bring out a procession.

“When the law enforcers tried to prevent the marchers, they hurled brick chunks at the law enforcers,” he said.

A sub-inspector was also struck on the head with a sharp weapon, the police officer said. The injured, Md Zafar, 40, who works at Teknaf Model Police Station, was undergoing treatment at Sadar Hospital.

In a press release yesterday, Border Guard Bangladesh said a group of miscreants suddenly attacked a special patrol team of Teknaf battalion near Oliabad Madrasa around 11:10pm on Tuesday.

One BGB member was wounded in the attack. Following the incident, a team of BGB and police personnel conducted a joint operation and arrested three suspects, said the release.

The arrestees are Khorshed Alam, 25, son of Fazal Ahmed; Akib, 22, son of Zafar Alam; and Abdul Gafur, 19, son of Markin Mia. All three are residents of Notun Pallan Para in ward-4 of Teknaf Sadar Union, it added.

Toddler falls

FROM PAGE 2

was in the ward. The child, who had recently started walking, apparently wandered through an open ward gate onto a balcony without a safety grille, from where he fell.

Dr Shamim said the area was under construction and remained somewhat unprotected.

“The child was without a guardian at the time. He fell while playing. We started treatment immediately, but could not save him,” he said.

He said the child’s body had been handed over to the family.

“The family is very poor. On the director’s instructions, arrangements have been made for them to return home from the hospital,” he added.

Man held over killing of 13-year-old boy

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

Police have arrested a 20-year-old man in connection with the killing of a 13-year-old boy who went missing four days ago and was found dead in a bush in Dhaka's Demra on Tuesday.

The body of Hamidul Islam was recovered in a decomposed state from behind a bottle factory in Naraibag after locals alerted police, said Sub-Inspector Shaikh Khasru of Demra Police Station yesterday. Police sent the body to Dhaka Medical College Hospital for an autopsy.

The suspect, Arif, a hotel worker, was arrested after police examined CCTV footage, the SI said.

During interrogation, Arif confessed to sexually assaulting him. When the boy screamed, Arif allegedly strangled him and left his body there, the SI said. The exact cause of death will be determined through the autopsy, he added.

Bangladesh joins global rooftop solar pact

FROM PAGE 2

The voluntary, non-binding declaration supports the "300 Million Solar Homes" initiative, which aims to double the number of solar-powered households worldwide to 300 million by 2030.

Signatories agree to prioritise simpler permitting processes, integrate rooftop solar into energy and climate policies, ensure affordable financing for households and communities, upgrade grids, guarantee equitable access to solar power, and train local workers.

"Many countries have the sunshine, the space, and the demand but lack the finance, infrastructure, and workforce needed to unlock this opportunity," said Chris Bowen, Australia's minister for climate change and energy, who is presiding over the COP31 negotiations.

One in three Australian homes currently has rooftop solar, the highest rate in the world, he said in the release.

Bangladesh's 5,500MW target is outlined in the government's National Renewable Energy Development Strategy 2026-2030, which aims to generate 20 percent of the country's electricity from renewable sources by the end of the decade.

However, the country remains far short of the goal. Official data puts installed rooftop solar capacity at 418.1MW as of June this year, though the Institute for Energy Economics and Financial Analysis (IEEFA), a US-based think tank, estimates the actual figure could be around 1,000MW, as official statistics miss many installations.

Heated exchanges in JS over fertiliser dealerships

FROM PAGE 3

of the 31 fertiliser dealers in Thakurgaon were affiliated with the BNP, including wives, children and nieces of party leaders.

He claimed a "festival" of dealership appointments had taken place, with some reserved-seat MPs issuing demi-official (DO) letters in exchange for money.

Hasnat demanded a review of the appointments. "When will this culture end in our country that whenever I become an MP, my son becomes a businessman, my wife becomes a businesswoman and my nephew becomes a businessman? I want a clear answer from the honourable minister," he said.

Responding, Aminur Rashid said he viewed the word "festival" positively.

"He [Hasnat] said there was a festival surrounding fertiliser dealerships. We actually want it to be a festival that people can celebrate. I understand the word festival in a positive sense. If you view it negatively, that is a different matter," he said.

His remarks triggered loud protests from opposition MPs, prompting the minister to urge them to stop interrupting.

Aminur Rashid said district- and upazila-level committees had been formed to appoint fertiliser dealers. Applications were assessed against established rules and criteria before scrutiny by district committees, with local MPs eligible to serve as advisers.

As opposition lawmakers continued protesting, Deputy Speaker Kayser Kamal, who was presiding over the sitting, intervened.

"If members are not satisfied with the answer, we will take another question. But why should we turn ourselves into schoolchildren by creating such a commotion? Please sit patiently and listen to his [minister's] answer," he said.

Several ruling party lawmakers also urged opposition MPs, some of whom had stood up, to return to their seats.

Chief Whip Nurul Islam Moni rejected the allegation that ruling party MPs had secured dealerships in exchange for money.

He challenged those making the allegations to submit written evidence or discuss the matter with the minister. Otherwise, he demanded that the "false statement" be expunged from the parliamentary record.

Despite further attempts by opposition MPs to speak, the deputy speaker moved on to the next question.

4 officials off to Netherlands

FROM PAGE 3

All expenses will be borne by the respective supplier, with no financial involvement from the Bangladesh government.

The officials' stay abroad, including travel and transit, will be counted as official duty. They cannot extend their stay beyond the approved period and must submit a report to the home ministry's senior secretary within 15 days of returning.

Contacted, Deputy Secretary Mohammad Shariful Islam, who signed the order, said yesterday evening, "The decision has been taken by the government and the order was taken accordingly."

He declined further comment.

RMG unrest continues

FROM PAGE 3

The government formed a wage board on November 1 following protests by RMG workers demanding a minimum monthly wage of Tk 30,000.

However, workers have continued protesting, demanding an announcement of the new minimum wage rather than merely the formation of the board.

Kabir Hossain, joint secretary of the central committee of the Jatiya Garments Sramik Federation, said those described as outsiders were actually workers who had lost their jobs following factory closures over the past two to three years.

"They are now engaged in different occupations, from driving rickshaws to other jobs. When the workers started the movement, these people joined in, driven by their own grievances," he added.

Primary education

FROM PAGE 3

conclusions from a study of only 24 schools.

NAPE Director General Farid Ahmad said many pupils still struggled with basic reading, making advanced learning approaches difficult to introduce.

Prof Nurun Nabi Alam, senior specialist at NCTB, said STEAM principles were already included in the curriculum, but teachers needed support to implement them. He recommended reviewing learning gaps across classes I to V.

World Vision education specialist Kamruzzaman Kamrul questioned a proposed model offering advanced facilities to urban schools but low-cost alternatives to rural ones.

Sesame Workshop Country Director Talat Mahmud opposed another pilot project, advocating nationwide implementation of existing STEM principles.

CAMPE Executive Director Rasheda K Choudhury, who chaired the discussion, called for stronger cooperation to improve primary education.

CAMPE Programme Officer Sizul Islam presented proposals on eligibility, exam schedules, university admissions, vocational training, employment opportunities and research into institutions recording either 100 percent passes or zero passes.

316 killed in armed attacks in CHT

FROM PAGE 3

He said the armed forces' special operation, "Operation Uttaran", was underway to curb the activities of regional armed groups, including KNF, UPDF and JSS, and recover illegal weapons.

The Bangladesh Army, Border Guard Bangladesh, police and Special Response Battalion were conducting regular patrols and intensifying intelligence activities.

Hundreds of active members of regional armed groups had been arrested, while large quantities of sophisticated firearms, ammunition, magazines, combat uniforms, drones and signal equipment had been recovered, he said.

The minister said authorities had identified key funding sources and economic sectors linked to the armed groups and placed them under strict surveillance to disrupt their financing and prevent arms and drug smuggling.

BGB had also strengthened surveillance along borders and in remote areas to prevent the smuggling of illegal firearms and drugs, he added.

Family outing ends in tragedy

FROM PAGE 3

handed them over to the family without autopsies at their request.

Mamun's father, Nazrul Hossain Mofazzal, said the family had gone on a trip to the Chandra area of Gazipur.

"They left the house all smiling, and returned lifeless hours later," he said, breaking down in tears.

OC Manzur said the family had yet to file a complaint.

"If a complaint is filed, legal procedure will be followed," he added.

Meanwhile, two women were killed in a road accident in the capital's Gabtoli around 10:30am yesterday.

The victims, Delowara Begum, 63, and Kajol Begum, 45, were waiting for a vehicle when a Dhaka-bound Chadni Paribahan bus from Bogura hit them, said Dulal Hossain, officer-in-charge of Darussalam Police Station.

Government of the People's Republic of Bangladesh
Department of Environment
Host and Rohingya Enhancement of Lives Project (HELP)
DoE Component-"Comprehensive Environmental Impact and Damage Assessment of Rohingya Influx in Cox's Bazar and Bhasanchar of Chattogram Division
1st Floor, Room: 202, Poribesh Bhaban New Building
E/16 Agargaon, Sher-E-Bangla Nagar, Dhaka-1207
www.doe.gov.bd

Memo No.: 22.02.0000.020.76.019.26.154 Date: 11/11/2026

Request for Expressions of Interest
(Consulting Services – Firm Selection)

Country: Bangladesh
Name of the Proposed Project: Host and Rohingya Enhancement of Lives Project (HELP)
Grant No.: E325-BD
Assignment Title: Development of Turtle Hatchery for conservation
Reference No.: S-12
Project ID No: P501274

The People's Republic of Bangladesh has received financing from the World Bank toward the cost of the **Host and Rohingya Enhancement of Lives Project (HELP)** and intends to apply part of the proceeds for consulting services for Development of Turtle Hatchery for conservation for the ultimate objective of this assignment is to facilitate hatchling production for conservation of sea turtles in Sonapara, Cox's Bazar.

1. The broad scope of consulting services ("the Services") includes but not limited to:
   - Inception
   - Situational Report
   - Mid-Term Progress Report
   - Comprehensive Conservation Strategy Report
   - The final report consolidating all Deliverables

1. Objectives

The ultimate objective of this assignment is to facilitate hatchling production for conservation of sea turtles in Sonapara, Cox's Bazar. The specific objectives are to: (1) understand sea turtle nesting sites' current situation, threats, and necessary conservation actions in Sonapara; (2) establish and operationalize turtle hatchery; and (3) conduct awareness raising activities.

2. Scope of Work

1) Conduct an assessment and year-round monitoring of sea turtle nesting at Sonapara Beach

The Consultant will identify and map sea turtle nesting sites and conduct focus group discussions (FGDs) with fishers to identify threats (including bycatch, predation, human disturbance, and habitat degradation). The Consultant will monitor nesting throughout the year to capture seasonal patterns and inform conservation actions. Develop a situational report which will cover: (i) identification and characterization of critical nesting habitats; (ii) migration and population studies using appropriate, ethical methods; (iii) development of an inventory of nesting events and hatching success; (iv) documentation of mortality, nesting frequency, and nest fate; and (v) identification and quantification of sources and levels of threats (including bycatch). The Consultant will prepare a comprehensive conservation strategy report summarizing findings and proposing a Conservation Management Plan (CMP) with actionable, long-term strategies, responsibilities, and a time-bound implementation schedule. The report also summarizes the results of all the activities conducted under this assignment.

2) Establish and manage turtle hatchery

The Consultant will establish a turtle hatchery and guard shed with appropriate equipment and security measures. Nests will be managed for safe in-situ incubation and hatching; where in-situ protection is not feasible, the Consultant will implement ex-situ conservation (egg relocation) following accepted protocols and required permits. The Consultant will deploy guards as needed, control predators (e.g., dogs, crows, and other predatory animals), and prevent egg poaching consistent with legal and ethical standards. The Consultant will maintain records of nests managed, relocation activities, hatching success, and predator control actions.

3) Conduct awareness raising activities

The Consultant will conduct awareness meetings with fisher communities on safe handling and release of entangled turtles. The Consultant will identify turtle egg collectors and hold dialogue with them to reduce poaching and promote stewardship. The Consultant will prepare and post informational signboards at key locations, develop and print a sea turtle information poster or leaflet (1,000 copies), and organize media campaigns around turtle hatchling releases and relevant observances (e.g., World Sea Turtle Day), in coordination with local authorities and community groups.

3. The detailed Terms of Reference (ToR) can be found at the following website: www.doe.gov.bd The ToR or any further information can be obtained at the address of the undersigned given below, during office hours from 9:00 am to 4:00 pm Bangladesh Standard Time (BST).

4. The Department of Environment (DoE) now invites eligible consulting firms ("Consultants") to indicate their interest in providing the services. Interested Consultants should provide information demonstrating that they have the required qualifications and relevant experience to perform the services. The shortlisting criteria are:
   a) General Experience of the Firm in providing services (core business and years in business);
   b) The Consultant must have at least 10 years of in-depth working experience on Development of Turtle hatchery in Bangladesh;

5. **Consultants are requested to submit, but not limited to, the following supporting documents in support of the above-mentioned criteria:**
   (i) The Firm's Incorporation/Trade/registration documents from the country of the firm (ii) Firm's brochures; (iii) description of similar consultancy contracts, including the scope, contract amount, name of Client, period of the contract (date of contract signing to date of completion), location/ country of the services, etc.

6. The attention of interested Consultants is drawn to the Section III, Para 3.14, 3.16, and 3.17 of the World Bank Procurement Regulations for IPF Borrowers, September 2023 ("Procurement Regulations"), setting forth the World Bank's policy on conflict of interest.

7. Consultants may associate with other firms to enhance their qualifications but shall indicate clearly whether the association is in the form of a joint venture (i.e. all members of the joint venture shall be jointly and severally liable) and/or a sub-consultancy (i.e. the Consultant will be responsible, including for the services of the sub-consultant). In case of an association, the Consultant must explain in the EoI submission (a) the rationale/ justification for the proposed inclusion of the JV members and/or sub-consultants; and (b) the anticipated role and relevant qualifications of each member of the Joint Venture and/or of each sub-consultant for carrying out the assignment. Failure to provide the above explanation in the EoI may risk the association not being shortlisted for the assignment. However, the qualifications/ experience of sub-consultants will not be considered by the Client in the evaluation of Expressions of Interest for Shortlisting purposes.

8. A consulting Firm will be selected following the "Consultant Qualification Selection" method.

9. Expected date for commencement of the services is March 2027 and the tentative duration of the entire assignment is 12 months.

10. Expressions of Interest must be delivered in a written form to the address below (in person or by mail) by 1500 hours (BST) (GMT + 6 hours) on 29 November, 2026.

11. The authority reserves the right to accept or reject any or all EoIs without assigning any reason, whatsoever.

Signed

Md. Samsuzzaman Sarker
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Host and Rohingya Enhancement of Lives Project (HELP)
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GD-2742

ESSAY

A century of Abu Ishaque and the persistence of the human spirit

ABDUS SELIM

A century after his birth on November 1, 1926, Abu Ishaque remains a paradox in Bangla literature: a writer of modest output and extraordinary literary reach. His three novels—*Shurjo-Dighal Bari* (1955), *Padmar Palidwip* (1986), and the detective novel *Jaal* (1988)—attest to a literary imagination less concerned with prolific production than with the moral anatomy of society. His achievement was not merely to portray the marginalised but to make those whom history routinely overlooks its most eloquent witnesses. His varied career in administration, policing, intelligence, and diplomacy sharpened his understanding of human psychology, particularly the hidden transactions of authority: how people command obedience, disguise self-interest, manipulate beliefs, and persuade the vulnerable that their suffering is inevitable.

Born in rural Bengal, Ishaque lived through the devastating famine of 1943, Partition, and the turbulence of Pakistan's early decades. Yet his fiction seldom approaches these historical convulsions through political leaders or official narratives. Instead, he records their consequences in emptied kitchens, broken households, dispossessed cultivators, and women driven to the margins. For him, history is not simply what happens to a nation; it is what a nation permits to happen to its poorest citizens. His realism thus acquires a political dimension without surrendering its artistic independence.

In *Shurjo-Dighal Bari*, Ishaque's finest achievement, Jaigun's desperate search for food and shelter exposes the cruelty concealed within respectable social conventions. She must work to keep her children alive, but working outside the home invites condemnation for violating purdah. Society insists upon a woman's modesty while denying her the material conditions of survival. The contradiction is devastating: the very activities through which Jaigun fulfils her maternal responsibilities become grounds for her public humiliation. Here, survival itself becomes an act of defiance.

The supposedly ill-omened house crystallises the novel's larger argument. Its orientation is blamed for the family's misfortunes, while the tangible sources of suffering—hunger, patriarchal violence, social hostility, and economic dependency—escape scrutiny. A fakir's promise of supernatural protection converts fear into material profit. Superstition becomes more than mistaken belief; it functions as an ideological instrument that diverts attention from the structures of exploitation. The irony is unmistakable: the house is not cursed; the social order is diseased.

This relationship between belief and authority becomes particularly disturbing when religious functionaries collaborate with village headmen to enforce social obedience. Jaigun's compulsory public repentance before her daughter's wedding party demonstrates how religious rituals can be appropriated to discipline women whose poverty makes conformity impossible. Ishaque's target, however, is not faith itself but its calculated manipulation. His fictional society reveals something akin to Antonio Gramsci's concept of hegemony: domination sustained not merely through coercion but through the internalisation of beliefs that make inequality appear legitimate which is almost equal to self-subjugation of our women folk.

Ishaque nevertheless refuses the comforts of moral simplification. Jaigun is neither an immaculate heroine nor a self-conscious feminist. She resists injustice while occasionally reproducing the prejudices that sustain it, particularly in her attitudes towards marriage and the unequal social value assigned to sons and daughters. Her contradictions make her psychologically convincing. Emancipation in this novel is not an accomplished condition but an uneven struggle against the very assumptions that have shaped one's consciousness. Jaigun's rebellion is practical before it is philosophical.



ILLUSTRATION: MAHMUDA EMDAD

Karim Bakhs, her brutal former husband, embodies another, equally compelling contradiction. Violent, possessive and deeply patriarchal, he initially appears an irredeemable villain. Yet his eventual sacrifice to protect Jaigun and her children transforms the reader's understanding of his character. This final act cannot absolve his earlier cruelty; rather, it reveals an unexpected capacity for humanity. Where Jaigun demonstrates remarkable continuity of purpose, Karim Bakhs undergoes a profound moral transformation. Ishaque thus challenges simplistic distinctions between virtuous victims and wicked oppressors. The oppressed may internalise oppression, while even the oppressor may discover compassion.

This complexity extends to Ishaque's representation of class. The poor are not invariably united, nor are they necessarily virtuous. Poverty produces suspicion, jealousy and rivalry as readily as solidarity. His village is consequently no pastoral sanctuary but a contested social world where landowners, religious intermediaries and local officials exercise power over those dependent upon them. Such realism reveals Ishaque's socialist sympathies without reducing his fiction to ideological propaganda.

Padmar Palidwip extends this inquiry from domestic shelter to the unstable geography of Bengal's riverine landscape. The Padma creates islands that erosion may subsequently erase; labour renders them productive, but power determines who possesses them. The house and the char thus become complementary symbols of precarious belonging. Nature provides land, human labour creates value, yet ownership remains governed by unequal social relationships. Both novels expose the distance between the elementary human need for security and the structures that perpetually frustrate it.

Ishaque's historical imagination is equally perceptive. His portrayal of Partition exposes the limitations of political emancipation when economic and social hierarchies remain intact. National boundaries may change, governments may fall and new political identities may emerge, but the struggles of landless peasants and destitute women can persist almost unchanged. Political independence, his fiction suggests, cannot be equated with social liberation.

I encountered another dimension of Ishaque's originality while translating *Shurjo-Dighal Bari* into English as *The Ill-Omened House*. His colloquial idioms, folk rhymes, religious expressions and socially differentiated voices presented formidable challenges. Their significance resides not merely in their literal meanings but in the cultural experiences they embody. To translate them mechanically would risk preserving information while extinguishing the vitality of the original.

More fundamentally, I confronted the relationship between grammatical tense and narrative time. Having travelled across different time zones, I had become conscious of the distinction between measurable time and its subjective experience. I therefore translated the first chapter predominantly in past tenses, since it establishes the narrative's antecedents. From the second chapter onwards, I adopted the narrative present, shifting into the past whenever necessary. My intention was not grammatical experimentation for its own sake but to recreate the immediacy and uncertainty through which Ishaque's characters experience their lives. Translation, I believe, demands fidelity not simply to words but to the movement of consciousness within a narrative.

At his centenary, Ishaque's relevance remains undiminished. Gender discrimination, religious manipulation, economic dispossession and environmental insecurity continue to trouble our society. Yet his greatest achievement transcends these immediate concerns. He recognised that human beings are neither wholly noble nor irredeemably corrupt, and that resilience must never become an excuse for the injustice that makes it necessary.

Jaigun's survival is heroic, but a society that demands heroism merely to stay alive stands morally condemned. The novel offers neither decisive victory nor comforting resolution. Its final movement affirms something more enduring: the unfinished struggle of human existence. Despite everything, they walk on.

Abdus Selim *is an eminent academic and translator. He can be reached at selim70plus@gmail.com.*

BOOK REVIEW: NONFICTION

'LISTEN': Lending an ear to the stories of human trafficking survivors

Review of photobook 'LISTEN: True Accounts of Those Who Survived Human Trafficking', developed by Korea International Cooperation Agency

TIASHA IDRAK

One of the only few things that a person can truly call their own is their body. But what happens when that very body, their very being is controlled by another, to be torn away from their identities, treated as commodity, bought and sold for consumption? That is what it means to be human trafficked, to be sold across borders, have one's dignity stripped away from them, to be reduced to a commodity.

Every year, hundreds of Bangladeshis aspire to rebuild their lives and secure a better future by crossing borders. Behind every statistic on human trafficking, behind every number, lies a story—one of a human life shaped by deception, tragedy, exploitation, and loss.

LISTEN: True Accounts of Those Who Survived Human Trafficking is a photobook that brings these stories to light. Launched by International Organization for Migration (IOM) Bangladesh, the photobook focuses exclusively on the diverse realities of human trafficking, documented through powerful visual storytelling and first-hand survivor narratives. First of its kind in Bangladesh, the publication places the voices and experiences of human trafficking survivors at the centre of the conversation.

This publication was developed with the support of the Korea International Cooperation Agency (KOICA) under the project "A Comprehensive Counter-Trafficking Programme in Bangladesh", implemented by IOM.

Conceptualised by Pooja Bhalla and Soumin Shahrid of IOM Bangladesh, the photobook features the photographs by Soumin Shahrid. The documentation of the stories was done by Catherine Northing, Pooja Bhalla, Disha Sonata Faruque, Amal Biswas, Tarek Mahmud, Soumin Shahrid, and Fabiha Noshin, all from IOM Bangladesh. The publication was designed by Najnin Jahan Khan of Drik, which also handled its production in Bangladesh.

The book features the stories of 22 survivors of human trafficking. All of the stories in the book are narrated by the survivors themselves, including men and women of different ages, hailing from different corners of the country. Most of them come from humble backgrounds, many of whom had their lands swallowed by the river, some had been struggling with unemployment. Most, if not all of them, had been battling poverty, which compelled them to work as migrant workers in the first place. And it was during these vulnerable periods of their lives that they came across a dalal (referring to a middleman or intermediary) who is involved in recruitment processes linked to smuggling and trafficking. They play the role of a friend, a well-wisher, promising a dignified future and stable income. Sometimes it is one's own family members.

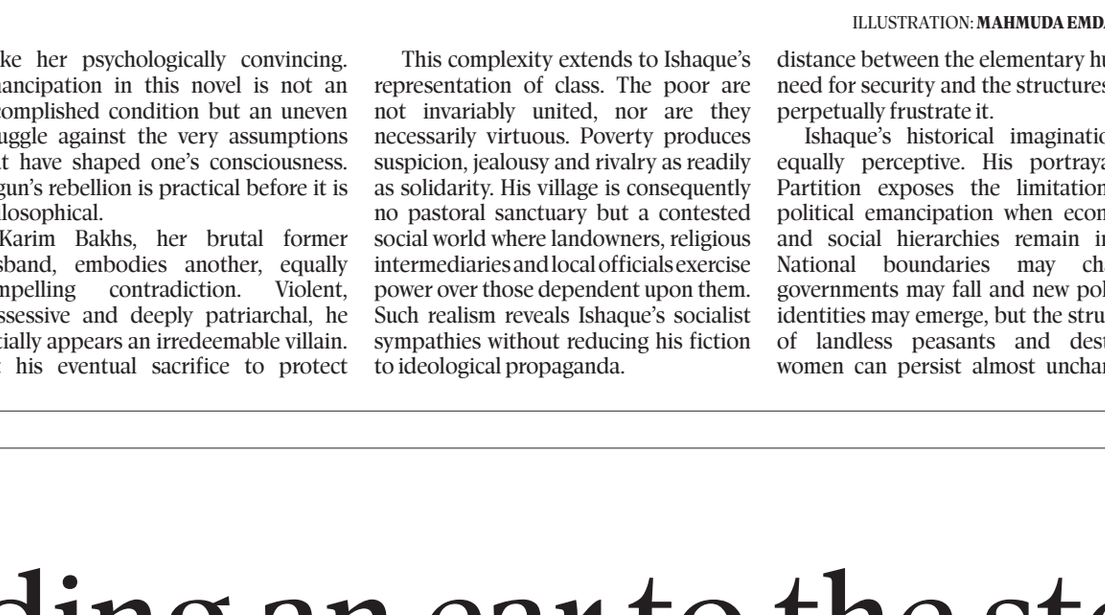


ILLUSTRATION: MAISHA SYEDA

Most of the survivors featured in the publication were trafficked to the Middle East or SWANA (Southwest Asia and North Africa), while others were trafficked to India and other neighbouring countries. In the Middle East, the dalals betrayed the survivors and sold them to kafeels (sponsor or employer), taking away their passports and stealing their income, and trapping them in a life of physical, emotional and sexual torment and servitude. In its introduction, the photobook states that the kafeel is central to the Kafala system, a labour sponsorship framework in several Arab states that ties a worker's legal status to the employer, which enables these employers to have complete control over the movement, employment and personal freedom of the workers—a total control over their lives.

On its cover photo, the book features the picture of a single ear. A woman's ear, to be precise. Above the picture is the title, *LISTEN*, typed in red. The cover is meant to be striking, to catch the eyes of any onlooker, beckoning them to lend an ear. Beckoning them to listen to the voices of the victims of human trafficking, the ones who have seen the horrors and have returned to tell the tale.

The book includes the stories of Latif, Mukta, Shabana, Rano, Salma, Masum, Robiul, Noor, Jannat, Ali, Putul, Farhana, Jhumur, Beli, Hashi, Nupur, among others. All of them had dreamt of building a better life, only to have their dignity and dreams trampled upon in the maws of trafficking. These stories however are not only about violence and exploitation the victims had faced abroad, but they also reveal yet another price of trafficking, the enduring trauma, silence and stigma that chase around the survivors long after their return.

Each story is paired with a picture of the survivor, a translucent sheet in between. These sheets are not for mere decorative purposes. They carry quotes from the survivors, their agony inked in red. The photographs obscure the faces of the survivors for their protection, but the way in which it is done varies. The team behind the publication explained that every photographic manipulation, whether achieved through the camera or during post-processing, was entirely deliberate. The testimony of the survivor impacted all of it.

This is an excerpt. Read the full review on *The Daily Star* and Star Books and Literature websites.

Tiasha Idrak *is drowning in a swamp of her own thoughts at the moment. She writes and daydreams, the latter is more applicable most of the time. She is still trying to come up with a proper author's bio. Tell her to stop procrastinating at tiashaidrak27@gmail.com.*

DHAKA THURSDAY NOVEMBER 12, 2026, KARTIK 27, 1433 BS

SPORT



I'm not calling for anything. All I've ever wanted for us is to take accountability as a team. This has never been a witch hunt for me, it's only been those three guys who've had to cop this flak for a long time.

USMAN KHAWAJA, former Australia batter about Sandpapergate



Farhaan Ali Wahid is ecstatic following his scintillating goal against Sri Lanka in Bangladesh's SAFF Championship fixture at the National Stadium in Dhaka on Wednesday. Shamit Shome, Hamza Choudhury and Rakib Hossain scored the other goals in a 4-0 rout. PHOTO: **FIROZ AHMED**

Scoring burden shared in emphatic response

TANVIR AHMED PRANTO

The absence of a prolific, out-and-out number nine had been a talking point surrounding Bangladesh ahead of their SAFF Championship campaign. But by the time the hosts had completed a 4-0 rout against Sri Lanka at the National Stadium yesterday, they had offered a convincing answer to that concern: goals do not necessarily have to come from the centre-forward.

Bangladesh found four different routes to goal on the day, as Shamit Shome, captain Hamza Choudhury, Farhaan Ali Wahid and Rakib Hossain all got on the scoresheet. Rather than relying on a traditional goalscorer to carry the attacking burden, the hosts drew on the movement and finishing ability of their midfielders and wide forwards.

Mohammad Ibrahim, who scored in the first game against Bhutan, offered a physical presence up front, keeping the central defenders occupied and creating room for players arriving from deeper positions. He also put himself about, taking a blow to the head in the 31st minute before challenging goalkeeper Sujan Perera for the ball in the 65th.

Shamit was perhaps the clearest example of Bangladesh's collective approach. Operating alongside Quazem Shah Kirmanee in a double pivot, his primary responsibility was to provide defensive cover and help win possession. He showed that side of his game in the 11th minute, tracking back to stop Adhavan Rajamohan after the Sri Lankan forward had found space centrally.

But Shamit also demonstrated that his influence was not restricted to defensive duties. In the eighth minute, he arrived in the box at the right time to turn home the rebound after Perera failed to hold Hamza's cross from the right. His willingness to move forward and support attacks, while maintaining his defensive responsibilities, gave Thomas Dooley's charges another dimension in midfield.

SEMIFINAL LINE-UP

1st Semifinal: India vs Bhutan, 14 Nov, 3:00 pm

2nd Semifinal: Bangladesh vs Pakistan, 14 Nov, 8:30 pm

The left flank, meanwhile, provided a different source of danger. Farhaan stretched the Sri Lankan defence with his direct running and ability to take on defenders, while Shamit's movement offered support. Their combination created problems for the visitors, with Farhaan also heading a diagonal delivery back into the danger area in the 25th minute, allowing Hamza to attempt a back-flick that narrowly cleared the crossbar.

Picking up the ball on the left, Farhaan beat his marker, and then two more with close control of the ball, cut inside onto his right foot and fired towards goal, with his effort taking a deflection off a defender before finding the net.

Hamza, meanwhile, was the driving force behind much of Bangladesh's play. The new captain was vocal in demanding greater intensity from his teammates, while also looking to influence the attack. After an early free-kick and a long-range effort failed to find the target, he produced the decisive moment just before half-time, beating his marker from the left before unleashing a powerful shot that went in off Perera's knee.

Rakib added the finishing touch in the 87th minute, driving the final nail into the coffin of now-eliminated Sri Lanka as he raced through on a counter-attack before delicately lifting the ball over the advancing goalkeeper.

With the attacking responsibility shared across midfield and the flanks, the hosts, chasing their second SAFF title in 23 years, will hope this performance marks a platform for an even sterner test in their semifinal against Pakistan on November 14.

'What do we currently have for women's cricket?'

Following disappointing campaigns in the Asia Cup and Asian Games, veteran coach Sarwar Imran lost his position as head coach of the Bangladesh women's team and was replaced by David Hemp. Sarwar, who guided the Bangladesh men's team in their inaugural Test in 2000, spoke to The Daily Star's Samsul Arefin Khan about his experience, regrets and concerns over the state of women's cricket in Bangladesh. The excerpts are as follows:

The Daily Star (DS): How would you describe your experience as Bangladesh women's head coach?

Sarwar Imran (SI): We won two matches at the T20 World Cup in England and performed reasonably well in two others. However, after poor performances in the Asia Cup and Asian Games, the situation changed. I may have made one or two comments that did not go down well with the board, and David Hemp replaced me. I tried my best to bring the team up to the standard of Test-playing nations, but fitness remained a major obstacle.

DS: Why has women's cricket struggled to improve its competitiveness and fitness?

SI: Our biggest problem is the lack of competition. Beyond 14 or 15 players, we do not have enough players of a similar standard. Established players know their places are almost guaranteed, so they feel little pressure to improve. The ongoing National Cricket League T20 is an example. There are hardly any significant performances, and we lack players capable of challenging the national squad members.

Also, bringing in foreign trainers is not automatically the solution. A good trainer must push players beyond their comfort zones and demand improvement. Being liked by everyone does not necessarily mean someone is doing a good job.

DS: What problems did you face within the team?

SI: My assistant coaches were reluctant to intervene or put players under pressure, so I had to handle most of those responsibilities myself. Perhaps they were afraid of scolding female players or demanding too much from them.

DS: Did internal controversies affect team environment?

SI: Definitely. There were several issues involving the captain that made the environment unstable. Coaches perhaps remained silent



on certain matters out of fear.

DS: Has Nigar Sultana Joty's captaincy influenced team selection?

SI: It would be unfair to hold Joty solely responsible. Selectors and coaches also have important roles in team selection. The captain can express a preference when two players compete for the same position, but that is different from having the authority to select the team.

DS: What is needed to develop the next generation of players?

SI: We must strengthen the pipeline through school and Under-18 cricket. We also need quality coaches specifically for women's cricket, including female coaches. Without proper infrastructure, we cannot expect to beat Sri Lanka, Pakistan, Australia or India. Their investment and facilities show how seriously they support women's cricket.

DS: Why has our batting failed to progress?

SI: Eight or nine teams play in the Women's Premier League, but only the top four are genuinely competitive. Players score runs against weaker teams and then expect national selection. We need to reduce the Premier League to six or seven competitive teams and ensure regular competitions at every level, including First Division and Premier League.

We simply do not play enough cricket. We occasionally beat Pakistan and Sri Lanka, but if things continue this way, Scotland and Ireland could eventually start beating us.

DS: Why have the Tigresses made little progress since winning the Asia Cup in 2018?

SI: We need facilities similar to those developed for men's cricket, such as the infrastructure at Mirpur. What do we currently have for women's cricket? While preparing for the Asia Cup and Asian Games, we were sent to the Cricketers' Academy. There was no indoor facility or suitable training arrangement for the rainy season in August.

DS: What is your biggest regret from your tenure?

SI: What hurts me most is that only around half of our first eleven have good fitness levels. These are our main players, yet I could not address the problem. It may take another three or four years to get things right.

Only problem is food: India coach

SPORTS REPORTER

Despite securing a SAFF Championship semifinal berth with consecutive wins over Pakistan and Maldives, India coach Naushad Moosa has expressed dissatisfaction with the food provided in Dhaka.

Speaking after Wednesday's 1-0 victory against Maldives at the National Stadium, Moosa noted that while general hospitality is fine, the daily repetition of meals is problematic for players requiring proper post-match nutrition.



"Hospitality-wise, everything has been fine. The only problem we are facing is with the food," Moosa said. "After a game, players need good food. On matchdays, they don't eat much before the game, so they need a proper meal afterwards. But when we go there, it's the same food every day."

These remarks align with widespread social media criticism regarding the tournament's food and accommodation arrangements. Maldives coach Istvan Urbanyi echoed these sentiments post-match, stating that current provisions fall short of the standards set by previous SAFF events.

The complaints have highlighted the tournament's administrative divide. While SAFF is the primary organizer and the BFF provides logistical support, TSA Sports and Entertainment holds the commercial rights and manages team travel and accommodation.

Moosa confirmed that while breakfast issues have been resolved, India's team management is still negotiating improvements for lunch and dinner. Additionally, he clarified that the squad has encountered no security issues in Dhaka, though players have been restricted from exploring the city.





Italy host France in Nations League

STAR SPORTS DESK

Two European giants collide on Thursday evening at Milan's iconic San Siro as Italy host France in their penultimate UEFA Nations League Group A1 fixture tonight.

Following a 1-1 stalemate in Paris earlier this campaign, top spot is at stake. Les Bleus sit atop the standings with 10 points from four matches. Aside from dropping two points against the Azzurri, Zinedine Zidane's tenure has been nearly flawless, featuring two victories over Belgium and another against Turkey. A win at San Siro will officially secure first place and quarterfinal qualification before they host Turkey on Sunday in Bordeaux.

However, uncertainty looms over Kylian Mbappe. The 27-year-old France captain and Real Madrid forward, who missed France's last three fixtures through injury, did not train with the team yesterday.

Roberto Mancini's Italy sit second with seven points, rebounding from an opening 2-0 defeat to Belgium with two wins and a draw. Currently occupying a knockout-stage berth, the Azzurri hold a precarious one-point edge over Belgium, whom they visit next in a potentially decisive finale.

While both nations secured 3-1 away victories against each other in the 2024–25 Nations League, France lead 4-2 in their head-to-head record since their shootout heartbreak in the 2006 World Cup final.

Bavuma wary of Tigers' 'fast bowling resource'

STAR SPORTS DESK

South Africa captain Temba Bavuma warned his team to prepare for Bangladesh's fast-bowling resources ahead of their two-match Test series, starting November 15. .

Bavuma noted their 2024 series sweep in Bangladesh sparked the momentum that culminated in their maiden World Test Championship (WTC) title in the last cycle.

"That series against Bangladesh in Bangladesh was pivotal in our journey or quest to get into the WTC final. It gave us a lot of confidence as a group and also individually," Bavuma told SuperSport.

Yet, he insists complacency has no place against the Tigers. "I look at the venues that we'll be playing, the Bangladesh team, the Highveld [in southern Africa], and we know how it offers assistance for fast



bowling. And I think they have that resource in terms of fast bowling," he said.

Bangladesh's pace squad includes Taskin Ahmed, Hasan Mahmud, Shoriful Islam, Ebadot Hossain, and Khaled Ahmed, while the Proteas have six pacers in their ranks – including Kagiso Rabada, Anrich Nortje, Marco Jansen – to dismantle the Tigers' batting lineup.

The visitors face a daunting historical barrier, having lost all eight previous Tests in South Africa. The opening Test marks Bangladesh's debut at Johannesburg's Wanderers Stadium, with the second beginning November 23 at Centurion's SuperSport Park.

To counter the bowling threat, Bavuma stressed his batters must be flawless.

"So from a batting point of view, I mean, we'll have to make sure that we tick that box in terms of our preparation and mentally not take anything to chance," Bavuma said.

"I think now you look across the world, there's no team that's an easy team. You know, teams on their day can put teams under pressure. And I think you want to make sure that you're not caught with your pants down."

WHAT TO WATCH

T SPORTS

Pakistan vs Sri Lanka
1st Test, Day four
Live from 10:30 am

SONY SPORTS 1, 2, 5

ACC U-19 Asia Cup
Semifinals
Bangladesh vs Pakistan
India vs Afghanistan
Live from 11:00 am
UEFA Nations League
Italy vs France
Live from 1:45 am (Friday)
England vs Croatia
Live from 1:45 am (Friday)
Czechia vs Spain
Live from 1:45 am (Friday)





‘Fascist Awami forces’ will never return

Says Salahuddin; Shafiqur challenges remarks on foreign intelligence links

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

Home Minister Salahuddin Ahmed yesterday said the “fascist Awami forces” that fled Bangladesh following the mass uprising would never return.

In a statement in parliament under Rule 300, he said law enforcers would take necessary measures during operations,



exercising their right of private defence.

He called for national unity against attempts to destabilise the country and sought cooperation from opposition parties, other political parties and citizens to improve public security.

He said programmes announced from across the border, whether protests, strikes or otherwise, aimed to create instability.

“To resist the fallen fascist forces, uproot them completely and prevent the implementation of any of their programmes or conspiracies, national unity is essential above all else.”

“The Nazis could not return to Germany or engage in politics again. Likewise, the fascist Awami forces that fled during the mass uprising will never be able to return to Bangladesh,” he said.

Salahuddin recalled that the opposition leader had declared at a programme in Dhaka on September 3, 2024, that his party

SEE PAGE 8 COL 1



Hamza Choudhury celebrates his goal during Bangladesh’s 4-0 win against Sri Lanka in their SAFF Championship fixture at the National Stadium in Dhaka yesterday, with the win setting up a semifinal clash against Pakistan. PHOTO: **BFF**

Keep control of the streets

BNP instructs grassroots

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

The ruling BNP has stepped up its political activities on the streets and planned to maintain its presence throughout December with a series of programmes amid countrywide incidents of crude bomb explosions and arson attacks on vehicles.

“We are not the kind of political party that would simply sit back and wait for the authorities to intervene while a banned party holds processions -- we do not depend on any government force or agency,” said Abdul Quiyum Choudhury, a member of the



BNP chairman’s advisory council.

The party would not remain passive in the face of attempts by the Awami League, whose activities have been banned, to “create unrest”.

“Our leader Tarique Rahman has instructed us not to leave the streets. All our party leaders and activists are on alert, and our presence on the streets remains strong,” said Quiyum, also the Sylhet district BNP president.

As part of its efforts to maintain political activities on the streets, the BNP plans to observe several important occasions throughout December, including Martyred Intellectuals Day on December 14, Victory Day on December 16, the anniversary of

SEE PAGE 8 COL 1

Arson attacks target vehicles, train carriage

Grameen Bank Pabna branch set on fire; police, BGB members attacked in Teknaf

STAR REPORT

At least three vehicles and a train carriage were set ablaze in three districts, including Dhaka, between Tuesday night and yesterday morning.

Miscreants also set fire to a branch of Grameen Bank, while two bomb-like objects were recovered in front of its another branch in two other districts.

Incidents of crude bomb blasts and arson attacks targeting buses have continued over the past few days. One person was killed when a parked bus was torched in Faridpur early Tuesday. More than two dozen vehicles, mostly buses, were torched in



The burnt seats inside a carriage of the Titas Commuter train. PHOTO: **STAR**

this period.

Early yesterday, in Dhaka, arsonists torched two parked buses in the Pallabi area. No casualties were reported, said Jalal Uddin Ahmed, officer-in-charge of Pallabi Police Station.

Criminals set fire to a Bikalpa Paribahan bus around 6:10am and fled, the OC said. The flames engulfed the bus before spreading to a nearby Abhijat Paribahan bus.

Locals managed to douse the fire and rain also helped contain the blaze, he said. “We are collecting CCTV footage and hope to identify those involved.”

In Narayanganj, miscreants tried to set fire to a parked truck

SEE PAGE 8 COL 4

NEWS IN FOCUS



Ninety-five-year-old Fulbanu (right) sits with her daughter, Manowara Begum, amid the rubble of their demolished home. PHOTO: **TOUSIF KAIUM**

230 families left homeless in Dhalpur eviction

Residents allege demolition violated HC ruling; DSCC says housing project 80pc complete

HELEMUL ALAM *and* **TOUSIF KAIUM**

On November 4, 75-year-old Sokhina Begum was trying to sell debris from her demolished home to earn some money. Her house had been razed three days earlier, and she managed to raise just Tk 3,500 by selling what she could salvage.

Sokhina said she had lived in the area for 36 years after being relocated from Jasim Uddin Road in Kamalapur, along with several hundred others, during the tenure of former president Hussain Muhammad Ershad.

“I spent Tk 70,000 rebuilding my house after it was demolished earlier during the tenure of former DSCC mayor Sheikh Fazle Noor Taposh,” she said.

Living alone, she makes and sells clay stoves to earn a living, despite having a broken hand. Her son and daughter have been living in their village home for the past decade.

“I feel helpless. I don’t know where to go,” she said.

Like Sokhina, around 230 families have been left homeless following the demolition of their houses at Dhalpur City Polli. Residents alleged that the eviction was carried out despite a High Court ruling directing the authorities not to evict them until proper rehabilitation arrangements were made.

Many of the affected families, most of them economically disadvantaged, said they had lived in the settlement for decades. They appealed to Prime Minister Tarique Rahman and the government to intervene and ensure their rehabilitation.

When these correspondents visited the area on November 4, they found dozens of families living under the open sky.

Fulbanu, 95, said her family had lived in the settlement since being allotted a house during Ershad’s tenure.

“I support my family by collecting scrap materials and begging. Now I am living under the open sky after the city corporation demolished our house,” she said.

She alleged that they had

SEE PAGE 8 COL 4

TIB slams Shahe Alam’s ‘contractors’ gifts’ remarks

Ministry says state minister apologised for his comments

STAFF CORRESPONDENT

Transparency International Bangladesh yesterday condemned remarks by State Minister for Local Government, Rural Development and Cooperatives Mir Shahe Alam that government engineers could accept gifts from contractors, warning that such comments could legitimise bribery in public procurement.

The minister has since apologised and withdrawn his remarks, the ministry said.

Addressing newly appointed assistant engineers of the Local Government Engineering

TRANSPARENCY INTERNATIONAL BANGLADESH
Social movement against corruption

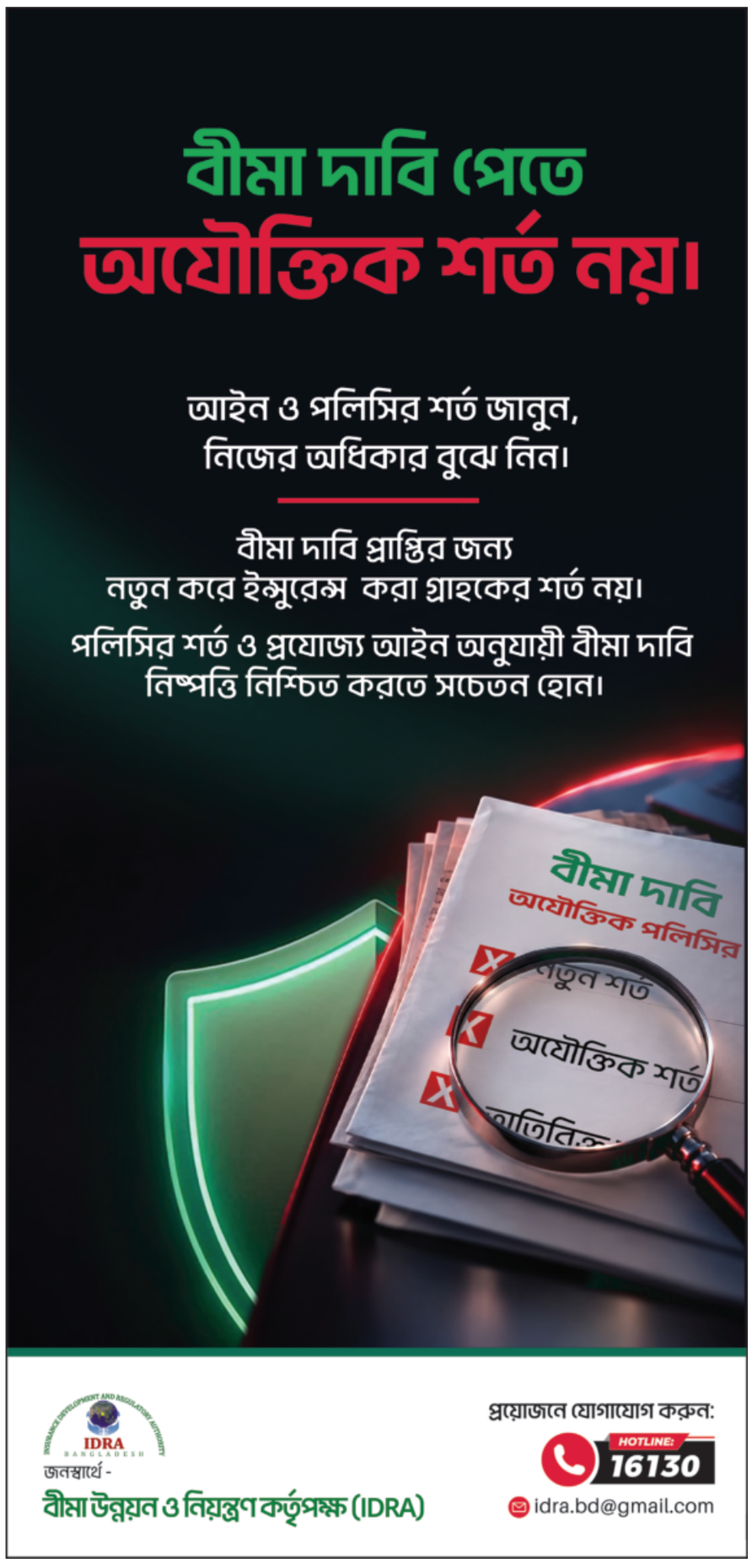
Department last Tuesday, he reportedly said they could accept gifts from contractors’ profits provided work quality was ensured and bills were paid promptly.

Quoting his ministry’s senior secretary, he said, “One day, the [LGD] senior secretary told me that an engineer has no need to take bribes. Once the quality of work is ensured, the contractor’s profit is already factored into the work. If, after promptly taking handover of the work and clearing the bill, the contractor happily gives a gift to the engineer from that profit, it does not count as a bribe. You can certainly accept it.”

Local Government Division Senior Secretary Md Shahidul Hassan was present.

TIB Executive Director Dr Iftekharuzzaman described

SEE PAGE 8 COL 3



Business

DHAKA THURSDAY NOVEMBER 12, 2026, KARTIK 27, 1433 BS
starbusiness@thedailystar.net



B4

SMALL MANUFACTURERS STRUGGLE AS SALES DRY UP

Govt expects to finalise IMF talks by January

Says finance minister

STAR BUSINESS REPORT

The government expects to finalise its discussions with the International Monetary Fund (IMF) by January next year, as it seeks a broader financing programme involving international development partners, Finance Minister Amir Khosru Mahmud Chowdhury said yesterday.

"Work is underway with the IMF. Working groups on both sides are working on it, and we hope to complete the process by January," he told reporters at the National Board of Revenue (NBR) headquarters in Agargaon.

The minister said the government was not looking at the negotiations solely as a means of securing another loan but as part of a broader financing package.

"The issue is not just about a loan; it is a programme," he said.

Bangladesh was working with the IMF, the World Bank, the Asian Development Bank and the Islamic Development Bank on the financing package, he said. The government was also exploring bilateral financing and bond issuances.

Asked whether the negotiations would result in a fresh IMF loan, Khosru said the programme would guide the government's course of action in coordination with development partners.

"The working groups are working on the programme with the IMF, and it will be completed in due time," he said.

The current BNP-led government decided in May to leave the existing IMF programme eight months before its scheduled expiry and pursue a fresh arrangement.

The programme, initially worth $4.7 billion, was signed by the previous Awami League government in January 2023 and later expanded to $5.5 billion under the interim government.

Bangladesh has so far received $3.8 billion in five instalments. The sixth tranche was held up after the IMF suspended discussions in November last year, opting to resume negotiations with the new government after the election.

READ MORE ON B3

Asia takes 70% of trained workers sent abroad

Experts say weak links between training, credentials and employers, rather than destinations, hold back pay-offs for workers

MD ASADUZ ZAMAN

Bangladesh is expanding skills programmes to prepare workers for overseas jobs, and 70 percent of trained workers placed abroad have gone to Asian markets.

Experts say that is not necessarily a weakness. The actual question is whether training leads to skilled, well-paid jobs, as skills mismatches, language barriers and weak global recognition of qualifications acquired from the local institutions get in the way.

Between 2022 and July this year, more than 750 training providers across the country have placed nearly 19,000 trained workers in overseas jobs, according to an internal survey by the National Skills Development Authority (NSDA), the apex regulatory and policymaking body for technical and vocational education, training, and skills development.

NSDA runs under the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) and is responsible for formulating national policies, establishing standard curricula, and quality-assuring the country's fragmented skills development landscape.

Of the trained workers, 70 percent went to Asian markets, while Europe accounted for 17.62 percent and North America for 7 percent. Australia and Oceania recorded 293 placements, Africa 147, and South America just four, shows the NSDA survey.

The authority identified 54 occupations associated with international placements in Asia, compared with 42 in Europe, 31 in North America and 32 in Australia and Oceania.

WHERE ARE BANGLADESH'S TRAINED WORKERS GOING?

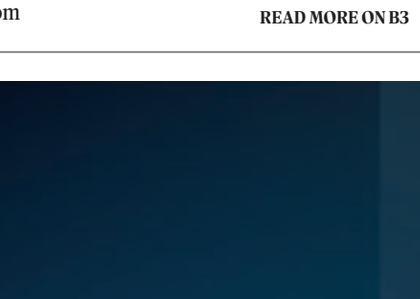
Nearly 19,000 workers placed by more than 750 training providers between 2022 and July 20, 2026

Destination	Workers placed	Share
Asia	13,260	70.46%
Europe	3,315	17.62%
North America	1,406	7.47%
Australia and Oceania	293	1.56%
Africa	147	0.78%
South America	4	0.02%
Total	18,819	100%

SOURCE: NSDA

Nearly seven in every 10 trained workers placed abroad went to Asian markets

What is holding back overseas employment diversification?



These occupations include automotive mechanics, caregiving, electrical installation, machine operation, refrigeration and air conditioning, plumbing, welding, digital marketing and information technology support.

The NSDA does not have placement data by occupation and destination country, so it is not possible to say how many mechanics reached Japan or how many caregivers went to Singapore.

ASIA'S DOMINANCE NOT NECESSARILY A PROBLEM

Asia's dominance is not necessarily a weakness, as the region includes high-income markets such as Japan, South Korea and Singapore, said Niaz Asadullah, a professor of economics at Dhaka University.

"What matters is not the geographical destination but the quality of jobs, wages and employment conditions," he said.

The bigger problem, he argued, is the weak link between training, certification and recruitment. Workers see little return on their investment in training when recruiters ignore their credentials.

A domestic certificate alone will not open doors to Australian or European markets without internationally recognised competencies, language skills and credible links with employers, added Prof Niaz.

He said success should be measured by how many graduates secure skilled jobs abroad and the wages they earn, rather than by the number of people trained.

Similarly, Urmi Jahan Tanni, research manager of the Ovibashi Karmi Unnayan Program (OKUP), said Bangladesh's skills development system remained "disconnected" from labour market demand and overseas employment opportunities.

"Training programmes often lack strong links with employers' actual requirements, particularly in destination countries. A training certificate alone does not guarantee that a worker possesses the competencies, practical experience or qualifications required by international employers," she said.

Urmi identified three priorities for diversifying Bangladesh's overseas labour markets: demand-driven training, the integration of language proficiency and soft skills into vocational courses, and international recognition of skills and qualifications.

"Bangladesh needs to move away from a supply-driven approach towards a demand-driven approach informed by reliable labour market intelligence.

READ MORE ON B3



BB eases import credit terms for Ramadan essentials

STAR BUSINESS REPORT

To help stabilise prices and ensure an adequate supply of essential commodities during Ramadan, Bangladesh Bank (BB) has allowed commercial imports of 10 essential food items under relaxed payment terms.

In a circular, the BB said rice, wheat (flour), onion, pulses, edible oil (soybean and palm oil), sugar, chickpeas, peas, spices and dates could be imported on usance terms for up to 90 days under suppliers' or buyers' credit.

Under usance terms, importers can receive goods before making payment, with up to 90 days to settle the bill. Suppliers' credit allows importers to pay exporters at a later date, while buyers' credit involves financing from a bank or financial institution.

The move comes about three months before the start of Ramadan in February 2027, when demand for these commodities typically rises.

Bangladesh meets most of its requirements for wheat, edible oil, sugar, pulses, chickpeas and dates through imports.

The central bank said the facility would remain effective until March 15, 2027.

StanChart sees 'considerable interest' in sale of retail business

STAR BUSINESS REPORT

Standard Chartered Bangladesh has said it is in talks with some banks regarding the sale of its wealth and retail banking business in the country and sees "considerable interest" among potential buyers.

The multinational bank said it expects a "competitive process" to be followed in the sale.

StanChart, the largest foreign bank in Bangladesh, shared the information yesterday in response to a news story published in this newspaper on November 10. The bank contested the report, saying the headline was 'misleading and sensationalist.'

The foreign bank said it had built its wealth and retail banking franchise over the last 120 years and that the portfolio remained robust and perhaps best in class.

"The reason for us to explore its sale is that we continue to sharpen our focus on where we have

READ MORE ON B3



SPOTLIGHT

Dollar rises against taka as fuel import payments mount

STAR BUSINESS REPORT

The US dollar continues to appreciate against the local currency taka as banks face higher foreign currency payment obligations for fuel and essential commodity imports ahead of Ramadan.

The weighted average interbank exchange rate rose to Tk 124.65 per dollar yesterday from Tk 124.42 a day earlier, according to central bank data.

Bankers attributed the latest increase mainly to higher payments for oil and gas imports, alongside preparations for increased demand for essential food items during Ramadan.

Most private commercial banks quoted the dollar at Tk 124.98 for spot selling and Tk 123.98 for spot buying yesterday.

The pressure comes as the country's import bill has risen sharply, led by fuel purchases.

In the July-September period this year, petroleum product imports increased 105 percent year-on-year to $4.2 billion from $2 billion, accounting for most of the growth in total imports,

READ MORE ON B3

RMG exports to EU up by nearly 3% in Jul-Oct

STAR BUSINESS REPORT

Bangladesh's readymade garment (RMG) exports to the European Union rose 2.79 percent year-on-year to $6.43 billion in the July-October period of fiscal year 2026-27.

Spain was the largest destination market, receiving $1.448 billion, or 22.51 percent of the total, according to data from the Export Promotion Bureau (EPB).

Germany ranked second, with $1.439 billion, accounting for 22.37 percent of the total.

Apparel shipments to the Netherlands and Poland also increased during the period, while exports to the remaining EU countries collectively fell 1.34 percent to $1.60 billion.

The top five markets -- Spain, Germany, the Netherlands, France and Poland -- accounted for two-thirds of Bangladesh's RMG exports to the bloc.

In October alone, Bangladesh's RMG exports to the EU rose 1.10 percent year-on-year to $1.53 billion.

Germany remained the largest single market for the month, ahead of Spain. Exports to France and Poland declined, while those to the Netherlands increased.

READ MORE ON B3

Govt to help restart idle Savar tanneries

Commerce minister says

STAR BUSINESS REPORT

The government will provide technical and financial support to restart tanneries at the Savar leather estate that are yet to start production, Commerce Minister Khandakar Abdul Muktadir said yesterday.

No tannery that fails to comply with environmental regulations will be allowed to operate, he said at an event at Sheraton Dhaka jointly organised by the Netherlands' Centre for the Promotion of Imports from Developing Countries (CBI) and LightCastle Partners.

Every factory of 50,000 square feet or more will have to set up its own effluent treatment plant, he said.

All Savar tanneries must also obtain certification from the international Leather Working Group (LWG), which assesses the environmental performance of leather manufacturers, according to a commerce ministry press release.

On exports, he said Bangladesh exported leather and non-leather goods worth around $1.78 billion last year. He called the European Union an important and promising market and India one of the main buyers.

On cottage, micro, small and medium enterprises (CMSMEs), he said their contribution to GDP was less than one-fourth and needed to rise to at least 60 percent to reduce economic inequality.

Since he assumed office, the allocation for the SME loan refinancing scheme has been raised from Tk 300 crore to Tk 2,000 crore, the minister said. The scheme's loan recovery rate was 98 percent, he added.

Netherlands Ambassador to Bangladesh Joris van Bommel and CBI Managing Director Judith Arends were also present at the event.



Tannery workers carry out leather-processing activities inside a factory. Savar is home to Bangladesh's central tannery industrial estate, which houses the country's relocated tannery units. PHOTO: STAR



Asaduzzaman appointed as CEO of NRBC Bank Securities

STAR BUSINESS DESK

Asaduzzaman has been appointed chief executive officer (CEO) of NRBC Bank Securities Limited, a subsidiary of NRBC Bank PLC, effective Monday.

He has more than 18 years of experience in the financial services and capital market sectors. Since 2010, he has held various key positions at EBL Securities PLC, according to a press release.

During his tenure there, he oversaw the company's overall business operations and played a significant role in its strategic and operational management.

Earlier, he worked as audit, risk and assurance manager at Pacific Jeans Limited.

Alongside his professional responsibilities, Asaduzzaman contributes to developing professional skills and expertise as a resource person at the Bangladesh Academy for Securities Markets (BASM) and other professional institutions.

Southeast Bank, CliniCall launch co-branded healthcare card



Malik Talha Ismail Bari, chairman of CliniCall Limited, and Md Khalid Mahmood Khan, managing director of Southeast Bank PLC, pose for a photograph after inaugurating the cards at a ceremony in Dhaka recently. PHOTO: SOUTHEAST BANK

STAR BUSINESS DESK

Southeast Bank PLC has signed an agreement with CliniCall Limited, an online doctor consultation and community healthcare service provider in Bangladesh, to launch a co-branded healthcare card offering banking and digital healthcare benefits.

The card combines everyday banking services with healthcare benefits through a single Visa card, extending the utility of payment cards beyond financial transactions.

Cardholders can access healthcare services simply by presenting their cards at participating healthcare facilities.

Md Khalid Mahmood Khan, managing director of Southeast Bank PLC, and Malik Talha Ismail Bari, chairman of CliniCall Limited, jointly inaugurated the cards at a ceremony in Dhaka recently, according to a press release.

Cardholders will be entitled to unlimited audio and video consultations with doctors round the clock, 365 days a year.

Other benefits include cashback on hospital expenses and doctor visits, insurance coverage, and discounts of up to 40 percent at more than 300 partner hospitals nationwide.

All benefits are subject to applicable terms and conditions.

Out-of-pocket spending accounts for nearly 70 percent of total healthcare expenditure in Bangladesh, while many families delay treatment because of high costs or limited access to doctors.

The co-branded card aims to address these challenges by providing round-the-clock access to doctors, reducing hospital care costs and offering additional financial protection through insurance coverage.

Abidur Rahman Chowdhury and Md Mahbub Alam, additional managing directors of Southeast Bank; Md Sekander-E-Azam, deputy managing director; Parvez Ahmad, co-founder and chief operating officer of CliniCall; and Saad M Milkan, head of business at the healthcare centre, along with senior officials from both organisations, were also present at the inaugural ceremony.

Citizens Bank holds student banking seminar at Armanitola

STAR BUSINESS DESK

Citizens Bank PLC recently organised a seminar on student banking at Ahameed Bawany Academy School & College in Armanitola, Dhaka, as part of its ongoing initiatives to promote financial literacy and enhance banking awareness among students.

Hasan Kazi Toufiqur Rahman, additional director of Bangladesh Bank, inaugurated the seminar as the chief guest, according to a press release.

The seminar aimed to enhance students' understanding of the fundamentals of banking, the importance of savings and the responsible use of financial services.

The speakers emphasised the importance of developing a savings habit from an early age and encouraged students to become financially aware, disciplined and responsible citizens.

Through this initiative, Citizens Bank PLC reaffirmed its commitment to promoting financial inclusion and strengthening financial literacy among the younger generation.



PHOTO: CITIZENS BANK

Hasan Kazi Toufiqur Rahman, additional director of Bangladesh Bank, poses for a group photograph after inaugurating a seminar organised by Citizens Bank PLC on the premises of Ahameed Bawany Academy School & College in Armanitola, Dhaka recently.

Sammilito Islami Bank merges legal, recovery divisions of five banks



Quazi Shairul Hassan, chairman of Sammilito Islami Bank, inaugurates the bank's newly merged central legal and investment recovery divisions at its head office in Motijheel, Dhaka yesterday in the presence of other officials. PHOTO: SAMMILITO ISLAMI BANK

STAR BUSINESS DESK

Sammilito Islami Bank PLC has merged the legal and investment recovery divisions of five banks into two central units, marking its first major step towards integrating their operations.

The move brings together the respective divisions of EXIM Bank, Social Islami Bank, First Security Islami Bank, Union Bank and Global Islami Bank under a single legal division and an investment recovery division.

The two units were formally inaugurated yesterday at the bank's head office in Motijheel, Dhaka, according to a press release.

Quazi Shairul Hassan, chairman of Sammilito Islami Bank, inaugurated the divisions in the presence of Abedur Rahman Sikder, managing director and chief executive officer of the bank, and Barrister Firoz Hasan, legal adviser to Bangladesh Bank.

NRBC Bank publishes second sustainability report

STAR BUSINESS DESK

NRBC Bank PLC has published its second sustainability report, highlighting its progress in digital banking, rural financial inclusion and environmental protection.

Titled "Innovation Drives Impact", the 2025 report was prepared under the Global Reporting Initiative (GRI) Standards, according to a press release. The report was unveiled on Monday by the bank's Chairman Md Ali Hossain Prodhania at a programme attended by directors and senior executives.

The report highlights the bank's first assessment of financed emissions under the global Partnership for Carbon Accounting Financials (PCAF) framework, which estimated emissions at 74,818 tonnes of carbon dioxide equivalent.

It also shows how digital services have reduced paper use. The bank's automated loan processing system handled 91,840 loans in 2025, saving an estimated 1.2 million sheets of paper and around 150 trees.

In financial inclusion, the bank disbursed Tk 5,533.54 crore in microfinance to 117,994 rural borrowers and provided Tk 270.80 crore to women entrepreneurs during the year. Its digital payment services under government social safety net programmes reached 183,664 beneficiaries.

Speaking at the event, Prodhania said sustainability was central to the bank's long-term resilience. He added that the board was integrating sustainability principles into lending and risk management to support green businesses, renewable energy and environmentally friendly infrastructure.



Md Ali Hossain Prodhania, chairman of NRBC Bank PLC, unveils the bank's 2025 sustainability report, "Innovation Drives Impact", alongside senior executives and directors at a programme in Dhaka recently. PHOTO: NRBC BANK

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নথি নং: এস-৪/৯২/World Bank Group (WBG)/প্রকল্প/২০২০-২১ (অংশ-৪)/ তারিখ- /১১/২০২৬ খ্রি.

১.	কাজের নাম:	কাস্টমস হাউস, চট্টগ্রামের অকেজো ঘোষিত ভবন/স্থাপনার বৈদ্যুতিক সরঞ্জামাদি, বিদ্যমান সাব-স্টেশন, Overhead & Underground Electrical Cable, Wiring Cable এবং অন্যান্য বৈদ্যুতিক সরঞ্জামাদি অপসারণ এবং নির্মাণ এলাকা পরিষ্কারকরণ।
২.	কার্য সম্পাদনের সময়সীমা:	৩০ (ত্রিশ) দিন
৩.	ঠিকাদারের যোগ্যতা:	আগ্রহী ঠিকাদারগণ নিজে অথবা বৈধ প্রতিনিধির মাধ্যমে হালনাগাদ ট্রেড লাইসেন্স (প্রযোজ্য ক্ষেত্রে), আয়কর সনদপত্র, ভ্যাট রেজিস্ট্রেশন সার্টিফিকেটের কপি (প্রযোজ্য ক্ষেত্রে) এবং দরপত্র সিডিউলের মূল্য পরিশোধ সংক্রান্ত এ-চালানের কপিসহ অ্যাসিস্ট্যান্ট কমিশনার (প্রিভেন্টিভ ও প্রশাসন), কাস্টমস হাউস, চট্টগ্রাম বরাবর দরপত্র সিডিউলের জন্য লিখিত আবেদন করবেন।
৪.	দরপত্র সিডিউলের মূল্য:	দরপত্র সিডিউলের মূল্য বাবদ ৩,০০০/- (তিন হাজার) টাকা হারে (অফেরতযোগ্য) কাস্টমস হাউস, চট্টগ্রাম-এর অনুকূলে এ-চালানের মাধ্যমে দরপত্র দলিল ফি খাতে কোড নং-1110203102008-110000000-11001000-1422328-এ জমা প্রদান করতে হবে।
৫.	টেন্ডার সিকিউরিটি:	উদ্ধৃত মূল্যের ১০% (দশ শতাংশ) পরিমাণ অর্থ কাস্টমস হাউস, চট্টগ্রাম-এর অনুকূলে পে-অর্ডার অথবা Bank Guarantee আকারে প্রস্তুতপূর্বক দরপত্রের সাথে সংযুক্ত করে দাখিল করতে হবে।
৬.	দরপত্র সিডিউল বিক্রয় ও প্রাপ্তিস্থান	রাজস্ব কর্মকর্তা (প্রশাসন) এর কক্ষ, কাস্টমস হাউস, চট্টগ্রাম।
৭.	দরপত্র দাখিলের স্থান	দরপত্র গ্রহণের সুবিধার্থে নিম্নবর্ণিত দপ্তরসমূহে সিলকৃত দরপত্র বাক্স স্থাপন করা হবে: (ক) জাতীয় রাজস্ব বোর্ড (NBR); (খ) অ্যাসিস্ট্যান্ট কমিশনার (প্রিভেন্টিভ ও প্রশাসন) এর দপ্তর, কাস্টমস হাউস, চট্টগ্রাম; (গ) কাস্টমস, এক্সাইজ ও ভ্যাট কমিশনারেট, চট্টগ্রাম; (ঘ) কাস্টমস বন্ড কমিশনারেট, চট্টগ্রাম; (ঙ) চট্টগ্রাম বন্দর কর্তৃপক্ষ; (চ) জেলা প্রশাসকের কার্যালয়, চট্টগ্রাম; এবং (ছ) চট্টগ্রাম মেট্রোপলিটন পুলিশ (সিএমপি) কার্যালয়। উল্লেখিত যে কোনো দরপত্র বাক্সে নির্ধারিত সময়ের মধ্যে সিলকৃত দরপত্র দাখিল করা যাবে। নির্ধারিত সময়ের পর প্রাপ্ত কোনো দরপত্র গ্রহণযোগ্য হবে না।
৮.	দরপত্র খোলার স্থান	কাস্টমস হাউস, চট্টগ্রাম
৯.	দরপত্র সিডিউল বিক্রির শেষ তারিখ ও সময়	২৯/১১/২০২৬ খ্রি. তারিখ বেলা ০৫:০০ ঘটিকা পর্যন্ত।
১০.	দরপত্র গ্রহণের শেষ তারিখ ও সময়	৩০/১১/২০২৬ খ্রি. তারিখ বেলা ১২:০০ ঘটিকা।
১১.	দরপত্র খোলার তারিখ ও সময়	নির্ধারিত সময় পর্যন্ত বিভিন্ন দপ্তরে স্থাপিত দরপত্র বাক্সে প্রাপ্ত সকল সিলকৃত দরপত্র সংগ্রহপূর্বক একই দিনে অর্থাৎ ৩০/১১/২০২৬ খ্রি. তারিখে কাস্টমস হাউস, চট্টগ্রাম-এ আনা হবে এবং উক্ত তারিখে বিকাল ৪:০০ ঘটিকায় অ্যাসিস্ট্যান্ট কমিশনার (প্রিভেন্টিভ ও প্রশাসন) এর কক্ষে উপস্থিত দরদাতাগণের সম্মুখে দরপত্র খোলা হবে।

১২। দরপত্র খোলার তারিখে কোন দরপত্র সিডিউল বিক্রয় করা হবে না।

১৩। অনিবার্য কারণ বশতঃ দরপত্র সিডিউল বিক্রয়ের শেষ তারিখ, গ্রহণের শেষ তারিখ বা খোলার তারিখে দরপত্র সিডিউল বিক্রি/গ্রহণ বা খোলা সম্ভব না হলে পরবর্তী কার্য দিবসের উল্লেখিত সময়ে যথাক্রমে দরপত্র সিডিউল বিক্রি/গ্রহণ ও খোলা হবে।

১৪। কাস্টমস হাউস, চট্টগ্রাম কোন কারণ দর্শানো ব্যতিরেকে যে কোন দরপত্র গ্রহণ, বাতিল অথবা কাজ ভাগ করে দেওয়ার ক্ষমতা সংরক্ষণ করে।

১৫। এ দরপত্র The Public Procurement Rules, 2025 অনুযায়ী প্রচলিত হবে।

১৬। অন্যান্য সংশ্লিষ্ট তথ্যাদি জানার জন্য আগ্রহী ঠিকাদারগণ দপ্তর চলাকালীন সময়ে নিম্নস্বাক্ষরকারীর সাথে যোগাযোগ করতে পারবেন।

(মোঃ ইমরান হোসেন)
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GD-2746

Behind Bangladesh's garment boom, workers cut food, healthcare as wages fall short

REUTERS, *Gazipur*

Before dawn each day, garment worker Shilpi Khatun cooks over a wood-fired clay stove because her family cannot afford gas, before heading to a factory in Gazipur, an industrial hub on the outskirts of Dhaka.

The 27-year-old is the sole breadwinner in a household where her husband is unemployed and her parents and in-laws depend on her wages.

Rising prices have left Khatun struggling to afford basic necessities despite five years in the garment industry, a frustration shared by thousands of Bangladesh's garment workers who staged protests last week demanding the minimum monthly wage be raised to 30,000 taka ($242.82) from 12,500 taka.

"Everything costs more now. Rent has doubled, food is more expensive and whatever I earn disappears before the month is over," Khatun said as she gathered leafy greens outside her home to eat with rice for lunch.



Garment workers enter a factory to begin their shift in Baipail, near Dhaka, on November 5, 2026. PHOTO: REUTERS

WAGE PRESSURE MOUNTS

Last week's unrest, some of it violent, forced hundreds of factories to shut down as workers staged protests and clashed with police, who used tear gas and sound grenades to disperse demonstrators.

The government's wage board agreed on November 4 to implement a revised wage structure from December, with workers set to receive their first pay under the new scale in January, but has yet to determine the size of the increase.

Low labour costs have helped make Bangladesh the world's second-largest apparel exporter after China and a preferred manufacturing base for global brands, including H&M, Zara, Gap, Primark and Walmart. The industry generates more than 80 percent of the country's export earnings and employs more than 4 million people.

Manufacturers, however, say a steep wage increase would erode Bangladesh's cost advantage over rivals such as India and Vietnam and further squeeze margins already under pressure from higher energy costs.

Workers also receive a 9 percent annual increment and two festival bonuses in addition to their basic wages, manufacturers say, arguing there is limited room for substantial pay increases.

WORKERS MAKE STARK CHOICES

Workers like Khatun say the wage increase has not kept pace with rising prices, forcing them to make difficult choices over everyday spending.

On the hardest days, Khatun's family survives on puffed rice, she said. Sitting in the small tin-shed room she shares with her husband, she said she had not seen a doctor in three years despite worsening health problems.

Her salary has crept up over five years but not enough to match rising costs. She now earns 13,500 taka ($108), up from 9,000 taka when she started. With overtime, she earns about 16,000 taka, but the money rarely lasts until the next payday, she said.

Bangladesh has faced a prolonged cost-of-living squeeze since 2022, with inflation averaging around 9 percent. Food prices initially drove the surge, but non-food costs have remained high.

"I think twice before buying anything, even food," said Roksana Parveen, a 29-year old sewing operator in a factory in Ashulia on the outskirts of Dhaka.

"I know my daughters should be eating better, but I just can't afford it."

Parveen and her two daughters often live on little more than rice and vegetables, with meat and fish becoming luxuries beyond their reach. To cut costs, one of her daughters dropped out of school.

Gold gains after steep drop

REUTERS

Gold prices climbed on Wednesday, but remained anchored near the $4,000 level after a sharp selloff in the previous session following a hot US inflation print and hawkish policymakers' comments that tilted market expectations towards further and larger rate hikes.

Spot gold rose 0.5 percent to $4,051.31 per ounce by 0916 GMT after dropping as much as 3 percent to $4,013.29 on Tuesday. US gold futures for December delivery gained 0.7 percent to $4,059 per ounce.

"Gold is seeing some slight relief after its post-CPI declines," said Han Tan, chief market analyst at Bybit. "However, it's a tough ask for gold bulls to keep pushing prices higher, given the prospects of more Fed rate hikes in the pipeline."

Dollar rises

FROM PAGE B1

according to Bangladesh Bank (BB) data.

Food imports also increased during the period, with edible oil purchases rising 54 percent and wheat imports climbing 66 percent.

Consequently, the country's trade deficit widened 31 percent year-on-year to $7.48 billion in the first quarter of the current fiscal year, as the fuel import bill more than doubled.

Industry insiders attributed the higher fuel import costs partly to rising global prices amid the Iran war and tensions in the Middle East.

The pressure on the foreign exchange market is also reflected in import financing. Banks opened letters of credit (LCs) worth $7.32 billion in October, while settling import bills of $5.95 billion, according to BB data.

Bangladesh has been grappling with foreign currency shortages and pressure on its exchange rate since 2022, when soaring global commodity prices pushed up import costs and depleted foreign exchange reserves. The taka, which traded at around Tk 85-Tk 86 per dollar in 2021, subsequently underwent several rounds of depreciation.

Recently, the central bank has taken several steps to facilitate imports ahead of Ramadan and prevent shortages of essential commodities.

In a recent directive, BB asked commercial banks to keep cash margins for opening LCs for 10 essential food items at the minimum level, based on their relationships with customers.

The central bank has also allowed commercial imports of these commodities under deferred payment terms of up to 90 days through suppliers' or buyers' credit. The facility is intended to ease the immediate foreign currency payment burden on importers, facilitate supplies, and help contain prices during Ramadan.

Asia takes 70% of trained workers

FROM PAGE B1

Training should be designed around specific occupations and the actual requirements of prospective employers in destination countries," the research manager said.

"Technical competence alone is insufficient for entering many European and other developed-country labour markets. Workers may need to demonstrate proficiency in the destination country's language, communication skills, workplace behaviour, digital literacy and an understanding of occupational safety standards."

Urmi also stressed the need to strengthen the international credibility of Bangladesh's skills assessment and certification systems.

"Even when workers possess relevant practical skills, the absence of recognised qualifications, transparent competency assessment and mutual recognition arrangements can prevent them from accessing formal employment opportunities abroad," she said.

SOME OCCUPATIONS REACH MORE MARKETS

The authority's occupation-wise analysis shows that five occupations have placements across six geographical regions: driving, electrical installation and maintenance, plumbing and pipe fitting, refrigeration and air conditioning, and welding.

Another seven occupations have a presence across five regions, including automotive mechanics, caregiving, computer operation, electronics servicing, food and beverage production and service, machine shop practice, and sewing machine operation.

Several others, including digital marketing, graphic design, housekeeping, IT support, garments, safety and compliance, and sales and customer service, have placements across four regions.

The geographical spread of these occupations suggests scope for Bangladesh to diversify overseas employment beyond its traditional destinations. Caregiving and automotive mechanics, in particular, have a presence across five regions, while digital marketing, IT support, graphic design, and web design and development indicate opportunities beyond traditional manual and technical jobs.

Solar photovoltaic technicians have placements in Asia, Europe and Australia and Oceania, reflecting potential opportunities in markets expanding renewable energy installations.

However, several occupations, including accounting, carpentry, fashion design and product development, knit sewing machine operation, mixing helper, and tourism or tour guiding, remain confined to a single region in the reported data.

TRAINER SHORTAGE LIMITS CAPACITY

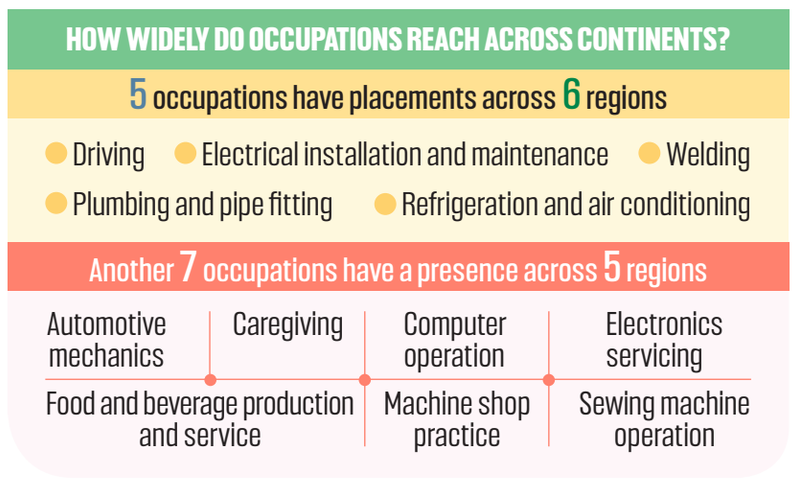
NSDA Executive Chairman Nazneen Kawshar Chowdhury said about 43 percent of training providers were underutilised, partly because of a shortage of qualified trainers.

"Completion-based training does not necessarily produce skilled workers," she said.

"We must focus on competency-based training."

The NSDA currently has nearly 2,700 trainers and aims to build a pool of 10,000 trainers by 2030.

Since launching its certification in 2022, nearly 6.76 lakh people have undergone regular or Recognition of Prior Learning assessments, of whom 4.90 lakh were found competent.



StanChart

FROM PAGE B1

the necessary scale and the most differentiated proposition for our cross-border and affluent clients," said Bitopi Das Chowdhury, country head of corporate affairs and brand and marketing at StanChart.

The foreign bank said it was building the leading super-connector institution for clients operating across borders and remained committed to furthering its Corporate and Investment Banking (CIB) business in Bangladesh.

"We are seeing considerable interest and expect a competitive process to be followed," it said, "For confidentiality purposes, we are unable to comment on who we are in talks with."

StanChart said it had earlier announced that the process would take approximately 18-24 months to complete. "As such, we are very early in any process and will update as and when we have more information."

In a statement in early October, the bank announced the sale of its retail banking business to sharpen its focus on corporate and investment banking.

Govt expects to finalise IMF talks

FROM PAGE B1

On the revenue front, Khosru said income tax and customs collections had each grown by more than 14 percent, while VAT revenue was expanding at a slower pace.

He attributed the comparatively weak VAT growth partly to the recent introduction of a quarterly system, saying the corresponding figures had yet to be reflected in collection data.

He expected VAT receipts to improve in the coming quarters, helping the government meet its annual revenue target.

Asked about revenue shortfalls amid rising government expenditure, the minister said the government was assessing spending decisions based on their economic returns and potential to generate employment.

"Every taka of taxpayers' money that we spend must generate value. It must have a return on investment and contribute to employment creation," he said.

He said expenditure would be managed in line with revenue and that the government was weighing the economic benefits of every spending decision.

"The economy is moving in the right direction. We are on the right course," he said.

On the proposed bifurcation of the NBR, Khosru said the government had already settled the decision and would provide it with a legal basis.

"Bifurcation is a settled matter. It can easily be given a legal shape," he said.

Asked whether the proposal would be placed before parliament, he said, "Whatever is necessary will be done."

Government of the People's Republic of Bangladesh
Local Government Engineering Department
Office of the Executive Engineer
Jhalakathi.
www.lged.gov.bd

Memo: 46.02.4200.000.07.014.26-2057 Date: 10/11/2026

Tender Notice No- 14/2026-27 (LTM: 01-05)

e-Tender is hereby invited in the National e-GP system portal (http://www.eprocure.gov.bd) for the procurement of following work.

Sl. No.	Tender ID	Name of the work with Package No	Method of Procurement	Date of Publication	Last Date of Selling	Last Date of Receiving Tender
01	1354594	**LGED/GOBM/JLK/26-27/RW-19** Periodic Maintenance of Kaikhali GC-Amua GC via Goserhat Road from Ch 3000m - Ch 5500m [Road ID 542432005] [KATHALIA]	LTM	12-Nov-2026	29-Nov-2026 12:00	30-Nov-2026 12:00
02	1354593	**LGED/GOBM/JLK/26-27/RW-21** Rehabilitation of Mollar Hat RHD - Sreemontokathi-N-Pingri via Balarjore Hat GC from Ch 8277m - Ch 11287m [Road ID 542842004] [RAJAPUR]	LTM	12-Nov-2026	29-Nov-2026 12:00	30-Nov-2026 12:00
03	1354576	**LGED/GOBM/JLK/26-27/RW-12** Rehabilitation of Goyalkati - Kandopasa from Ch 00m - Ch 915m [Road ID 542735099] [NALCHITY]	LTM	12-Nov-2026	29-Nov-2026 12:00	30-Nov-2026 12:00
04	1354575	**LGED/GOBM/JLK/26-27/RW-14** Rehabilitation of Shirjughat(St. from UZR2005)-Amrajuri Ferryghat Road from Ch 00m - Ch 1390m [Road ID 542404178] [JHALOKATHI-S]	LTM	12-Nov-2026	29-Nov-2026 12:00	30-Nov-2026 12:00
05	1354570	**LGED/GOBM/JLK/26-27/CW-03** Rehabilitation of 01 No. Single Vent 2.50mx2.50m RCC Box Culvert on Nizamia high School- North Palot Launch Ghat via Baroia high school Road at Ch.920.00m [Road ID 542844139] [RAJAPUR]	LTM	12-Nov-2026	29-Nov-2026 12:00	30-Nov-2026 12:00

e-Tender will be accepted in the National e-GP portal and no offline/hard copies will be accepted. To submit e-Tender, registration in the National e-GP system portal (http://eprocure.gov.bd) is required. The fees for downloading the e-Tender documents from the National e-GP System portal have to be deposited online through any registered bank's branches. Details, information and guidelines are available in the National e-GP System portal and from e-GP Help Desk (helpdesk@eprocure.gov.bd).

12/11/26
(QUAZI MAHMUDULLAH)
Executive Engineer
Phone: 02478875494
e-mail: xen.jhalokathi@lged.gov.bd

GD-2741

CIVIL AVIATION AUTHORITY OF BANGLADESH
Office of the Director
Shah Amanat International Airport, Chattogram.

e-Tender Notice (OTM)

S/N	Tender ID	Reference No.	Name of Works	Tender Closing Date & Time	Remarks
1.	1363712	30.31.0000.000.211.32.0347.22.669	Supply of Pallet for Cargo Operation at SAIA, CTG.	22-Nov-2026 12:30:00	

This is an online tender, where only e-Tenders will be accepted in e-GP portal and no offline/hard copies will be accepted. To submit e-Tender, please resister on e-GP system portal. (http://www.eprocure.gov.bd)

স্মারক নং-৩০.৩১.০০০০.০৫১.১১.০০১.২৬/৫৯৮
তারিখ: ১১/১১/২০২৬ খ্রি.

Group Captain Md. Nur Hossain
Director
Shah Amanat International Airport, Chattogram.

GD-3740

RMG exports

FROM PAGE B1

Earlier, Bangladesh's RMG exports to the EU had fallen 16.43 percent year-on-year to €8.64 billion in January-June 2026, according to Eurostat, the bloc's statistical office.

During the six-month period, export volumes fell 8.22 percent year-on-year, while prices declined 8.94 percent.

Spain had overtaken Germany as Bangladesh's largest EU market for RMG in July-September of FY2026-27, with exports rising nearly 14 percent year-on-year to $1.14 billion. Exports to Germany stood at $1.12 billion, registering a marginal decline of 0.15 percent.

Small manufacturers struggle as sales dry up

Rising costs, weak demand and costly loans threaten businesses and jobs

JAGARAN CHAKMA



A leather goods shop in Hazaribagh displays shoes, bags and belts as small manufacturers struggle with weak consumer demand, rising production costs and expensive loans, threatening businesses and millions of workers' livelihoods. The photo was taken recently.

PHOTO: COLLECTED

Forida Yesmin Bithi has a factory employing 14-15 workers, machinery capable of producing goods worth Tk 12 lakh a month, and customers in overseas markets. Yet, last month, her leather goods business generated less than Tk 1 lakh in sales, against monthly expenses of Tk 1.5 lakh to Tk 2 lakh.

Bithi is one of many small manufacturers across Bangladesh struggling to keep up as orders run dry, production costs rise, and borrowing becomes more expensive. Some are accumulating losses, while others are considering layoffs or struggling to pay workers on time.

Their difficulties reflect wider pressures on the country's small and medium enterprises, where weak consumer demand, high inflation and limited access to affordable finance are threatening businesses and livelihoods.

Bithi started her Dhaka-based business in 2020 with Tk 3 lakh, two machines and one assistant. Her company now sells products in Malaysia and Italy through export intermediaries. But declining orders, particularly from corporate clients, have pushed the business into losses.

"Last month, our sales did not even reach Tk 1 lakh, while the monthly expenses for the factory and showroom stand at around Tk 1.5 lakh to Tk 2 lakh," she said.

The shortfall has made it difficult to pay workers' salaries and loan instalments. Bithi took a Tk 10 lakh loan from Shahjalal Islami Bank for five years, with monthly instalments of Tk 19,000 to Tk 20,000. She has also borrowed elsewhere to cover operating costs.

Much of her factory's monthly production capacity now remains unused.

For Golam Morsalin, managing partner of Collagen Bangladesh, rising input costs and unreliable electricity supply have squeezed margins and disrupted production.

Power cuts lasting three to four hours, two to three days a week, regularly interrupt manufacturing and affect colour matching, which requires natural daylight.

A stronger US dollar and higher electricity tariffs have raised raw material and production costs, while selling prices have remained largely unchanged.

"We are spending more but producing less, while selling prices have not increased accordingly," he said.

The business, which previously earned around Tk 15 for every Tk 100 in sales, now loses about Tk 10. Over the past three months, it has accumulated losses of nearly Tk 1.6 crore, while monthly revenue has fallen from around Tk 10 lakh to Tk 8 lakh. Morsalin is considering laying off three to four of his 14 workers.

Weak consumer spending has also hit Ashit Chowdhury, a Rangpur-based jute products manufacturer operating under the brand Apon.

"In 2023, our monthly sales averaged Tk 12 lakh to Tk 15 lakh, depending on the season. But last year, they fell to around Tk 7 lakh, and there has been little improvement since," he said.

M Masrur Reaz, chairman and CEO of Policy Exchange Bangladesh, said high inflation has raised operating costs and eroded purchasing power, while higher interest rates have made borrowing more expensive

Ashit's business produces shataranji, bags and decorative items. Despite the downturn, he has no plans to lay off his 70 workers. However, he owes Tk 60 lakh to BRAC Bank and BASIC Bank, with monthly instalments of Tk 1.30 lakh, and sometimes struggles to pay salaries on time.

For Paritos Kumar Malo, proprietor of Faridpur-based RK Metal, the slowdown in government projects and agricultural supply programmes has sharply reduced orders for agricultural machinery.

"Business is almost nonexistent. Tenders have stopped, several projects have stalled, and government supplies have dried up. Whatever little business remains is barely enough to get by," he said.

Paritos has outstanding loans with Sonali, Rupali and Prime banks, with monthly instalments ranging from Tk 1 lakh to Tk 1.5 lakh. He often struggles to make payments on time.

M Masrur Reaz, chairman and CEO of Policy Exchange Bangladesh, said the difficulties reflected structural weaknesses in the small and medium enterprise (SME) sector. SMEs contribute around 25 percent of GDP in Bangladesh, compared with 50 percent in many economies and 70-80 percent in some industrialised countries, he said.

The sector has faced mounting pressure since macroeconomic difficulties emerged in 2022-23. High inflation has raised operating costs and eroded purchasing power, while higher interest rates have made borrowing more expensive.

Rising non-performing loans have also made banks increasingly cautious about lending to smaller businesses.

"Financial institutions already considered lending to small businesses relatively risky. With the deterioration in the overall economic environment, their perceived risk has increased further, making access to finance even more difficult," Masrur said.

Regulatory barriers also discourage micro and cottage businesses from entering the formal economy, limiting access to institutional finance. Stronger links with large corporations and exporters could help smaller firms secure orders and integrate into wider supply chains, he added.

According to the SME Foundation, cottage, micro, small and medium enterprises (CMSMEs) contribute around 30 percent to the economy.

The Economic Census 2024 shows they account for nearly 99 percent of industrial establishments and around 85 percent of industrial employment, providing jobs to more than 3 crore people.

Md Nazeem Hassan Satter, managing director (additional charge) of the SME Foundation, said the organisation was concerned about the difficulties facing entrepreneurs.

Guarding the corporate purse against related party deals

SNEHASISH BARUA

In financial markets, trust is the primary currency. When everyday citizens invest their savings in a listed company, they trust the money will be used to grow the business and generate fair returns. Historically, however, corporate funds have rarely been siphoned off through midnight theft. Instead, money most often leaves companies in broad daylight through seemingly normal arrangements known as related party transactions (RPTs).

An RPT occurs whenever a company does business with its directors, major shareholders or their families, such as buying from a sister concern or lending to an affiliate. Many are genuine, but all carry a conflict of interest. Unchecked, assets can be bought at inflated prices or sold too cheaply, moving wealth into private hands while public shareholders bear the loss. Recognising this risk, the Bangladesh Securities and Exchange Commission (BSEC) has made RPT oversight central to its draft Corporate Governance Rules, 2026. This welcome, proactive initiative invites public suggestions to make the safeguards watertight.

Rule 21 proposes a three-step review: the audit committee recommends, the board approves, and shareholders decide at a general meeting if most directors are interested. This creates clear accountability, but several details need strengthening to close loopholes. First, approval should come before the deal.

Rule 21 asks companies to place RPTs "periodically before the audit committee", usually months after a contract is executed and paid. Review after the fact turns oversight into a post-mortem. The rules should require prior audit committee and board approval, with annual "omnibus approvals" for routine supplies.



The draft corporate governance rules need stronger safeguards to prevent related party deals from diverting company funds at the expense of shareholders

Second, the rules need clear thresholds. A material RPT should be defined as exceeding 1 percent of tangible assets or 10 percent of turnover, with all contracts with one entity aggregated. Otherwise, a Tk 100 crore contract could be split into ten Tk 10 crore deals to bypass oversight.

Third, funds go to counterparties that appear unconnected because no director or sponsor is named on paper. A mandatory ultimate beneficial ownership register, proposed in pending amendments to the Companies Act, 1994, would help boards and regulators identify the natural persons in control.

Fourth, setting a fair price is hard without open bidding, so material deals should require an independent valuation or fairness opinion as an objective benchmark. Fifth, shareholders should vote on all material deals. The draft sends an RPT to them only if most directors are interested, so a contract involving significant company assets could bypass them if only two of six are interested.

Sixth, interested shareholders should be barred from voting. Founding sponsors often own 40 to 60 percent of shares, so approval is practically guaranteed if they can vote. Any director, sponsor or investor with a stake should be excluded, leaving independent and minority shareholders to decide. A BSEC notification of March 22, 2021, already set the 1 percent and 10 percent thresholds, required shareholder approval and barred interested parties from voting. If the 2026 rules are published as drafted, companies might argue they relax that directive, so the final rules should preserve these principles.

Regional markets already do this. India requires prior audit committee approval and bars related parties from voting on deals above 10 percent of turnover, while Malaysia and Sri Lanka require fairness opinions and votes by non-interested shareholders. Closing these gaps will not hinder business; it will give ethical enterprises a clear framework and investors genuine confidence. Sound governance transforms our capital market into an attractive, resilient home for long-term investment.

The writer is the managing director of SMAC Advisory Services Ltd. He can be reached at snehasish@smac-bd.com

Many AI companies will adopt advertising

Says ad agency CEO

AFP, *Lisbon*

Many AI platforms will end up eventually adopting advertising, the head of the online advertising agency Criteo told AFP Tuesday, as investors are focused on whether the technology will ever be profitable.

"I believe that a lot of AI platforms will find their way to advertising models over time," said the group's chief executive Michael Komasinski on the sidelines of the Web Summit in Lisbon.

"Advertising is the most scalable business model in the world. It has paid for most of the large platforms that we all use and enjoy today, whether it's Google, Meta, Snapchat.

"The ad formats will continue to become more interesting, more innovative, and certainly more native to that conversational experience," he added.

Pressure to boost revenue to cover its colossal spending pushed OpenAI to begin testing advertising in ChatGPT in February in the United States for free and low-cost tier subscriptions.

It has subsequently begun to progressively roll out ads worldwide, in cooperation with Criteo.

OpenAI's rival Anthropic, which is set to imminently go public with a stock listing, has said it doesn't plan to integrate advertising in its AI tools due to data protection concerns as well as to protect the interests of its users.

Square Pharma, Square Textiles post higher profits in Jul-Sept

STAR BUSINESS REPORT

Square Pharmaceuticals and Square Textiles, both Square Group entities, reported higher profits on revenue growth in the July-September quarter.

Square Pharmaceuticals' profit for the July-September quarter of 2026 rose 5 percent year-on-year to Tk 778 crore, according to its financial statements.

It posted a net revenue of Tk 2,244 crore for the quarter, a 4 percent year-on-year rise.

Its earnings per share (EPS), which shows the profit attributable to each share, was Tk 8.77 for July-September, against Tk 8.35 for the same period the previous year.

Square Pharmaceuticals' net operating cash flow per share (NOCFPS), which shows the cash generated from day-to-day operations for each share, declined to Tk 5.49 for July-September compared to Tk 7.55 for the same quarter of last year.

In a disclosure on the Dhaka Stock Exchange (DSE) website yesterday, Square Pharmaceuticals said the decline in NOCFPS was mainly because cash costs grew much faster than collections from customers.

Specifically, payments to suppliers and for manufacturing and operating expenses grew at a much faster pace than receipts from customers. Higher income tax payments further reduced net operating cash flow, the company said.

Square Textiles' profit for the July-September quarter rose 28 percent to Tk 42.83 crore, according to its financial statement.

It had posted a revenue of Tk 669 crore for the period, a 10 percent year-on-year rise.

Its EPS was Tk 2.17 for July-September 2026, against Tk 1.69 for July-September 2025. The company said in a disclosure on the DSE that EPS increased because of a rise in yarn prices.

Square Textiles' NOCFPS was negative Tk 3.66 for July-September 2026, against negative Tk 0.90 for the same period last year. A negative figure means the company spent more cash on operations than it generated.

Shares of Square Pharmaceuticals declined 0.27 percent to Tk 218.7 as of 12:39 pm on the DSE.

Square Textiles' share increased 3.20 percent to Tk 54.90 as of 11:57 am yesterday.

War to cost Gulf over $200b in damage, $790b losses until 2030: insurer

AFP, *Dubai*

The US-Iran war will cost Gulf countries more than $200 billion in damage and economic losses could reach nearly four times that amount by 2030, insurer Allianz Trade said on Wednesday.

Gulf countries bore the brunt of Tehran's wrath after the United States and Israel launched attacks on Iran on February 28, triggering the war.

In retaliation, Iran restricted shipping in the key strait of Hormuz and struck civilian infrastructure including airports, seaports, energy facilities, landmarks and American assets in the US-allied countries.

"Physical damage across the region is assessed just above $200bn, mostly concentrated in Hormuz-locked economies, especially in energy infrastructure," the insurer said in a report.

More than 80 energy facilities were hit in the war, mostly in Kuwait, Qatar and Bahrain, the report said, with a third of them "severely damaged".

Beyond physical damage to energy infrastructure, the war has affected other sectors like tourism and real estate, which will see slower growth over the years.

"The total cost of the war for the GCC is set to reach $790bn, a cumulative gap of 5.9 percent of GDP relative to the pre-war trend through 2030," the report said.

"This reflects the cumulative loss of economic output over 2026-30, the difference between what the region was forecast to produce on its pre war-growth trend and what it is now projected to produce post-war," it said.



DHAKA THURSDAY NOVEMBER 12, 2026, *KARTIK 27, 1433 BS* | A PUBLICATION OF The Daily Star

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NAVIGATING UNIVERSITY ADMISSIONS TESTS

PHOTO: PRABIR DAS



MOVIES

TONY

A coming-of-age film through the lens of a biopic

SHARAR CHOWDHURY

**This review contains spoilers*

I went into *Tony* knowing very little about Anthony Bourdain. I knew he was loved in the food world, that his television shows took him all over the planet, and that he once shared a plastic-stool dinner with a US president, Barack Obama, in Hanoi. I also knew about his death in 2018 and how hard it hit people far beyond the kitchen. That turned out to be the right amount to know, because *Tony* is not interested in any of it.

Directed by Matt Johnson, the film takes a few pages of *Kitchen Confidential,* Bourdain's 2000 memoir, and stretches them into a single summer in 1975. Anyone expecting a kitchen drama in the mould of *The Bear*, all brigades and shouting, will not find it here. Instead, it is about a 19-year-old who does not yet know who he is.

That 19-year-old, played by Dominic Sessa, wants to be a writer, and the film opens with him pitching himself for a fellowship that would take him to New York. He is arrogant about it and certain he has won. He has not. Rather than tell anyone, he lies to his family and follows a girl, played by Emilia Jones, to Provincetown, only to find she already has a boyfriend. So, he drinks, picks fights, and lives entirely in the moment, which is how he gets himself thrown out of a seafood restaurant by its chef.

That chef, named Ciro, played by Antonio Banderas, becomes



the first of two men who shape the rest of Tony's summer. He is principled and devout, takes Tony to Mass, and teaches him the old-fashioned way, with buckets of cold water and the worst jobs in the kitchen.

The second is Sal, a cook played by Leo Woodall. Ciro calls him a "sin eater", which was my favourite line in the film. In old folk tradition in Wales and the English border counties, a sin eater was usually a poor man who paid a few coins to eat bread and drink ale over a coffin, taking the dead person's sins onto himself so their soul could rest. The community needed him and shunned him for it. Sal is the kitchen's version, the one who soaks up everyone else's worst habits, and he strings Tony along with him.

Between them, Ciro and Sal offer Tony two directions, and the film does not explicitly tell you the right one. Nobody in it is purely good or purely bad. Ciro is kind but hard, Sal is fun until he is dangerous, and Tony himself lies, fights, and makes as many poor decisions as good ones. They are simply the people who happened to be around him during the summer that decided who he would become.

That is why *Tony* works better as a coming-of-age film than as a biopic. Take away the famous name and it is a story most of us will recognise: heading somewhere unfamiliar, wanting nothing more than to be loved, telling your family things are going better than they are, and coming out the other side knowing a little more about who you are and what you want to do. By the end, Tony has chosen the kitchen and is taking his first real steps towards becoming a chef.

Most people know what came after: years in New York kitchens, the books, the shows, and the fame. *Tony* is about the summer before any of that was certain. I came out wanting to know how that 19-year-old became the man on the plastic stool in Hanoi, and his books seem like the place to start.

Sharar Chowdhury is learning how to be a manager and believes "I'm confused" is not a complete sentence. Send him emails at: sharar672@gmail.com.

OPPORTUNITIES

Fung Global Fellows Program PRINCETON

Princeton University - Fung Global Fellows Programme 2027-28

ELIGIBILITY

Applicants must have received their PhD (or equivalent) generally after September 1, 2017.

Candidates who are currently enrolled in a PhD programme or employed as postdocs are not eligible to apply.

Fellowships will be awarded to those employed outside the US who have a faculty appointment or a professional research appointment.

Fellowships will be awarded to candidates who have already demonstrated outstanding scholarly achievement and exhibit unusual intellectual promise but are still at the beginning of their careers.

Criteria for the fellowship include the strength of the candidate's research projects, the relationship of those projects to the programme's theme, the candidate's previous scholarly work, etc.

Visit funggfp.princeton.edu to learn more

DEADLINE: NOVEMBER 16, 2026

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HOW GLENRICH INTERNATIONAL SCHOOL PREPARES STUDENTS FOR LIFE

Good grades matter. So do examination results, certificates and university offers. But for students preparing to enter an increasingly competitive world, these are only a part of the bigger picture.

University and professional life require more than academic knowledge. To succeed, students also need to be independent thinkers, good team players, responsible, resilient, and proactive. These are skills that take time to develop. They cannot be built in the final year of school simply by adding more activities.

Teaching and training students in these skills is at the core of Glenrich International School's teaching philosophy. Instead of treating university applications as an afterthought, Glenrich treats them as the goal, and attempts to place students in the top-ranked universities of the world.

At Glenrich, alongside academics, students can begin working on their profiles as early as Grade 8 through the Profile Building Club. The programme encourages them to understand their strengths, explore their interests, take on leadership roles and gradually build experiences that reflect who they are.

"We teach our students that preparing for higher education and life isn't about frantically filling up a portfolio in Grade 12. It's about starting early, understanding yourself, exploring your interests and finding meaningful ways to contribute," said Nafia Akter Tonni, Economics Teacher of Upper-Secondary and Coordinator for Grade 11.

That preparation extends beyond academics. Glenrich has the following clubs: STEAM (Science, Technology, Engineering, Art, and Mathematics), Coding & Graphics, Economics-Accounting-Business Summit, Start Up, Model United Nations (MUN), Girl Up, Foreign Language, Community, Newspaper, Literature & Library, Environmental Society, Student Council, and Well-Being. They can also participate in research projects under the guidance of the teachers and compete in international Olympiads after training in Olympiad clubs. Competitive sports include basketball, swimming, skating, volleyball, handball, cricket, football, table tennis, chess, and gymnastics. Students also learn guitar, drums, keyboard, piano, and violin, along with vocal training. Art teachers teach sketching, illustrating, painting, and even sculpting occasionally. Dance teachers teach a diverse range of dance styles, dance dramas, and forms.

For some Glenrich students, these experiences have gone hand in hand with strong academic results.

Farhan Shahid secured admission to the London School of Economics (LSE). In the latest QS World University Rankings by Subject, LSE ranks #6 globally for Economics and Econometrics. At Glenrich, he served as Deputy Head Boy, was Vice President of the Eco-Acc-Biz Club and earned medals in both Table Tennis and Chess.

Afra Ibnat Mizan led Glenrich Uttara's STEAM Club as President, expanding its membership to 135 students. Her exceptional profile earned her offers from leading universities across the UK, USA, and Canada, including University College London (UCL), where she is pursuing Neuroscience. UCL is ranked joint 8th in the QS World University Rankings 2027. Afra is also a very talented dancer with lots of prizes in dance competitions.

Nishat Tamanna also actively contributed to student life through STEAM and Student Council initiatives. Her outstanding profile earned her admission to Peking University, ranked 13th in the QS World University Rankings 2027, with a fully funded Chinese Government Scholarship for seven years.

"Seeing our graduates advance to top institutions in China, Germany, Japan, USA, Canada, Australia, and the UK reinforces our approach to education. Students truly benefit when strong academic foundations are complemented by opportunities to pursue their interests, take ownership, and mature as individuals," said Ms Shegufta Hasan Khan, Head of Upper-Secondary at Glenrich Uttara.

For Glenrich, preparing students for the future therefore starts well before they begin filling out university applications. It is part of the school experience itself; giving students the academic foundation, experiences and confidence they need to take their next step and make their own way in the world.



EDUCATION

Admission preparation combinations for public uni aspirants



ILLUSTRATION: **SABA ALI HAFIZ**

SHEIKH FABIHA AMREEN

The one thing that is predictable about a student's admission life is how unpredictable it can be. No matter how much effort and time you devote, misfortune can still strike in the gruelling examination halls. As such, it's always a good idea to leave room for alterative options. These are some favourable combinations aspirants can go for based on their main targets.

INSTITUTE OF BUSINESS ADMINISTRATION (IBA), DHAKA UNIVERSITY (DU)

If you are mainly preparing for IBA – DU, then you will naturally be focusing on English along with mathematics and analytical abilities for your admission preparation. This will be more than enough to cover IBA, Jahangirnagar University (JU), and Army IBA (AIBA) as well.

For IBA, Rajshahi University (RU), it differs from student to student based on what your track in HSC was. You will have to go through the basics of science, business, or humanities accordingly, besides the usual English and aptitude tests.

The Faculty of Business Studies (FBS) of Bangladesh University of Professionals (BUP) is also quite similar to it, aside from the fact that it includes a general knowledge portion in its admission test covering mostly the history of Bangladesh and some business-related questions.

The DU C Unit works as a backup if you want to study BBA, but it requires more extensive preparation, as you need to cover several extra subjects depending on your HSC track.

C UNIT (BUSINESS STUDIES UNIT), DHAKA UNIVERSITY

People from all backgrounds can apply for the C Unit; only the subjects differ from track to track. The common subjects to be answered by every track are English and Bangla.

For non-business-background students, their common subject alongside the other two is Information and Communication Technology (ICT). On top of that, you will have to answer higher mathematics if you're from science, and economics if you're from humanities.

For NCTB commerce students, you have to answer questions relating to accounting, fundamentals of business, and finance or marketing. For English-medium students, you have to answer English, advanced English, and a choice of two from accounting, fundamentals of business, economics, and mathematics.

As for backups, there are plenty of business seats outside DU: JU E Unit, Jagannath University (JnU) C Unit, RU B Unit, Chittagong University (CU) C Unit, and the General, Science & Technology (GST) cluster's C Unit all let you continue in business studies.

Since the C Unit already has you preparing for English and Bangla, the most natural combination is the C Unit with the B Unit. The only major extra workload is general knowledge.

ENGINEERING

Engineering aspirants will mainly focus on the core science subjects: physics, chemistry, and higher mathematics. Architecture aspirants, alongside these, will have to master the freehand drawing test.

For engineering aspirants, right after Bangladesh University of Engineering and Technology (BUET), it goes: Rajshahi University of Engineering and Technology (RUET), Chittagong University of Engineering and Technology (CUET), Khulna University of Engineering and Technology (KUET), and Shahjalal University of Science and Technology (SUST), in no particular order, as subject preference and distance will start to factor into choosing one over the other.

If remaining near Dhaka is a priority, then Islamic University of Technology (IUT), Bangladesh University of Textiles (BUTEX), and Military Institute of Science and Technology (MIST) are fantastic options, where students will only need to study English as an extra workload. This way, they can also cover the DU A Unit exam, as they can skip their fourth subject (in this case, biology) and answer English or Bangla instead.

A lot of people take on extra biology preparation so they can also sit for medical and other biology-based units. Those who do can sit for the cluster examination for agricultural universities as well, without any additional studies.

MEDICINE

Medicine is, in my opinion, the most cutthroat track one can pick for their admission journey, as there aren't many backup plans if you want to study at a public university. If they want to stay on course to become doctors, medical aspirants can mainly rely on the dental college test, which shares the same admission test, and on the Armed Forces Medical College (AFMC), Army Medical Colleges (AMC), and Navy Medical College, Chattogram (NMCC), which admit students through AFMC's own process.

But if they want to remain in the science stream, they can go for the DU A Unit and other universities' science units. They will have already studied biology, chemistry, and physics, so they would only need extra preparation in English or Bangla instead of higher mathematics.

But if they do decide to study higher mathematics as well, they can sit for a cluster examination for agricultural universities.

The other respite medical aspirants have is the ability to sit for their admission test once more the following year as second-timers.

A UNIT (SCIENCE UNIT), DHAKA UNIVERSITY

Those who want to study pure science must master the core subjects: physics and chemistry. But DU A Unit offers some breathing room in the form of a fourth subject choice, where students can forgo their optional subject and answer English or Bangla instead. This swap applies only to higher mathematics or biology, depending on which was your optional subject in HSC.

JU makes this even easier by dividing the sciences into the Faculty of Mathematical and Physical Sciences and the Faculty of Biological Sciences right at the admission test, into an A Unit and a D Unit, respectively. A Unit focuses on physics and higher mathematics, while the D Unit focuses on botany and zoology. The same goes for Khulna University (KU) A and B Units.

The agriculture cluster needs both higher mathematics and biology, so this only holds if the student has prepared both rather than swapping one for English or Bangla. Some universities may have compulsory ICT questions, but these can be overcome with a light brush-up of the HSC-level ICT subject.

B UNIT (ARTS, LAW, AND SOCIAL SCIENCES UNIT), DHAKA UNIVERSITY

For people who want to change their track to the humanities, they can go for B Unit, but not all universities let students from other tracks sit for the examinations. For everyone, though, the subjects to study remain the same: English, Bangla, and general knowledge. If you are from an English-medium background, you would answer advanced English instead of Bangla.

The good news is that this one preparation carries you through a large number of exams. RU A Unit and the GST cluster's B Unit (21 universities) follow the same pattern of Bangla, English, and general knowledge. The CU B Unit and KU C Unit use the same subjects, though with different mark distributions. The same goes for BUP's Faculty of Arts and Social Sciences (FASS) and Faculty of Security and Strategic Studies (FSSS).

However, it does not remain the same everywhere. Several universities include a mathematics or reasoning section that catches humanities students off guard. For example, the JU B Unit, JnU D Unit, SUST B Unit, and CU D Unit all include a mathematics or analytical portion, which can be overcome with just basic arithmetic and IQ-style mathematics practice.

A few universities also add a subject-based portion. JU C Unit and Comilla University B Unit both have a 40-mark section on subjects related to the departments or your stream, so check the syllabus before you assume your preparation is complete.

Whatever path you may choose, may the odds be ever in your favour.

All information has been collected from the 2025-2026 admission circulars.



PHOTO: **ORCHID CHAKMA**

EDUCATION

How to stay sane during ADMISSION SEASON

IRFAN HOSSAIN

They say the three most important phases of life are birth, marriage, and death. But ask an average Bangladeshi kid, and they will add a fourth: admission season, or at least it feels that way.

You have just finished HSC. You are supposed to relax. Instead, all of a sudden, everybody asks the same questions: Which subjects are you preparing for? Which coaching centres are you going to? Will you go to Dhaka? No matter which answer you give, relatives already have a bunch of advice ready. It seems as though they are more concerned about your academic future than you yourself are. After all, the prevailing belief is that the next three or four months will decide the shape of your entire life.

However, I am here to tell you otherwise. They will not.

As such, here is some advice from a person who has somehow survived this rat race.

FOLLOW YOUR PASSION, ALWAYS

Most students forget this advice. Do not reach for the safe option before you have even asked yourself what you want. Where do you see yourself in 10 years? Does the preparation you are about to start lead you there?

Talk to seniors. Look up what professionals who are already in that field have to say. Then take a deep breath and choose. Do not run toward engineering or medicine simply because that is the race everyone else is running. If you do not love what you study, the regret that awaits you later is heavier than anything admission season can throw at you now.

KNOW YOUR STRENGTHS (AND WEAKNESSES)

Socrates said it best: know thyself. If you have not developed the basics of STEM during HSC, Udvash classes will make that clear within a week. If you do not have the patience to memorise hundreds of facts from a page of a biology book, you will give up medical preparation midway.

See what you are good at, and more importantly, what you are not good at. Prepare for the discipline that suits you best.

CONSISTENCY BEATS EVERYTHING

Not everyone starts from the same place. There will be classmates who have already started counting the ranks they will target in the admission exams. It may seem like you have already lost before it began. Trust me, most people are in the same place as you.

Start with your weakest subject. Make a schedule. Follow it honestly. The only person who can carry you through this is you. The competition may seem overwhelming, but most people will not commit fully until the end. If you go all in, you will be just fine.

SIT FOR PRACTICE EXAMS

This holds true no matter what you are preparing for. In the end, everything narrows down to 90 minutes or two hours in that one room. So, sit for as many exams as you can find. Simulate the pressure before the main exam. Write down every mistake, and make an exam-hall strategy.

Do not get frustrated about your rank in the first few exams. If you are improving, then you are on the right track.

FOLLOW THE PARETO PRINCIPLE

Remember: 80 percent of the exam covers about 20 percent of the syllabus. Study previous years' questions. Find the pattern. Master the most important topics, then move to what you are weak at.

KEEP A PLAN B

This one is an absolute must. The exam you prepared hardest for might still slip away from you. Luck plays its part whether you invite it or not. So, have a backup plan to fall back on. Apply to as many universities as you reasonably can.

Getting into one university will increase your confidence a lot for the upcoming examinations. And in the moments when everything feels uncertain, that confidence is worth more than anything.

REACH OUT FOR HELP

In the moments that frustrate you the most, reach out to the people around you: seniors, friends, and parents. It is the simplest way to hold onto your sanity when everything else feels like it is slipping away.

I owe not losing my sanity to a handful of people who never once made me feel small for needing them: friends who sat through hours of my ranting without asking me to stop, seniors who answered questions I was almost embarrassed to ask, and parents who kept telling me, every single step of the way, that I was going to be fine.

They were right. If their words are anything to go by, you will be fine too.

Irfan spends his time writing, travelling, doomscrolling — and occasionally attending class for a degree he believes will be useful someday. Send him cat reels at: irfan.ink63@gmail.com.

EDUCATION

Public university units: Explained

CAMPUS DESK

Most public universities in Bangladesh admit undergraduates through unit-based tests, where related faculties are grouped under a single exam. Here is how six of them organise their units.

DHAKA UNIVERSITY

Dhaka University (DU) holds its undergraduate admission tests under five units, each tied to a stream of faculties or an institute.

Unit A (Ka) — Science
Built mainly for science students, this unit covers the Faculty of Science (Physics, Chemistry, Mathematics, Statistics and others) and the Faculty of Biological Sciences (Botany, Zoology, Biochemistry and Molecular Biology, Microbiology, Psychology and others). It also includes the Faculty of Pharmacy (Clinical Pharmacy and Pharmacology, Pharmaceutical Chemistry and others), the Faculty of Earth and Environmental Sciences (Geography and Environment, Geology, Oceanography, Disaster Science and Management, Meteorology) and the Faculty of Engineering and Technology (Applied Chemistry and Chemical Engineering, Computer Science and Engineering, Electrical and Electronic Engineering and others).

Unit B (Kha) — Arts, Law and Social Sciences
This unit brings the humanities, social sciences and law together. The Faculty of Arts contributes Bangla, English, History, Philosophy, Arabic, Islamic Studies, Islamic History and Culture, Linguistics, Theatre and Performance Studies, Music, World Religions and Culture, Dance and more. The Faculty of Law adds the Department of Law. The Faculty of Social Sciences covers Economics, Political Science, International Relations, Sociology, Mass Communication and Journalism, Public Administration, Anthropology, Population Sciences, Peace and Conflict Studies, Women and Gender Studies, Development Studies, Criminology and others.

Unit C (Ga) — Business Studies
Aimed at students from a business or commerce background, though eligibility can vary with each year's admission circular. It covers the Faculty of Business Studies: Accounting and Information Systems, Finance, Marketing, Management, Banking and Insurance, Management Information Systems, Tourism and Hospitality Management, International Business, and Organization Strategy and Leadership.

Fine Arts Unit
Focused on creative and visual arts, this unit covers only the Faculty of Fine Art: Drawing and Painting, Graphic Design, Oriental Art, Sculpture, Printmaking, Ceramic, Crafts and History of Art.

Institute of Business Administration (IBA) – DU
The Institute of Business Administration (IBA) admits students through its own unit. Like the Fine Arts unit, its test is held in Dhaka only.

JAHANGIRNAGAR UNIVERSITY

Jahangirnagar University (JU) runs its admission tests under seven units: A, B, C, C1, D, E and IBA-JU.

Unit A — Mathematical and Physical Sciences
Designed mainly for science students, this unit covers the Faculty of Mathematical and Physical Sciences (Computer Science and Engineering, Mathematics, Physics, Chemistry, Statistics and Data Science, Geological Sciences and Environmental Sciences) and the Institute of Information Technology (IIT).

Unit B — Social Sciences
Focused on the social sciences and regional planning, this unit covers the Faculty of Social Sciences: Economics, Government and Politics, Public Administration, Anthropology, Geography and Environment, and Urban and Regional Planning.



PHOTO: ORCHID CHAKMA

Unit C — Arts, Humanities and Law
This unit combines the humanities, law and communication disciplines. It covers the Faculty of Arts and Humanities (Bangla, English, History, Philosophy, Archaeology, International Relations, Journalism and Media Studies), the Faculty of Law (Law and Justice) and the Institute of Comparative Literature and Culture.

Unit C1 — Drama and Fine Arts
A specialised unit for the performing and visual arts, covering only Drama and Dramatics and Fine Arts under the Faculty of Arts and Humanities.

Unit D — Biological Sciences
Tailored for the life sciences, health and medical research, this unit covers the Faculty of Biological Sciences: Pharmacy, Microbiology, Biochemistry and Molecular Biology, Biotechnology and Genetic Engineering, Botany, Zoology, and Public Health and Informatics.

Unit E — Business Studies
For students pursuing core business disciplines, this unit covers the Faculty of Business Studies: Accounting and Information Systems, Finance and Banking, Marketing, and Management Studies.

IBA-JU
The Institute of Business Administration at JU admits its BBA students through a separate unit.

JAGANNATH UNIVERSITY

Jagannath University (JnU) organises its admission tests under five units.

Unit A — Science and Life and Earth Sciences
Tailored for science students, this unit covers the Faculty of Science (Physics, Chemistry, Mathematics, Statistics, CSE) and the Faculty of Life and Earth Sciences (Pharmacy, Microbiology, Biochemistry, Biotechnology, Botany, Zoology, Geography and Psychology).

Unit B — Arts and Law
Focused on the humanities, languages and law, this unit covers the Faculty of Arts and the Faculty of Law.

Unit C — Business Studies
Designed for business administration disciplines, this unit covers the Faculty of Business Studies: Accounting, Finance, Marketing and Management.

Unit D — Social Sciences
Covering the behavioural, political and social sciences, this unit takes in the Faculty of Social Sciences: Economics, Political Science, Sociology, Social Work, Mass Communication, Public Administration and Anthropology.

Unit E — Fine Arts
Dedicated to the visual, creative and performing arts, this unit covers the Faculty of Fine Arts, including its Music and Drama departments.

RAJSHAHI UNIVERSITY

The University of Rajshahi (RU) organises its admission tests under three broad units.

Unit A — Humanities, Arts, Law and Social Sciences
This unit covers the Faculties of Arts, Law, Social Sciences and Fine Arts, along with the Institute of Education and Research.

Unit B — Business Studies
Tailored for commerce and business disciplines, this unit covers the Faculty of Business Studies and the Institute of Business Administration (IBA-RU).

Unit C — Science
Designed for science students, this unit brings together the Faculties of Science, Engineering, Biological Sciences, Agriculture, Geosciences, Fisheries, and Veterinary and Animal Sciences.

KHULNA UNIVERSITY

Khulna University (KU) admits students through four units, each corresponding to one or more of its schools.

Unit A — Science, Engineering and Technology
For engineering, the pure sciences and planning, this unit covers the School of Science, Engineering and Technology, including CSE, Architecture, Urban and Rural Planning, Electronics and Communication Engineering, Mathematics, Physics, Chemistry and Statistics.

Unit B — Life Science
Focused on agricultural, biological and pharmaceutical sciences, this unit covers the Life Science School, including Pharmacy, Biotechnology and Genetic Engineering, Agrotechnology, Environmental Science, Fisheries and Marine Resource Technology, Forestry and Wood Technology, and Soil, Water and Environment.

U**nit C — Arts, Humanities, Social Sciences, Law, Education and Fine Arts**
A multidisciplinary track covering the Schools of Arts and Humanities, Social Science, Law, Education and Fine Arts.

Unit D — Management and Business Administration
Dedicated to commerce and corporate leadership, this unit covers the School of Management and Business Administration.

BARISHAL UNIVERSITY

The Barishal University (BU) admits students through three units under the GST (General, Science and Technology) cluster system.

Unit A — Science and Bio-Sciences
Designed mainly for science students, this unit covers the Faculty of Science and Engineering (Computer Science and Engineering, Mathematics, Physics, Chemistry, Geology and Mining, Statistics and Data Science) and the Faculty of Bio-Sciences (Biochemistry and Biotechnology, Botany, Soil and Environmental Sciences, Coastal Studies and Disaster Management).

Unit B — Humanities, Social Sciences and Law
This unit combines humanistic, social and legal disciplines. It covers the Faculty of Arts and Humanities (Bangla, English, Philosophy, History), the Faculty of Social Sciences (Economics, Political Science, Public Administration, Sociology, Mass Communication and Journalism) and the Faculty of Law.

Unit C — Business Studies
For students pursuing core business disciplines, this unit covers the Faculty of Business Studies: Accounting and Information Systems, Finance and Banking, Marketing, and Management Studies.

EDUCATION

SHOULD YOU TAKE ENGINEERING AND IBA PREPARATION AT THE SAME TIME?

FAIZA ZARIN ZAARA

Every year, when admission season rolls around, students are faced with the difficult decision of selecting which stream of higher education they wish to pursue. Each field, be it STEM, arts and humanities, or business studies, requires a completely different approach, mindset, and preparation strategy.

That being said, preparing for multiple fields or academic tracks is a common strategy among students. A notable trend here is seen among science background students who usually target engineering programmes as their primary objective but keep business degrees, particularly at Dhaka University's (DU) Institute of Business Administration (IBA), as an alternative option.

Two years ago, I was in the same boat. My main goal was to get into the Bangladesh University of Engineering and Technology (BUET), so I poured most of my time into engineering preparation while simultaneously preparing for IBA. Looking back, I can tell you that juggling two of the most competitive exams in the country is not for everyone.

THE DUALITY OF THE EXAMS

The first thing you need to understand is just how different the engineering and IBA admission tests are. Engineering admission



PHOTO: **SYED MAHIN IRTEZA**

tests require you to be quick and precise with your problem-solving. You need a deep understanding of HSC-level physics, chemistry, and higher mathematics, and the ability to solve complex equations with significant time constraints. You have to develop a muscle memory for problem types over months of drilling.

On the other hand, IBA is more of an aptitude test which assesses your basic mathematics, English proficiency, and analytical ability. The admission test for DU-IBA also features a "Communication Test" in the second stage, where candidates must answer questions about themselves under pressure.

These are two fundamentally different paths, and most candidates will struggle to constantly switch between them. In my case, my foundation in mathematics, English, and other science subjects was strong, which worked in my favour. But not everyone shares the same starting point.

For Mohammed Tarifur Rahman, who ranked 353rd in BUET and 18th in DU-IBA in the 2025 admission tests, IBA started as little more than a side quest. "In college, my English was pretty good, so I asked myself: how hard could the IBA admission test be?" he recalls. "I bought a few books on English and analytical reasoning and started going through them."

However, once he actually started preparing for the IBA, Tarifur quickly realised how challenging it would be.

"I was confident about my English and mathematics before starting my IBA preparations," he says. "But going through the past IBA admission questions diminished my confidence."

THE STRESS OF THE EXAM TIMELINES

Engineering and the IBA admission tests tend to fall in a very compressed window of time, giving you very little breathing room, usually around 30-40 days.

While candidates pursuing any one of the two tracks can dedicate their time to intensive revising, dual-track candidates have to keep switching between the two, meaning neither preparation gets the push it needs.

In my own experience, I managed to keep my focus intact during the first few months, cracking a few engineering admission tests early. I then shifted my focus to IBA in the month before the admission test and, due to my prior preparation, managed to get through it.

Unfortunately for me, getting into IBA shifted my attention in a way I had not anticipated. I could never fully shift my focus to engineering preparation afterwards, and by the time my BUET admission test came around, I was unable to do the very important last-minute revision it demanded.



PHOTO: **AL ARAF**

Moreover, success or failure in any one of the exams will drastically affect your focus for the next one. Tarifur experienced this first-hand as the transition between the two exams was one of the hardest parts of the journey. "The period between the IBA and BUET admission tests gave me a great deal of pain," he recalls. "After I was almost sure I bombed my IBA exam, I lost all interest in studying."

DIVIDING YOUR TIME

Both engineering and IBA preparation are individually demanding enough to consume your entire day on their own. Engineering preparation is relentless – marathon classes, weekly exams, and solving question banks with thousands of problems. Practising your timing and accuracy is crucial, and it easily eats up most of your day.

IBA preparation also has its own non-negotiables: acquiring English grammar proficiency, quick hand calculation skills (as using calculators is prohibited in the exam), and analytical instinct. These are not skills you can develop in the last minute.

You will need to sit down with yourself, find out your weaknesses and strengths and prioritise your time accordingly. Between the two, I always felt more confident in my aptitude for the IBA admission test. Since I felt that my English and analytical skills were solid, I utilised my time to get better at hand calculations. On the other hand, I identified some big gaps in my chemistry and physics preparation, so the bulk of my day went towards practising equations and physics diagrams.

Zarin Ashraf Moon, who ranked 1072nd in BUET, 19th in BUET Architecture, and 107th in DU IBA admission tests in 2024, does not recommend dual preparation, but for those who will attempt it anyway, she offers a practical framework: "I suggest the 80-20 method. Put 80 percent of your time into engineering preparation and the rest for the IBA preparation."

FINANCIAL COST

Something that easily gets overlooked is the financial commitment of preparing for two admission tests. Most admission candidates will enrol in a single coaching programme, hire a private tutor, or both. The expenses start to add up with the cost of books, question banks, and mock tests. Engineering and IBA coaching classes aren't cheap.

For many families, the admission season is a significant financial burden. Taking the dual route can make the burden heavier, especially if the other option is only being kept as a safety net. So, this is a conversation worth having before taking the double route.

WHAT DO YOU ACTUALLY WANT?

It may feel reassuring to prepare for both engineering and IBA just for the sake of having a safety net. But you have to ask yourself whether you are genuinely interested in pursuing both paths or if you are simply reacting out of societal or family pressure. Aiming for IBA merely because it sounds prestigious when your passion lies in engineering will lead to misplaced effort. The same is true the other way around.

Zarin is direct on this point. "Not only are both admission tests incredibly difficult, but they are also completely different in nature," she says. "Moreover, there is a luck factor in every admission test. In my opinion, it is truly not worth it to prepare for two of the hardest and most competitive exams simultaneously."

If you are truly interested in pursuing either business or engineering as a career, the dual preparation approach might be worth attempting. You, however, need to go in with a clear primary target and know which exam you would rather ace, ensuring that your preparation reflects that. You should also be prepared to drop one track if it no longer feels sustainable.

Faiza Zarin Zaara is probably watching her 3rd movie of the day. Suggest her something niche to hyperfixate on at: faiza.zarin.zaara.317@gmail.com



OPINION

HOW MUCH OF GETTING A JOB COMES DOWN TO LUCK?

ILLUSTRATION: **ABIR HOSSAIN**

SHARAR CHOWDHURY

The process of getting a job, on paper, seems quite simple. Apply every day, tailor your CV, and write a cover letter that ticks every requirement, and a job should follow. However, most of the time, it does not. There are far more applicants than openings, and doing everything right only gets you into the running.

A lot of what decides the rest is luck, and that luck starts the day you are born.

Italian researchers once tried to put numbers on this with a computer model that followed a thousand simulated careers over 40 working years. The most successful person in it was barely more talented than average, and the most talented finished with less than they started with. It is a simple model, but it matches a lot of what I have seen.

Take the family you are born into. Some families have the money to invest in you early. Others have the know-how, knowing that Olympiads, competitions and extracurriculars exist and how to steer a child towards them. A study of 1.2 million inventors in the United States found that children from the richest one percent of families were ten times as likely to become inventors as those from families below the median income. Even children who topped their maths class in primary school were far more likely to invent if their families were well off. The researchers put much of the gap down to exposure: the mentors, information and networks a child grows up around.

Then there is the lottery of where you are born. If you are Bangladeshi and want to work abroad, you need money, a strong profile, and an employer willing to sponsor your visa. A French or German graduate can take a job anywhere in the European Union without a visa or a sponsor. Professor Branko Milanovic, a former World Bank economist, calls the advantage of being born in a richer country the "citizenship premium", and his research suggests more than half of the income differences between people worldwide come down to the country they live in. Staying home does not remove the odds either, as Bangladesh had around 885,000 unemployed university graduates in 2024, according to the Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics (BBS), so every opening draws a crowd.

Timing plays its part too. A role goes up at 11 PM, and whether you apply depends on whether you happened to be looking. Then there is knowing someone who knows someone. A contact builds rapport before you have even applied, so your application gets a second look instead of sinking into the pile. Experiments on 20 million LinkedIn users found that acquaintances, people you share a few mutual connections with but rarely speak to, did more to move people into new jobs than close friends did.

I count myself among the lucky ones, although it did not feel that way at the time. After my engineering degree in the UK, I went back home to figure things out, which felt like stepping off the expected route into a UK job. That detour turned out to be where the luck kicked in. I worked my way through networks, landed internships in banking and finance, and went into each one with an open mind. Those internships pushed me towards an MSc in Management, and the master's led to a full-time role. It worked like a butterfly effect. If any one of those links had been missing, or if I had started applying for full-time jobs straight after my engineering degree, I doubt I would have found one. None of it would have happened without a family that could send me abroad to study, which is luck I did nothing to earn.

You cannot choose where you were born or when a role goes live. What you can work on is noticing the chance when it appears. Professor Richard Wiseman, a psychologist who spent years studying self-described lucky and unlucky people, once asked volunteers to count the photographs in a newspaper. Half of the second page was a message saying there were 43 photographs and they could stop counting. The unlucky group took about two minutes. The lucky group took seconds because they saw the message. Wiseman found that lucky people tended to be more relaxed and aware of their environment, so they spotted chances that others walked straight past. That part is within your control. Say yes to things before you feel ready. Go to the event, reply to the message, take the internship that does not fit the plan, and weigh what saying no would cost you. Do not let a run of rejections talk you into staying in. Things rarely work out the way you imagined, but it only takes one good opportunity going your way, and you never know when it will turn up. Mine came out of a year I spent convinced I had fallen behind.

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Sharar Chowdhury is learning how to be a manager and believes "I'm confused" is not a complete sentence. Send him emails at: sharar672@gmail.com